



EUROPEAN RESEARCH EXECUTIVE AGENCY (REA)

REA.C – Future Society
C.4 – Reforming European R&I and Research Infrastructures

GRANT AGREEMENT

Project 101292277 — SoBigData IP

PREAMBLE

This **Agreement** ('the Agreement') is **between** the following parties:

on the one part,

the **European Research Executive Agency (REA)** ('EU executive agency' or 'granting authority'),
under the powers delegated by the European Commission ('European Commission'),

and

on the other part,

1. 'the coordinator':

CONSIGLIO NAZIONALE DELLE RICERCHE (CNR), PIC 999979500, established in
PIAZZALE ALDO MORO 7, ROMA 00185, Italy,

and the following other beneficiaries, if they sign their 'accession form' (see Annex 3 and Article 40):

2. **UNIVERSITA DI PISA (UNIP)**, PIC 999862712, established in LUNGARNO PACINOTTI
43/44, PISA 56126, Italy,

3. **SCUOLA NORMALE SUPERIORE (SNS)**, PIC 999886962, established in PIAZZA DEI
CAVALIERI 7, PISA 56126, Italy,

4. **SCUOLA IMT (ISTITUZIONI, MERCATI, TECNOLOGIE) ALTI STUDI DI LUCCA
(IMT)**, PIC 965146412, established in PIAZZA SAN PONZIANO 6, LUCCA 55100, Italy,

5. **UNIVERSITA DEGLI STUDI DELL'AQUILA (UNIVAQ)**, PIC 999859511, established in
PIAZZA SANTA MARGHERITA 2, L AQUILA 67100, Italy,

6. **UNIVERSITA DEGLI STUDI DI ROMA LA SAPIENZA (UNIROMA1)**, PIC 999987745,
established in Piazzale Aldo Moro 5, ROMA 00185, Italy,

7. **SCUOLA SUPERIORE DI STUDI UNIVERSITARI E DI PERFEZIONAMENTO S ANNA
(SSSA)**, PIC 999884731, established in PIAZZA MARTIRI DELLA LIBERTA 33, PISA 56127, Italy,

8. **ALMA MATER STUDIORUM - UNIVERSITA DI BOLOGNA (UNIBO)**, PIC 999993953,
established in VIA ZAMBONI 33, BOLOGNA 40126, Italy,

9. **UNIVERSITA DEGLI STUDI DI PALERMO (UNIPA)**, PIC 999734284, established in PIAZZA MARINA 61, PALERMO 90133, Italy,
10. **GOTTFRIED WILHELM LEIBNIZ UNIVERSITAET HANNOVER (LUH)**, PIC 999981828, established in WELFENGARTEN 1, HANNOVER 30167, Germany,
11. **ATHINA-EREVNITIKO KENTRO KAINOTOMIAS STIS TECHNOLOGIES TIS PLIROFORIAS, TON EPIKOINONION KAI TIS GNOSIS (ATHENA)**, PIC 999562788, established in ARTEMIDOS 6 KAI EPIDAVROU, MAROUSSI 151 25, Greece,
12. **OPENAIRE AMKE (OpenAIRE)**, PIC 903914192, established in 6 ARTEMIDOS STR & EPIDAVROU, MAROUSI 151 25, Greece,
13. **UNIVERSITEIT VAN AMSTERDAM (UvA)**, PIC 999985708, established in SPUI 21, AMSTERDAM 1012WX, Netherlands,
14. **TECHNISCHE UNIVERSITEIT DELFT (TUDelft)**, PIC 999977366, established in STEVINWEG 1, DELFT 2628 CN, Netherlands,
15. **STICHTING EGI (EGI)**, PIC 989221715, established in SCIENCE PARK 140, AMSTERDAM 1098 XG, Netherlands,
16. **BARCELONA SUPERCOMPUTING CENTER CENTRO NACIONAL DE SUPERCOMPUTACION (BSC)**, PIC 999655520, established in CALLE JORDI GIRONA 31, BARCELONA 08034, Spain,
17. **UNIVERSITAT ROVIRA I VIRGILI (URV)**, PIC 999880560, established in CARRER DE ESCORXADOR, TARRAGONA 43003, Spain,
18. **UNIVERSIDAD POMPEU FABRA (UPF)**, PIC 999867077, established in PLACA DE LA MERCE, 10-12, BARCELONA 08002, Spain,
19. **UNIVERSIDAD COMPLUTENSE DE MADRID (UCM)**, PIC 999874546, established in AVENIDA DE SENECA 2, MADRID 28040, Spain,
20. **KING'S COLLEGE LONDON (KCL)**, PIC 999981052, established in STRAND, LONDON WC2R 2LS, United Kingdom,
21. **UNIVERSITY OF BRISTOL (REPHRAIN)**, PIC 999974262, established in BEACON HOUSE QUEENS ROAD, BRISTOL BS8 1QU, United Kingdom,
22. **CENTER FOR THE STUDY OF DEMOCRACY (CSD)**, PIC 999548529, established in ALEXANDER ZHENDOV STREET 5, SOFIA 1113, Bulgaria,
23. **SMARTEX SRL SOCIETA DI PRODOTTI E SERVIZI GIURIDICI INTERDISCIPLINARI (SLEX)**, PIC 925521039, established in VIA LENIN 132G, SAN GIULIANO TERME 56017, Italy,
24. **TUSCAN ORGANISATION OF UNIVERSITIESAND RESEARCH 4 EUROPE (TOUR4EU)**, PIC 903152742, established in ROND POINT ROBERT SCHUMAN 14, BRUXELLES 1040, Belgium,

25. **X-officio Research AB (X-officio)**, PIC 876844887, established in Klostergatan 8b, Lund 222 22, Sweden,

26. **DEUTSCHES FORSCHUNGSZENTRUM FÜR KUNSTLICHE INTELLIGENZ GMBH (DFKI)**, PIC 999607602, established in TRIPPSTADTER STRASSE 122, KAISERSLAUTERN 67663, Germany,

Unless otherwise specified, references to ‘beneficiary’ or ‘beneficiaries’ include the coordinator and affiliated entities (if any).

If only one beneficiary signs the grant agreement (‘mono-beneficiary grant’), all provisions referring to the ‘coordinator’ or the ‘beneficiaries’ will be considered — mutatis mutandis — as referring to the beneficiary.

The parties referred to above have agreed to enter into the Agreement.

By signing the Agreement and the accession forms, the beneficiaries accept the grant and agree to implement the action under their own responsibility and in accordance with the Agreement, with all the obligations and terms and conditions it sets out.

The Agreement is composed of:

Preamble

Terms and Conditions (including Data Sheet)

Annex 1 Description of the action¹

Annex 2 Estimated budget for the action

Annex 3 Accession forms (if applicable)²

Annex 3a Declaration on joint and several liability of affiliated entities (if applicable)³

Annex 4 Model for the financial statements

Annex 5 Specific rules (if applicable)

¹ Template published on [Portal Reference Documents](#).

² Template published on [Portal Reference Documents](#).

³ Template published on [Portal Reference Documents](#).

TERMS AND CONDITIONS

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DATA SHEET

1. General data

Project summary:

Project summary
SoBigData is a pan-European RI dedicated to social mining and big data analytics. The RI serves as a dynamic nexus for innovative research, offering a fully open and collaborative environment where experts from computer science, social sciences, humanities, and related fields can leverage cutting-edge tools and advanced methodologies. Building on the solid technological foundations validated during the preparatory phase, the infrastructure is now moving toward a sustainable future, focusing on broader accessibility and an improved user experience. The Implementation Phase of the SoBigData RI focuses on putting into action the plans developed during its preparatory stage. During this phase, technological components, tools, and services, are refined and integrated for the public use. It also involves the support to establishing the ERIC and make it operational. More specifically, SoBigData IP has a central objective to integrate new services and enhance the way users interact with the RI, making services and facilities easier to navigate and use, while fostering active engagement across diverse communities, including researchers, industry, policymakers, and citizens. By consolidating access policies and expanding participation opportunities, SoBigData IP aims to create a more inclusive and impactful ecosystem. At the same time, the SoBigData IP is strengthening the RI pan-European relevance by aligning closely with EOSC and European Data Spaces, promoting interoperability, and supporting cross-border collaboration. This integration reinforces Europe's research capacity and enables evidence-based policymaking. Finally, the pathway to establishing SoBigData as an ERIC is underway. Guided by the SoBigData IP, the RI is consolidating its governance, legal, and financial frameworks to ensure long-term sustainability. This transition will secure SoBigData's position as a stable, trusted, and high-impact research infrastructure within the European landscape.

Keywords:

- Social and behavioural science
- Artificial intelligence
- Cloud computing
- Data Repositories, Management, Access
- Open Science and FAIR Data (EOSC)
- SoBigData++
- Social Mining, Artificial Intelligence, Computational network

Project number: 101292277

Project name: SoBigData Implementation Phase

Project acronym: SoBigData IP

Call: HORIZON-INFRA-2025-01

Topic: HORIZON-INFRA-2025-01-DEV-02

Type of action: HORIZON Coordination and Support Actions

Granting authority: European Research Executive Agency

Grant managed through EU Funding & Tenders Portal: Yes (eGrants)

Project starting date: fixed date: 1 June 2026

Project end date: 31 May 2029

Project duration: 36 months

Consortium agreement: Yes

2. Participants

List of participants:

N°	Role	Short name	Legal name	Ctry	PIC	Max grant amount
1	COO	CNR	CONSIGLIO NAZIONALE DELLE RICERCHE	IT	999979500	357 954.80
2	BEN	UNIP1	UNIVERSITA DI PISA	IT	999862712	35 999.00
3	BEN	SNS	SCUOLA NORMALE SUPERIORE	IT	999886962	11 281.27
4	BEN	IMT	SCUOLA IMT (ISTITUZIONI, MERCATI, TECNOLOGIE) ALTI STUDI DI LUCCA	IT	965146412	12 125.00
5	BEN	UNIVAQ	UNIVERSITA DEGLI STUDI DELL'AQUILA	IT	999859511	44 317.80
6	BEN	UNIROMA1	UNIVERSITA DEGLI STUDI DI ROMA LA SAPIENZA	IT	999987745	25 605.00
7	BEN	SSSA	SCUOLA SUPERIORE DI STUDI UNIVERSITARI E DI PERFEZIONAMENTO S ANNA	IT	999884731	54 981.25
8	BEN	UNIBO	ALMA MATER STUDIORUM - UNIVERSITA DI BOLOGNA	IT	999993953	11 125.00
9	BEN	UNIPA	UNIVERSITA DEGLI STUDI DI PALERMO	IT	999734284	11 165.30
10	BEN	LUH	GOTTFRIED WILHELM LEIBNIZ UNIVERSITAET HANNOVER	DE	999981828	40 137.50
11	BEN	ATHENA	ATHINA-EREVNITIKO KENTRO KAINOTOMIAS STIS TECHNOLOGIES TIS PLIROFORIAS, TON EPIKOINONION KAI TIS GNOSIS	EL	999562788	40 047.76
12	BEN	OpenAIRE	OPENAIRE AMKE	EL	903914192	18 482.50
13	BEN	UvA	UNIVERSITEIT VAN AMSTERDAM	NL	999985708	47 273.00
14	BEN	TU Delft	TECHNISCHE UNIVERSITEIT DELFT	NL	999977366	40 328.55
15	BEN	EGI	STICHTING EGI	NL	989221715	33 702.50
16	BEN	BSC	BARCELONA SUPERCOMPUTING CENTER CENTRO NACIONAL DE SUPERCOMPUTACION	ES	999655520	77 749.50
17	BEN	URV	UNIVERSITAT ROVIRA I VIRGILI	ES	999880560	10 857.50
18	BEN	UPF	UNIVERSIDAD POMPEU FABRA	ES	999867077	10 803.10
19	BEN	UCM	UNIVERSIDAD COMPLUTENSE DE MADRID	ES	999874546	45 790.90
20	BEN	KCL	KING'S COLLEGE LONDON	UK	999981052	67 523.30
21	BEN	REPHRAIN	UNIVERSITY OF BRISTOL	UK	999974262	23 579.27
22	BEN	CSD	CENTER FOR THE STUDY OF DEMOCRACY	BG	999548529	9 803.00
23	BEN	SLEX	SMARTEX SRL SOCIETA DI PRODOTTI E SERVIZI GIURIDICI INTERDISCIPLINARI	IT	925521039	119 812.50
24	BEN	TOUR4EU	TUSCAN ORGANISATION OF UNIVERSITIES AND RESEARCH 4 EUROPE	BE	903152742	75 000.00
25	BEN	X-officio	X-officio Research AB	SE	876844887	97 873.13
26	BEN	DFKI	DEUTSCHES FORSCHUNGSZENTRUM FUR KUNSTLICHE INTELLIGENZ GMBH	DE	999607602	40 305.75
Total						1 363 624.18

Coordinator:

— CONSIGLIO NAZIONALE DELLE RICERCHE (CNR)

3. Grant**Maximum grant amount, total estimated eligible costs and contributions and funding rate:**

Maximum grant amount (Annex 2)	Maximum grant amount (award decision)
1 363 624.18	1 363 624.18

Grant form: Lump Sum**Grant mode:** Action grant

Budget categories/activity types: Lump sum contributions

Cost eligibility options: n/a

Budget flexibility: No

4. Reporting, payments and recoveries

4.1 Continuous reporting (art 21)

Deliverables: see Funding & Tenders Portal Continuous Reporting tool

4.2 Periodic reporting and payments

Reporting and payment schedule (art 21, 22):

Reporting					Payments	
Reporting periods			Type	Deadline	Type	Deadline (time to pay)
RP No	Month from	Month to				
					Initial prefinancing	30 days from entry into force/10 days before starting date – whichever is the latest
					Interim payment	90 days from receiving periodic report
					Final payment	90 days from receiving periodic report
1	1	18	Periodic report	60 days after end of reporting period		
2	19	36	Periodic report	60 days after end of reporting period		

Prefinancing payments and guarantees:

Prefinancing payment	
Type	Amount
Prefinancing 1 (initial)	1 090 899.34

Reporting and payment modalities (art 21, 22):

Mutual Insurance Mechanism (MIM): Yes

MIM contribution: 5% of the maximum grant amount (68 181.21), retained from the initial prefinancing

Restrictions on distribution of initial prefinancing: The prefinancing may be distributed only if the minimum number of beneficiaries set out in the call conditions (if any) have acceded to the Agreement and only to beneficiaries that have acceded.

Interim payment ceiling (if any): 90% of the maximum grant amount

No-profit rule: n/a

Late payment interest: ECB + 3.5%

Bank account for payments:

IT75N0100503392000000218150 BNLIITR1BLZ

Conversion into euros: n/a

Reporting language: Language of the Agreement

4.3 Certificates (art 24): n/a

4.4 Recoveries (art 22)

First-line liability for recoveries:

Beneficiary termination: Beneficiary concerned

Final payment: Each beneficiary for their own debt

After final payment: Beneficiary concerned

Joint and several liability for enforced recoveries (in case of non-payment):

Individual financial responsibility: Each beneficiary is liable only for its own debts (and those of its affiliated entities, if any)

Joint and several liability of affiliated entities — n/a

5. Consequences of non-compliance, applicable law & dispute settlement forum

Suspension and termination:

Additional suspension grounds (art 31)

Additional termination grounds (art 32)

Applicable law (art 43):

Standard applicable law regime: EU law + law of Belgium

Dispute settlement forum (art 43):

Standard dispute settlement forum:

EU beneficiaries: EU General Court + EU Court of Justice (on appeal)

Non-EU beneficiaries: Courts of Brussels, Belgium (unless an international agreement provides for the enforceability of EU court judgements)

6. Other

Specific rules (Annex 5): Yes

Standard time-limits after project end:

Confidentiality (for X years after final payment): 5

Record-keeping (for X years after final payment): 5 (or 3 for grants of not more than EUR 60 000)

Reviews (up to X years after final payment): 2

Audits (up to X years after final payment): 2

Extension of findings from other grants to this grant (no later than X years after final payment): 2

Impact evaluation (up to X years after final payment): 5 (or 3 for grants of not more than EUR 60 000)

CHAPTER 1 GENERAL

ARTICLE 1 — SUBJECT OF THE AGREEMENT

This Agreement sets out the rights and obligations and terms and conditions applicable to the grant awarded for the implementation of the action set out in Chapter 2.

ARTICLE 2 — DEFINITIONS

For the purpose of this Agreement, the following definitions apply:

Actions — The project which is being funded in the context of this Agreement.

Grant — The grant awarded in the context of this Agreement.

EU grants — Grants awarded by EU institutions, bodies, offices or agencies (including EU executive agencies, EU regulatory agencies, EDA, joint undertakings, etc.).

Participants — Entities participating in the action as beneficiaries, affiliated entities, associated partners, third parties giving in-kind contributions, subcontractors or recipients of financial support to third parties.

Beneficiaries (BEN) — The signatories of this Agreement (either directly or through an accession form).

Affiliated entities (AE) — Entities affiliated to a beneficiary within the meaning of Article 190 of EU Financial Regulation 2024/2509⁴ which participate in the action with similar rights and obligations as the beneficiaries (obligation to implement action tasks and right to charge costs and claim contributions).

Associated partners (AP) — Entities which participate in the action, but without the right to charge costs or claim contributions.

Purchases — Contracts for goods, works or services needed to carry out the action (e.g. equipment, consumables and supplies) but which are not part of the action tasks (see Annex 1).

Subcontracting — Contracts for goods, works or services that are part of the action tasks (see Annex 1).

In-kind contributions — In-kind contributions within the meaning of Article 2(38) of EU Financial Regulation 2024/2509, i.e. non-financial resources made available free of charge by third parties.

⁴ For the definition, see Article 190 Regulation (EU, Euratom) 2024/2509 of the European Parliament and of the Council of 23 September 2024 on the financial rules applicable to the general budget of the Union (recast) ('EU Financial Regulation') (OJ L, 2024/2509, 26.9.2024): "**affiliated entities** [are]:

- (a) entities that form a sole beneficiary [(i.e. where an entity is formed of several entities that satisfy the criteria for being awarded a grant, including where the entity is specifically established for the purpose of implementing an action to be financed by a grant)];
- (b) entities that satisfy the eligibility criteria and that do not fall within one of the situations referred to in Article 138(1) and 143(1) and that have a link with the beneficiary, in particular a legal or capital link, which is neither limited to the action nor established for the sole purpose of its implementation".

Fraud — Fraud within the meaning of Article 3 of EU Directive 2017/1371⁵ and Article 1 of the Convention on the protection of the European Communities' financial interests, drawn up by the Council Act of 26 July 1995⁶, as well as any other wrongful or criminal deception intended to result in financial or personal gain.

Irregularities — Any type of breach (regulatory or contractual) which could impact the EU financial interests, including irregularities within the meaning of Article 1(2) of EU Regulation 2988/95⁷.

Grave professional misconduct — Any type of unacceptable or improper behaviour in exercising one's profession, especially by employees, including grave professional misconduct within the meaning of Article 138(1)(c) of EU Financial Regulation 2024/2509⁸.

Applicable EU, international and national law — Any legal acts or other (binding or non-binding) rules and guidance in the area concerned.

Portal — EU Funding & Tenders Portal; electronic portal and exchange system managed by the European Commission and used by itself and other EU institutions, bodies, offices or agencies for the management of their funding programmes (grants, procurements, prizes, etc.).

CHAPTER 2 ACTION

ARTICLE 3 — ACTION

The grant is awarded for the action **101292277 — SoBigData IP** ('action'), as described in Annex 1.

ARTICLE 4 — DURATION AND STARTING DATE

The duration and the starting date of the action are set out in the Data Sheet (see Point 1).

CHAPTER 3 GRANT

ARTICLE 5 — GRANT

5.1 Form of grant

⁵ Directive (EU) 2017/1371 of the European Parliament and of the Council of 5 July 2017 on the fight against fraud to the Union's financial interests by means of criminal law (OJ L 198, 28.7.2017, p. 29).

⁶ OJ C 316, 27.11.1995, p. 48.

⁷ Council Regulation (EC, Euratom) No 2988/95 of 18 December 1995 on the protection of the European Communities financial interests (OJ L 312, 23.12.1995, p. 1).

⁸ 'Professional misconduct' includes, in particular, the following: violation of ethical standards of the profession; wrongful conduct with impact on professional credibility; breach of generally accepted professional ethical standards; false declarations/misrepresentation of information; participation in a cartel or other agreement distorting competition; violation of IPR; attempting to influence decision-making processes by taking advantage, through misrepresentation, of a conflict of interests, or to obtain confidential information from public authorities to gain an advantage; incitement to discrimination, hatred or violence or similar activities contrary to the EU values where negatively affecting or risking to affect the performance of a legal commitment.

The grant is an action grant⁹ which takes the form of a lump sum grant for the completion of work packages.

5.2 Maximum grant amount

The maximum grant amount is set out in the Data Sheet (see Point 3) and in the estimated budget (Annex 2).

5.3 Funding rate

Not applicable

5.4 Estimated budget, budget categories and forms of funding

The estimated budget for the action (lump sum breakdown) is set out in Annex 2.

It contains the estimated eligible contributions for the action (lump sum contributions), broken down by participant and work package.

Annex 2 also shows the types of contributions (forms of funding)¹⁰ to be used for each work package.

5.5 Budget flexibility

Budget flexibility does not apply; changes to the estimated budget (lump sum breakdown) always require an amendment (see Article 39).

Amendments for transfers between *work packages* are moreover possible only if:

- the work packages concerned are not already completed (and declared in a financial statement) and
- the transfers are justified by the technical implementation of the action.

ARTICLE 6 — ELIGIBLE AND INELIGIBLE CONTRIBUTIONS

6.1 and 6.2 General and specific eligibility conditions

Lump sum contributions are eligible ('eligible contributions'), if:

- (a) they are set out in Annex 2 and
- (b) the work packages are completed and the work is properly implemented by the beneficiaries and/or the results are achieved, in accordance with Annex 1 and during in the period set out in Article 4 (with the exception of work/results relating to the submission of the final periodic report, which may be achieved afterwards; see Article 21)

They will be calculated on the basis of the amounts set out in Annex 2.

⁹ For the definition, see Article 183(2)(a) EU Financial Regulation 2024/2509: '**action grant**' means an EU grant to finance "an action intended to help achieve a Union policy objective".

¹⁰ See Article 125 EU Financial Regulation 2024/2509.

6.3 Ineligible contributions

‘Ineligible contributions’ are:

- (a) lump sum contributions that do not comply with the conditions set out above (see Article 6.1 and 6.2)
- (b) lump sum contributions for activities already funded under other EU grants (or grants awarded by an EU Member State, non-EU country or other body implementing the EU budget), except for the following case:
 - (i) Synergy actions: not applicable
- (c) other:
 - (i) country restrictions for eligible costs: not applicable.

6.4 Consequences of non-compliance

If a beneficiary declares lump sum contributions that are ineligible, they will be rejected (see Article 27).

This may also lead to other measures described in Chapter 5.

CHAPTER 4 GRANT IMPLEMENTATION

SECTION 1 CONSORTIUM: BENEFICIARIES, AFFILIATED ENTITIES AND OTHER PARTICIPANTS

ARTICLE 7 — BENEFICIARIES

The beneficiaries, as signatories of the Agreement, are fully responsible towards the granting authority for implementing it and for complying with all its obligations.

They must implement the Agreement to their best abilities, in good faith and in accordance with all the obligations and terms and conditions it sets out.

They must have the appropriate resources to implement the action and implement the action under their own responsibility and in accordance with Article 11. If they rely on affiliated entities or other participants (see Articles 8 and 9), they retain sole responsibility towards the granting authority and the other beneficiaries.

They are jointly responsible for the *technical* implementation of the action. If one of the beneficiaries fails to implement their part of the action, the other beneficiaries must ensure that this part is implemented by someone else (without being entitled to an increase of the maximum grant amount and subject to an amendment; see Article 39). The *financial* responsibility of each beneficiary in case of recoveries is governed by Article 22.

The beneficiaries (and their action) must remain eligible under the EU programme funding the grant

for the entire duration of the action. Lump sum contributions will be eligible only as long as the beneficiary and the action are eligible.

The **internal roles and responsibilities** of the beneficiaries are divided as follows:

(a) Each beneficiary must:

- (i) keep information stored in the Portal Participant Register up to date (see Article 19)
- (ii) inform the granting authority (and the other beneficiaries) immediately of any events or circumstances likely to affect significantly or delay the implementation of the action (see Article 19)
- (iii) submit to the coordinator in good time:
 - the prefinancing guarantees (if required; see Article 23)
 - the financial statements and certificates on the financial statements (CFS): not applicable
 - the contribution to the deliverables and technical reports (see Article 21)
 - any other documents or information required by the granting authority under the Agreement
- (iv) submit via the Portal data and information related to the participation of their affiliated entities.

(b) The coordinator must:

- (i) monitor that the action is implemented properly (see Article 11)
- (ii) act as the intermediary for all communications between the consortium and the granting authority, unless the Agreement or granting authority specifies otherwise, and in particular:
 - submit the prefinancing guarantees to the granting authority (if any)
 - request and review any documents or information required and verify their quality and completeness before passing them on to the granting authority
 - submit the deliverables and reports to the granting authority
 - inform the granting authority about the payments made to the other beneficiaries (report on the distribution of payments; if required, see Articles 22 and 32)
- (iii) distribute the payments received from the granting authority to the other beneficiaries without unjustified delay (see Article 22).

The coordinator may not delegate or subcontract the above-mentioned tasks to any other beneficiary or third party (including affiliated entities).

However, coordinators which are public bodies may delegate the tasks set out in Point (b)(ii) last

indent and (iii) above to entities with ‘authorisation to administer’ which they have created or which are controlled by or affiliated to them. In this case, the coordinator retains sole responsibility for the payments and for compliance with the obligations under the Agreement.

Moreover, coordinators which are ‘sole beneficiaries’¹¹ (or similar, such as European research infrastructure consortia (ERICs)) may delegate the tasks set out in Point (b)(i) to (iii) above to one of their members. The coordinator retains sole responsibility for compliance with the obligations under the Agreement.

The beneficiaries must have **internal arrangements** regarding their operation and co-ordination, to ensure that the action is implemented properly.

If required by the granting authority (see Data Sheet, Point 1), these arrangements must be set out in a written **consortium agreement** between the beneficiaries, covering for instance:

- the internal organisation of the consortium
- the management of access to the Portal
- different distribution keys for the payments and financial responsibilities in case of recoveries (if any)
- additional rules on rights and obligations related to background and results (see Article 16)
- settlement of internal disputes
- liability, indemnification and confidentiality arrangements between the beneficiaries.

The internal arrangements must not contain any provision contrary to this Agreement.

ARTICLE 8 — AFFILIATED ENTITIES

Not applicable

ARTICLE 9 — OTHER PARTICIPANTS INVOLVED IN THE ACTION

9.1 Associated partners

Not applicable

9.2 Third parties giving in-kind contributions to the action

Other third parties may give in-kind contributions to the action (i.e. personnel, equipment, other goods, works and services, etc. which are free-of-charge) if necessary for the implementation.

Third parties giving in-kind contributions do not implement any action tasks. They may not charge contributions to the action (no lump sum contributions) and their costs are considered entirely covered by the lump sum contributions paid to the beneficiaries.

¹¹ For the definition, see Article 190(2) EU Financial Regulation 2024/2509: “Where several entities satisfy the criteria for being awarded a grant and together form one entity, that entity may be treated as the **sole beneficiary**, including where it is specifically established for the purpose of implementing the action financed by the grant.”

The third parties and their in-kind contributions should be set out in Annex 1.

9.3 Subcontractors

Subcontractors may participate in the action, if necessary for the implementation.

Subcontractors must implement their action tasks in accordance with Article 11. The beneficiaries' costs for subcontracting are considered entirely covered by the lump sum contributions for implementing the work packages (irrespective of the actual subcontracting costs incurred, if any).

The beneficiaries must ensure that their contractual obligations under Articles 11 (proper implementation), 12 (conflict of interest), 13 (confidentiality and security), 14 (ethics), 17.2 (visibility), 18 (specific rules for carrying out action), 19 (information) and 20 (record-keeping) also apply to the subcontractors.

The beneficiaries must ensure that the bodies mentioned in Article 25 (e.g. granting authority, OLAF, Court of Auditors (ECA), etc.) can exercise their rights also towards the subcontractors.

9.4 Recipients of financial support to third parties

If the action includes providing financial support to third parties (e.g. grants, prizes or similar forms of support), the beneficiaries must ensure that their contractual obligations under Articles 12 (conflict of interest), 13 (confidentiality and security), 14 (ethics), 17.2 (visibility), 18 (specific rules for carrying out action), 19 (information) and 20 (record-keeping) also apply to the third parties receiving the support (recipients).

The beneficiaries must also ensure that the bodies mentioned in Article 25 (e.g. granting authority, OLAF, Court of Auditors (ECA), etc.) can exercise their rights also towards the recipients.

ARTICLE 10 — PARTICIPANTS WITH SPECIAL STATUS

10.1 Non-EU participants

Participants which are established in a non-EU country (if any) undertake to comply with their obligations under the Agreement and:

- to respect general principles (including fundamental rights, values and ethical principles, environmental and labour standards, rules on classified information, intellectual property rights, visibility of funding and protection of personal data)
- for the submission of certificates under Article 24: use qualified external auditors which are independent and comply with comparable standards as those set out in EU Directive 2006/43/EC¹²
- for the controls under Article 25: allow for checks, reviews, audits and investigations (including on-the-spot checks, visits and inspections) by the bodies mentioned in that Article (e.g. granting authority, OLAF, Court of Auditors (ECA), etc.).

¹² Directive 2006/43/EC of the European Parliament and of the Council of 17 May 2006 on statutory audits of annual accounts and consolidated accounts (OJ L 157, 9.6.2006, p. 87).

Special rules on dispute settlement apply (see Data Sheet, Point 5).

10.2 Participants which are international organisations

Participants which are international organisations (IOs; if any) undertake to comply with their obligations under the Agreement and:

- to respect general principles (including fundamental rights, values and ethical principles, environmental and labour standards, rules on classified information, intellectual property rights, visibility of funding and protection of personal data)
- for the submission of certificates under Article 24: to use either independent public officers or external auditors which comply with comparable standards as those set out in EU Directive 2006/43/EC¹³
- for the controls under Article 25: to allow for the checks, reviews, audits and investigations by the bodies mentioned in that Article, taking into account the specific agreements concluded by them and the EU (if any).

For such participants, nothing in the Agreement will be interpreted as a waiver of their privileges or immunities, as accorded by their constituent documents or international law.

Special rules on applicable law and dispute settlement apply (see Article 43 and Data Sheet, Point 5).

10.3 Pillar-assessed participants

Pillar-assessed participants (if any) may rely on their own systems, rules and procedures, in so far as they have been positively assessed and do not call into question the decision awarding the grant or breach the principle of equal treatment of applicants or beneficiaries.

‘Pillar-assessment’ means a review by the European Commission on the systems, rules and procedures which participants use for managing EU grants (in particular internal control system, accounting system, external audits, financing of third parties, rules on recovery and exclusion, information on recipients and protection of personal data; see Article 157 EU Financial Regulation 2024/2509).

Participants with a positive pillar assessment may rely on their own systems, rules and procedures, in particular for:

- record-keeping (Article 20): may be done in accordance with internal standards, rules and procedures
- currency conversion for financial statements (Article 21): may be done in accordance with usual accounting practices
- guarantees (Article 23): for public law bodies, prefinancing guarantees are not needed
- certificates (Article 24):
 - certificates on the financial statements (CFS): may be provided by their regular internal

¹³ Directive 2006/43/EC of the European Parliament and of the Council of 17 May 2006 on statutory audits of annual accounts and consolidated accounts (OJ L 157, 9.6.2006, p. 87).

or external auditors and in accordance with their internal financial regulations and procedures

- certificates on usual accounting practices (CoMUC): are not needed if those practices are covered by an ex-ante assessment

and use the following specific rules, for:

- recoveries (Article 22): in case of financial support to third parties, there will be no recovery if the participant has done everything possible to retrieve the undue amounts from the third party receiving the support (including legal proceedings) and non-recovery is not due to an error or negligence on its part
- checks, reviews, audits and investigations by the EU (Article 25): will be conducted taking into account the rules and procedures specifically agreed between them and the framework agreement (if any)
- impact evaluation (Article 26): will be conducted in accordance with the participant's internal rules and procedures and the framework agreement (if any)
- grant agreement termination (Article 32): the final grant amount and final payment will be calculated taking into account also costs relating to contracts due for execution only after termination takes effect, if the contract was entered into before the pre-information letter was received and could not reasonably be terminated on legal grounds
- liability for damages (Article 33.2): the granting authority must be compensated for damage it sustains as a result of the implementation of the action or because the action was not implemented in full compliance with the Agreement only if the damage is due to an infringement of the participant's internal rules and procedures or due to a violation of third parties' rights by the participant or one of its employees or individual for whom the employees are responsible.

Participants whose pillar assessment covers procurement and granting procedures may also do purchases, subcontracting and financial support to third parties (Article 6.2) in accordance with their internal rules and procedures for purchases, subcontracting and financial support.

Participants whose pillar assessment covers data protection rules may rely on their internal standards, rules and procedures for data protection (Article 15).

The participants may however not rely on provisions which would breach the principle of equal treatment of applicants or beneficiaries or call into question the decision awarding the grant, such as in particular:

- eligibility (Article 6)
- consortium roles and set-up (Articles 7-9)
- security and ethics (Articles 13, 14)
- IPR (including background and results, access rights and rights of use), communication, dissemination and visibility (Articles 16 and 17)

- information obligation (Article 19)
- payment, reporting and amendments (Articles 21, 22 and 39)
- rejections, reductions, suspensions and terminations (Articles 27, 28, 29-32)

If the pillar assessment was subject to remedial measures, reliance on the internal systems, rules and procedures is subject to compliance with those remedial measures.

Participants must inform the coordinator without delay of any changes to the systems, rules and procedures that were part of the pillar assessment. The coordinator must immediately inform the granting authority.

Pillar-assessed participants that have also concluded a framework agreement with the EU, may moreover — under the same conditions as those above (i.e. not call into question the decision awarding the grant or breach the principle of equal treatment of applicants or beneficiaries) — rely on provisions set out in that framework agreement.

SECTION 2 RULES FOR CARRYING OUT THE ACTION

ARTICLE 11 — PROPER IMPLEMENTATION OF THE ACTION

11.1 Obligation to properly implement the action

The beneficiaries must implement the action as described in Annex 1 and in compliance with the provisions of the Agreement, the call conditions and all legal obligations under applicable EU, international and national law.

11.2 Consequences of non-compliance

If a beneficiary breaches any of its obligations under this Article, the grant may be reduced (see Article 28).

Such breaches may also lead to other measures described in Chapter 5.

ARTICLE 12 — CONFLICT OF INTERESTS

12.1 Conflict of interests

The beneficiaries must take all measures to prevent any situation where the impartial and objective implementation of the Agreement could be compromised for reasons involving family, emotional life, political or national affinity, economic interest or any other direct or indirect interest ('conflict of interests').

They must formally notify the granting authority without delay of any situation constituting or likely to lead to a conflict of interests and immediately take all the necessary steps to rectify this situation.

The granting authority may verify that the measures taken are appropriate and may require additional measures to be taken by a specified deadline.

12.2 Consequences of non-compliance

If a beneficiary breaches any of its obligations under this Article, the grant may be reduced (see Article 28) and the grant or the beneficiary may be terminated (see Article 32).

Such breaches may also lead to other measures described in Chapter 5.

ARTICLE 13 — CONFIDENTIALITY AND SECURITY

13.1 Sensitive information

The parties must keep confidential any data, documents or other material (in any form) that is identified as sensitive in writing ('sensitive information') — during the implementation of the action and for at least until the time-limit set out in the Data Sheet (see Point 6).

If a beneficiary requests, the granting authority may agree to keep such information confidential for a longer period.

Unless otherwise agreed between the parties, they may use sensitive information only to implement the Agreement.

The beneficiaries may disclose sensitive information to their personnel or other participants involved in the action only if they:

- (a) need to know it in order to implement the Agreement and
- (b) are bound by an obligation of confidentiality.

The granting authority may disclose sensitive information to its staff and to other EU institutions and bodies.

It may moreover disclose sensitive information to third parties, if:

- (a) this is necessary to implement the Agreement or safeguard the EU financial interests and
- (b) the recipients of the information are bound by an obligation of confidentiality.

The confidentiality obligations no longer apply if:

- (a) the disclosing party agrees to release the other party
- (b) the information becomes publicly available, without breaching any confidentiality obligation
- (c) the disclosure of the sensitive information is required by EU, international or national law.

Specific confidentiality rules (if any) are set out in Annex 5.

13.2 Classified information

The parties must handle classified information in accordance with the applicable EU, international or national law on classified information (in particular, Decision 2015/444¹⁴ and its implementing rules).

¹⁴ Commission Decision 2015/444/EC, Euratom of 13 March 2015 on the security rules for protecting EU classified information (OJ L 72, 17.3.2015, p. 53).

Deliverables which contain classified information must be submitted according to special procedures agreed with the granting authority.

Action tasks involving classified information may be subcontracted only after explicit approval (in writing) from the granting authority.

Classified information may not be disclosed to any third party (including participants involved in the action implementation) without prior explicit written approval from the granting authority.

Specific security rules (if any) are set out in Annex 5.

13.3 Consequences of non-compliance

If a beneficiary breaches any of its obligations under this Article, the grant may be reduced (see Article 28).

Such breaches may also lead to other measures described in Chapter 5.

ARTICLE 14 — ETHICS AND VALUES

14.1 Ethics

The action must be carried out in line with the highest ethical standards and the applicable EU, international and national law on ethical principles.

Specific ethics rules (if any) are set out in Annex 5.

14.2 Values

The beneficiaries must commit to and ensure the respect of basic EU values (such as respect for human dignity, freedom, democracy, equality, the rule of law and human rights, including the rights of minorities).

Specific rules on values (if any) are set out in Annex 5.

14.3 Consequences of non-compliance

If a beneficiary breaches any of its obligations under this Article, the grant may be reduced (see Article 28).

Such breaches may also lead to other measures described in Chapter 5.

ARTICLE 15 — DATA PROTECTION

15.1 Data processing by the granting authority

Any personal data under the Agreement will be processed under the responsibility of the data controller of the granting authority in accordance with and for the purposes set out in the Portal Privacy Statement.

For grants where the granting authority is the European Commission, an EU regulatory or executive agency, joint undertaking or other EU body, the processing will be subject to Regulation 2018/1725¹⁵.

15.2 Data processing by the beneficiaries

The beneficiaries must process personal data under the Agreement in compliance with the applicable EU, international and national law on data protection (in particular, Regulation 2016/679¹⁶).

They must ensure that personal data is:

- processed lawfully, fairly and in a transparent manner in relation to the data subjects
- collected for specified, explicit and legitimate purposes and not further processed in a manner that is incompatible with those purposes
- adequate, relevant and limited to what is necessary in relation to the purposes for which they are processed
- accurate and, where necessary, kept up to date
- kept in a form which permits identification of data subjects for no longer than is necessary for the purposes for which the data is processed and
- processed in a manner that ensures appropriate security of the data.

The beneficiaries may grant their personnel access to personal data only if it is strictly necessary for implementing, managing and monitoring the Agreement. The beneficiaries must ensure that the personnel is under a confidentiality obligation.

The beneficiaries must inform the persons whose data are transferred to the granting authority and provide them with the Portal Privacy Statement.

15.3 Consequences of non-compliance

If a beneficiary breaches any of its obligations under this Article, the grant may be reduced (see Article 28).

Such breaches may also lead to other measures described in Chapter 5.

ARTICLE 16 — INTELLECTUAL PROPERTY RIGHTS (IPR) — BACKGROUND AND RESULTS — ACCESS RIGHTS AND RIGHTS OF USE

16.1 Background and access rights to background

¹⁵ Regulation (EU) 2018/1725 of the European Parliament and of the Council of 23 October 2018 on the protection of natural persons with regard to the processing of personal data by the Union institutions, bodies, offices and agencies and on the free movement of such data, and repealing Regulation (EC) No 45/2001 and Decision No 1247/2002/EC (OJ L 295, 21.11.2018, p. 39).

¹⁶ Regulation (EU) 2016/679 of the European Parliament and of the Council of 27 April 2016 on the protection of natural persons with regard to the processing of personal data and on the free movement of such data, and repealing Directive 95/46/EC ('GDPR') (OJ L 119, 4.5.2016, p. 1).

The beneficiaries must give each other and the other participants access to the background identified as needed for implementing the action, subject to any specific rules in Annex 5.

‘Background’ means any data, know-how or information — whatever its form or nature (tangible or intangible), including any rights such as intellectual property rights — that is:

- (a) held by the beneficiaries before they acceded to the Agreement and
- (b) needed to implement the action or exploit the results.

If background is subject to rights of a third party, the beneficiary concerned must ensure that it is able to comply with its obligations under the Agreement.

16.2 Ownership of results

The granting authority does not obtain ownership of the results produced under the action.

‘Results’ means any tangible or intangible effect of the action, such as data, know-how or information, whatever its form or nature, whether or not it can be protected, as well as any rights attached to it, including intellectual property rights.

16.3 Rights of use of the granting authority on materials, documents and information received for policy, information, communication, dissemination and publicity purposes

The granting authority has the right to use non-sensitive information relating to the action and materials and documents received from the beneficiaries (notably summaries for publication, deliverables, as well as any other material, such as pictures or audio-visual material, in paper or electronic form) for policy information, communication, dissemination and publicity purposes — during the action or afterwards.

The right to use the beneficiaries’ materials, documents and information is granted in the form of a royalty-free, non-exclusive and irrevocable licence, which includes the following rights:

- (a) **use for its own purposes** (in particular, making them available to persons working for the granting authority or any other EU service (including institutions, bodies, offices, agencies, etc.) or EU Member State institution or body; copying or reproducing them in whole or in part, in unlimited numbers; and communication through press information services)
- (b) **distribution to the public** (in particular, publication as hard copies and in electronic or digital format, publication on the internet, as a downloadable or non-downloadable file, broadcasting by any channel, public display or presentation, communicating through press information services, or inclusion in widely accessible databases or indexes)
- (c) **editing or redrafting** (including shortening, summarising, inserting other elements (e.g. meta-data, legends, other graphic, visual, audio or text elements), extracting parts (e.g. audio or video files), dividing into parts, use in a compilation)
- (d) **translation**
- (e) **storage** in paper, electronic or other form
- (f) **archiving**, in line with applicable document-management rules

- (g) the right to authorise **third parties** to act on its behalf or sub-license to third parties the modes of use set out in Points (b), (c), (d) and (f), if needed for the information, communication and publicity activity of the granting authority and
- (h) **processing**, analysing, aggregating the materials, documents and information received and **producing derivative works**.

The rights of use are granted for the whole duration of the industrial or intellectual property rights concerned.

If materials or documents are subject to moral rights or third party rights (including intellectual property rights or rights of natural persons on their image and voice), the beneficiaries must ensure that they comply with their obligations under this Agreement (in particular, by obtaining the necessary licences and authorisations from the rights holders concerned).

Where applicable, the granting authority will insert the following information:

“© – [year] – [name of the copyright owner]. All rights reserved. Licensed to the [name of granting authority] under conditions.”

16.4 Specific rules on IPR, results and background

Specific rules regarding intellectual property rights, results and background (if any) are set out in Annex 5.

16.5 Consequences of non-compliance

If a beneficiary breaches any of its obligations under this Article, the grant may be reduced (see Article 28).

Such a breach may also lead to other measures described in Chapter 5.

ARTICLE 17 — COMMUNICATION, DISSEMINATION AND VISIBILITY

17.1 Communication — Dissemination — Promoting the action

Unless otherwise agreed with the granting authority, the beneficiaries must promote the action and its results by providing targeted information to multiple audiences (including the media and the public), in accordance with Annex 1 and in a strategic, coherent and effective manner.

Before engaging in a communication or dissemination activity expected to have a major media impact, the beneficiaries must inform the granting authority.

17.2 Visibility — European flag and funding statement

Unless otherwise agreed with the granting authority, communication activities of the beneficiaries related to the action (including media relations, conferences, seminars, information material, such as brochures, leaflets, posters, presentations, etc., in electronic form, via traditional or social media, etc.), dissemination activities and any infrastructure, equipment, vehicles, supplies or major result funded by the grant must acknowledge the EU support and display the European flag (emblem) and funding statement (translated into local languages, where appropriate):



Funded by the
European Union



Co-funded by the
European Union



Funded by the
European Union



Co-funded by the
European Union

The emblem must remain distinct and separate and cannot be modified by adding other visual marks, brands or text.

Apart from the emblem, no other visual identity or logo may be used to highlight the EU support.

When displayed in association with other logos (e.g. of beneficiaries or sponsors), the emblem must be displayed at least as prominently and visibly as the other logos.

For the purposes of their obligations under this Article, the beneficiaries may use the emblem without first obtaining approval from the granting authority. This does not, however, give them the right to exclusive use. Moreover, they may not appropriate the emblem or any similar trademark or logo, either by registration or by any other means.

17.3 Quality of information — Disclaimer

Any communication or dissemination activity related to the action must use factually accurate information.

Moreover, it must indicate the following disclaimer (translated into local languages where appropriate):

“Funded by the European Union. Views and opinions expressed are however those of the author(s) only and do not necessarily reflect those of the European Union or [name of the granting authority]. Neither the European Union nor the granting authority can be held responsible for them.”

17.4 Specific communication, dissemination and visibility rules

Specific communication, dissemination and visibility rules (if any) are set out in Annex 5.

17.5 Consequences of non-compliance

If a beneficiary breaches any of its obligations under this Article, the grant may be reduced (see Article 28).

Such breaches may also lead to other measures described in Chapter 5.

ARTICLE 18 — SPECIFIC RULES FOR CARRYING OUT THE ACTION

18.1 Specific rules for carrying out the action

Specific rules for implementing the action (if any) are set out in Annex 5.

18.2 Consequences of non-compliance

If a beneficiary breaches any of its obligations under this Article, the grant may be reduced (see Article 28).

Such a breach may also lead to other measures described in Chapter 5.

SECTION 3 GRANT ADMINISTRATION

ARTICLE 19 — GENERAL INFORMATION OBLIGATIONS

19.1 Information requests

The beneficiaries must provide — during the action or afterwards and in accordance with Article 7 — any information requested in order to verify eligibility of the lump sum contributions declared, proper implementation of the action and compliance with the other obligations under the Agreement.

The information provided must be accurate, precise and complete and in the format requested, including electronic format.

19.2 Participant Register data updates

The beneficiaries must keep — at all times, during the action or afterwards — their information stored in the Portal Participant Register up to date, in particular, their name, address, legal representatives, legal form and organisation type.

19.3 Information about events and circumstances which impact the action

The beneficiaries must immediately inform the granting authority (and the other beneficiaries) of any of the following:

- (a) **events** which are likely to affect or delay the implementation of the action or affect the EU's financial interests, in particular:
 - (i) changes in their legal, financial, technical, organisational or ownership situation (including changes linked to one of the exclusion grounds listed in the declaration of honour signed before grant signature)
 - (ii) linked action information: not applicable

(b) **circumstances** affecting:

- (i) the decision to award the grant or
- (ii) compliance with requirements under the Agreement.

19.4 Consequences of non-compliance

If a beneficiary breaches any of its obligations under this Article, the grant may be reduced (see Article 28).

Such breaches may also lead to other measures described in Chapter 5.

ARTICLE 20 — RECORD-KEEPING

20.1 Keeping records and supporting documents

The beneficiaries must — at least until the time-limit set out in the Data Sheet (see Point 6) — keep records and other supporting documents to prove the proper implementation of the action (proper implementation of the work and/or achievement of the results as described in Annex 1) in line with the accepted standards in the respective field (if any); beneficiaries do not need to keep specific records on the actual costs incurred.

The records and supporting documents must be made available upon request (see Article 19) or in the context of checks, reviews, audits or investigations (see Article 25).

If there are on-going checks, reviews, audits, investigations, litigation or other pursuits of claims under the Agreement (including the extension of findings; see Article 25), the beneficiaries must keep these records and other supporting documentation until the end of these procedures.

The beneficiaries must keep the original documents. Digital and digitalised documents are considered originals if they are authorised by the applicable national law. The granting authority may accept non-original documents if they offer a comparable level of assurance.

20.2 Consequences of non-compliance

If a beneficiary breaches any of its obligations under this Article, lump sum contributions insufficiently substantiated will be ineligible (see Article 6) and will be rejected (see Article 27), and the grant may be reduced (see Article 28).

Such breaches may also lead to other measures described in Chapter 5.

ARTICLE 21 — REPORTING

21.1 Continuous reporting

The beneficiaries must report on the progress of the action (e.g. **deliverables, milestones, outputs/outcomes, critical risks, indicators**, etc; if any), in the Portal Continuous Reporting tool and in accordance with the timing and conditions it sets out (as agreed with the granting authority).

Standardised deliverables (e.g. progress reports not linked to payments, reports on cumulative expenditure, special reports, etc; if any) must be submitted using the templates published on the Portal.

21.2 Periodic reporting: Technical reports and financial statements

In addition, the beneficiaries must provide reports to request payments, in accordance with the schedule and modalities set out in the Data Sheet (see Point 4.2):

- for additional prefinancings (if any): **an additional prefinancing report**
- for interim payments (if any) and the final payment: a **periodic report**

The prefinancing and periodic reports include a technical and financial part.

The technical part includes an overview of the action implementation. It must be prepared using the template available in the Portal Periodic Reporting tool.

The financial part of the additional prefinancing report includes a statement on the use of the previous prefinancing payment.

The financial part of the periodic report includes:

- the financial statement (consolidated statement for the consortium)
- the explanation on the use of resources (or detailed cost reporting table): not applicable
- the certificates on the financial statements (CFS): not applicable.

The **financial statement** must contain the lump sum contributions indicated in Annex 2, for the work packages that were completed during the reporting period.

For the last reporting period, the beneficiaries may exceptionally also declare partial lump sum contributions for work packages that were not completed (e.g. due to force majeure or technical impossibility).

Lump sum contributions which are not declared in a financial statement will not be taken into account by the granting authority.

By signing the financial statement (directly in the Portal Periodic Reporting tool), the coordinator confirms (on behalf of the consortium) that:

- the information provided is complete, reliable and true
- the lump sum contributions declared are eligible (in particular, the work packages have been completed, that the work has been properly implemented and/or the results were achieved in accordance with Annex 1; see Article 6)
- the proper implementation and/or achievement can be substantiated by adequate records and supporting documents (see Article 20) that will be produced upon request (see Article 19) or in the context of checks, reviews, audits and investigations (see Article 25).

In case of recoveries (see Article 22), beneficiaries will be held responsible also for the lump sum contributions declared for their affiliated entities (if any).

21.3 Currency for financial statements and conversion into euros

The financial statements must be drafted in euro.

21.4 Reporting language

The reporting must be in the language of the Agreement, unless otherwise agreed with the granting authority (see Data Sheet, Point 4.2).

21.5 Consequences of non-compliance

If a report submitted does not comply with this Article, the granting authority may suspend the payment deadline (see Article 29) and apply other measures described in Chapter 5.

If the coordinator breaches its reporting obligations, the granting authority may terminate the grant or the coordinator's participation (see Article 32) or apply other measures described in Chapter 5.

ARTICLE 22 — PAYMENTS AND RECOVERIES — CALCULATION OF AMOUNTS DUE

22.1 Payments and payment arrangements

Payments will be made in accordance with the schedule and modalities set out in the Data Sheet (see Point 4.2).

They will be made in euro to the bank account indicated by the coordinator (see Data Sheet, Point 4.2) and must be distributed without unjustified delay (restrictions may apply to distribution of the initial prefinancing payment; see Data Sheet, Point 4.2).

Payments to this bank account will discharge the granting authority from its payment obligation.

The cost of payment transfers will be borne as follows:

- the granting authority bears the cost of transfers charged by its bank
- the beneficiary bears the cost of transfers charged by its bank
- the party causing a repetition of a transfer bears all costs of the repeated transfer.

Payments by the granting authority will be considered to have been carried out on the date when they are debited to its account.

22.2 Recoveries

Recoveries will be made, if — at beneficiary termination, final payment or afterwards — it turns out that the granting authority has paid too much and needs to recover the amounts undue.

Each beneficiary's financial responsibility in case of recovery is in principle limited to their own debt and undue amounts of their affiliated entities.

In case of enforced recoveries (see Article 22.4), affiliated entities will be held liable for repaying debts of their beneficiaries, if required by the granting authority (see Data Sheet, Point 4.4).

22.3 Amounts due

22.3.1 Prefinancing payments

The aim of the prefinancing is to provide the beneficiaries with a float.

It remains the property of the EU until the final payment.

For **initial prefinancings** (if any), the amount due, schedule and modalities are set out in the Data Sheet (see Point 4.2).

For **additional prefinancings** (if any), the amount due, schedule and modalities are also set out in the Data Sheet (see Point 4.2). However, if the statement on the use of the previous prefinancing payment shows that less than 70% was used, the amount set out in the Data Sheet will be reduced by the difference between the 70% threshold and the amount used.

The contribution to the Mutual Insurance Mechanism will be retained from the prefinancing payments (at the rate and in accordance with the modalities set out in the Data Sheet, see Point 4.2) and transferred to the Mechanism.

Prefinancing payments (or parts of them) may be offset (without the beneficiaries' consent) against amounts owed by a beneficiary to the granting authority — up to the amount due to that beneficiary.

For grants where the granting authority is the European Commission or an EU executive agency, offsetting may also be done against amounts owed to other Commission services or executive agencies.

Payments will not be made if the payment deadline or payments are suspended (see Articles 29 and 30).

22.3.2 Amount due at beneficiary termination — Recovery

In case of beneficiary termination, the granting authority will determine the provisional amount due for the beneficiary concerned.

This will be done on the basis of work packages already completed in previous interim payments. Payments for ongoing/not yet completed work packages which the beneficiary was working on before termination (if any) will therefore be made only later on, with the next interim or final payments when those work packages have been completed.

The **amount due** will be calculated in the following step:

Step 1 — Calculation of the total accepted EU contribution

Step 1 — Calculation of the total accepted EU contribution

The granting authority will first calculate the 'accepted EU contribution' for the beneficiary, on the basis of the beneficiary's lump sum contributions for the work packages which were approved in previous interim payments.

After that, the granting authority will take into account grant reductions (if any). The resulting amount is the 'total accepted EU contribution' for the beneficiary.

The **balance** is then calculated by deducting the payments received (if any; see report on the distribution of payments in Article 32), from the total accepted EU contribution:

$$\left\{ \begin{array}{l} \text{total accepted EU contribution for the beneficiary} \\ \text{minus} \\ \text{prefinancing and interim payments received (if any)} \end{array} \right\}.$$

If the balance is **negative**, it will be **recovered** in accordance with the following procedure:

The granting authority will send a **pre-information letter** to the beneficiary concerned:

- formally notifying the intention to recover, the amount due, the amount to be recovered and the reasons why and
- requesting observations within 30 days of receiving notification.

If no observations are submitted (or the granting authority decides to pursue recovery despite the observations it has received), it will confirm the amount to be recovered and ask this amount to be paid to the coordinator (**confirmation letter**).

If payment is not made to the coordinator by the date specified in the confirmation letter, the granting authority may call on the Mutual Insurance Mechanism to intervene, if continuation of the action is guaranteed and the conditions set out in the rules governing the Mechanism are met.

In this case, it will send a **beneficiary recovery letter**, together with a **debit note** with the terms and date for payment.

The debit note for the beneficiary will include the amount calculated for the affiliated entities which also had to end their participation (if any).

If payment is not made by the date specified in the debit note, the granting authority will **enforce recovery** in accordance with Article 22.4.

22.3.3 Interim payments

Interim payments reimburse the eligible lump sum contributions claimed for work packages implemented during the reporting periods (if any).

Interim payments (if any) will be made in accordance with the schedule and modalities set out the Data Sheet (see Point 4.2).

Payment is subject to the approval of the periodic report and the work packages declared. Their approval does not imply recognition of compliance, authenticity, completeness or correctness of their content.

Incomplete work packages and work packages that have not been delivered or cannot be approved will be rejected (see Article 27).

The **interim payment** will be calculated by the granting authority in the following steps:

Step 1 — Calculation of the total accepted EU contribution

Step 2 — Limit to the interim payment ceiling

Step 1 — Calculation of the total accepted EU contribution

The granting authority will first calculate the ‘accepted EU contribution’ for the action for the reporting period, by calculating the lump sum contributions for the approved work packages.

After that, the granting authority will take into account grant reductions from beneficiary termination (if any). The resulting amount is the ‘total accepted EU contribution’.

Step 2 — Limit to the interim payment ceiling

The resulting amount is then capped to ensure that the total amount of prefinancing and interim payments (if any) does not exceed the interim payment ceiling set out in the Data Sheet (see Point 4.2).

Interim payments (or parts of them) may be offset (without the beneficiaries’ consent) against amounts owed by a beneficiary to the granting authority — up to the amount due to that beneficiary.

For grants where the granting authority is the European Commission or an EU executive agency, offsetting may also be done against amounts owed to other Commission services or executive agencies.

Payments will not be made if the payment deadline or payments are suspended (see Articles 29 and 30).

22.3.4 Final payment — Final grant amount — Revenues and Profit — Recovery

The final payment (payment of the balance) reimburses the remaining eligible lump sum contributions claimed for the implemented work packages (if any).

The final payment will be made in accordance with the schedule and modalities set out in the Data Sheet (see Point 4.2).

Payment is subject to the approval of the final periodic report and the work packages declared. Their approval does not imply recognition of compliance, authenticity, completeness or correctness of their content.

Work packages (or parts of them) that have not been delivered or cannot be approved will be rejected (see Article 27).

The **final grant amount for the action** will be calculated in the following steps:

Step 1 — Calculation of the total accepted EU contribution

Step 2 — Limit to the maximum grant amount

Step 3 — Reduction due to the no-profit rule

Step 1 — Calculation of the total accepted EU contribution

The granting authority will first calculate the ‘accepted EU contribution’ for the action for all reporting periods, by calculating the lump sum contributions for the approved work packages.

After that, the granting authority will take into account grant reductions (if any). The resulting amount is the ‘total accepted EU contribution’.

Step 2 — Limit to the maximum grant amount

Not applicable

Step 3 — Reduction due to the no-profit rule

Not applicable

The **balance** (final payment) is then calculated by deducting the total amount of prefinancing and interim payments already made (if any), from the final grant amount:

$$\begin{aligned} & \{\text{final grant amount} \\ & \text{minus} \\ & \{\text{prefinancing and interim payments made (if any)}\} \}. \end{aligned}$$

If the balance is **positive**, it will be **paid** to the coordinator.

The amount retained for the Mutual Insurance Mechanism (see above) will be released and **paid** to the coordinator (in accordance with the rules governing the Mechanism).

The final payment (or part of it) may be offset (without the beneficiaries’ consent) against amounts owed by a beneficiary to the granting authority — up to the amount due to that beneficiary.

For grants where the granting authority is the European Commission or an EU executive agency, offsetting may also be done against amounts owed to other Commission services or executive agencies.

Payments will not be made if the payment deadline or payments are suspended (see Articles 29 and 30).

If — despite the release of the Mutual Insurance Mechanism contribution — the balance is **negative**, it will be **recovered** in accordance with the following procedure:

The granting authority will send a **pre-information letter** to the coordinator:

- formally notifying the intention to recover, the final grant amount, the amount to be recovered and the reasons why
- requesting a report on the distribution of payments to the beneficiaries within 30 days of receiving notification and
- requesting observations within 30 days of receiving notification.

If no observations are submitted (or the granting authority decides to pursue recovery despite the observations it has received) and the coordinator has submitted the report on the distribution of payments, it will calculate the **share of the debt per beneficiary**, by:

- (a) identifying the beneficiaries for which the amount calculated as follows is negative:

$$\left\{ \left\{ \begin{array}{l} \text{total accepted EU contribution for the beneficiary} \\ \text{divided by} \\ \text{total accepted EU contribution for the action} \end{array} \right\} \right. \\ \left. \begin{array}{l} \text{multiplied by} \\ \text{final grant amount for the action} \end{array} \right\}, \\ \text{minus} \\ \left\{ \text{prefinancing and interim payments received by the beneficiary (if any)} \right\}$$

and

(b) dividing the debt:

$$\left\{ \begin{array}{l} \text{amount calculated according to point (a) for the beneficiary concerned} \\ \text{divided by} \\ \text{the sum of the amounts calculated according to point (a) for all the beneficiaries identified according to} \\ \text{point (a)} \end{array} \right\} \\ \text{multiplied by} \\ \text{the amount to be recovered}.$$

and confirm the amount to be recovered from each beneficiary concerned (**confirmation letter**), together with **debit notes** with the terms and date for payment.

The debit notes for beneficiaries will include the amounts calculated for their affiliated entities (if any).

If the coordinator has not submitted the report on the distribution of payments, the granting authority will **recover** the full amount from the coordinator (**confirmation letter** and **debit note** with the terms and date for payment).

If payment is not made by the date specified in the debit note, the granting authority will **enforce recovery** in accordance with Article 22.4.

22.3.5 Audit implementation after final payment — Revised final grant amount — Recovery

If — after the final payment (in particular, after checks, reviews, audits or investigations; see Article 25) — the granting authority rejects lump sum contributions (see Article 27) or reduces the grant (see Article 28), it will calculate the **revised final grant amount** for the beneficiary concerned.

The **beneficiary revised final grant amount** will be calculated in the following step:

Step 1 — Calculation of the revised total accepted EU contribution

Step 1 — Calculation of the revised total accepted EU contribution

The granting authority will first calculate the ‘revised accepted EU contribution’ for the beneficiary, by calculating the ‘revised accepted contributions’.

After that, it will take into account grant reductions (if any). The resulting ‘revised total accepted EU contribution’ is the beneficiary revised final grant amount.

If the revised final grant amount is lower than the beneficiary’s final grant amount (i.e. its share in the final grant amount for the action), it will be **recovered** in accordance with the following procedure:

The **beneficiary final grant amount** (i.e. share in the final grant amount for the action) is calculated as follows:

$$\left\{ \begin{array}{l} \text{total accepted EU contribution for the beneficiary} \\ \text{divided by} \\ \text{total accepted EU contribution for the action} \end{array} \right\} \times \text{final grant amount for the action}.$$

The granting authority will send a **pre-information letter** to the beneficiary concerned:

- formally notifying the intention to recover, the amount to be recovered and the reasons why and
- requesting observations within 30 days of receiving notification.

If no observations are submitted (or the granting authority decides to pursue recovery despite the observations it has received), it will confirm the amount to be recovered (**confirmation letter**), together with a **debit note** with the terms and the date for payment.

Recoveries against affiliated entities (if any) will be handled through their beneficiaries.

If payment is not made by the date specified in the debit note, the granting authority will **enforce recovery** in accordance with Article 22.4.

22.4 Enforced recovery

If payment is not made by the date specified in the debit note, the amount due will be recovered:

- (a) by offsetting the amount — without the coordinator or beneficiary’s consent — against any amounts owed to the coordinator or beneficiary by the granting authority.

In exceptional circumstances, to safeguard the EU financial interests, the amount may be offset before the payment date specified in the debit note.

For grants where the granting authority is the European Commission or an EU executive agency, debts may also be offset against amounts owed by other Commission services or executive agencies.

- (b) financial guarantee(s): not applicable
- (c) joint and several liability of beneficiaries: not applicable
- (d) by holding affiliated entities jointly and severally liable (if any, see Data Sheet, Point 4.4)
- (e) by taking legal action (see Article 43) or, provided that the granting authority is the European

Commission or an EU executive agency, by adopting an enforceable decision under Article 299 of the Treaty on the Functioning of the EU (TFEU) and Article 100(2) of EU Financial Regulation 2024/2509.

If the Mutual Insurance Mechanism was called on by the granting authority to intervene, recovery will be continued in the name of the Mutual Insurance Mechanism. If two debit notes were sent, the second one (in the name of the Mutual Insurance Mechanism) will be considered to replace the first one (in the name of the granting authority). Where the MIM intervened, offsetting, enforceable decisions or any other of the above-mentioned forms of enforced recovery may be used *mutatis mutandis*.

The amount to be recovered will be increased by **late-payment interest** at the rate set out in Article 23.5, from the day following the payment date in the debit note, up to and including the date the full payment is received.

Partial payments will be first credited against expenses, charges and late-payment interest and then against the principal.

Bank charges incurred in the recovery process will be borne by the beneficiary, unless Directive 2015/2366¹⁷ applies.

For grants where the granting authority is an EU executive agency, enforced recovery by offsetting or enforceable decision will be done by the services of the European Commission (see also Article 43).

22.5 Consequences of non-compliance

22.5.1 If the granting authority does not pay within the payment deadlines (see above), the beneficiaries are entitled to **late-payment interest** at the reference rate applied by the European Central Bank (ECB) for its main refinancing operations in euros, plus the percentage specified in the Data Sheet (Point 4.2). The ECB reference rate to be used is the rate in force on the first day of the month in which the payment deadline expires, as published in the C series of the *Official Journal of the European Union*.

If the late-payment interest is lower than or equal to EUR 200, it will be paid to the coordinator only on request submitted within two months of receiving the late payment.

Late-payment interest is not due if all beneficiaries are EU Member States (including regional and local government authorities or other public bodies acting on behalf of a Member State for the purpose of this Agreement).

If payments or the payment deadline are suspended (see Articles 29 and 30), payment will not be considered as late.

Late-payment interest covers the period running from the day following the due date for payment (see above), up to and including the date of payment.

Late-payment interest is not considered for the purposes of calculating the final grant amount.

¹⁷ Directive (EU) 2015/2366 of the European Parliament and of the Council of 25 November 2015 on payment services in the internal market, amending Directives 2002/65/EC, 2009/110/EC and 2013/36/EU and Regulation (EU) No 1093/2010, and repealing Directive 2007/64/EC (OJ L 337, 23.12.2015, p. 35).

22.5.2 If the coordinator breaches any of its obligations under this Article, the grant may be reduced (see Article 28) and the grant or the coordinator may be terminated (see Article 32).

Such breaches may also lead to other measures described in Chapter 5.

ARTICLE 23 — GUARANTEES

Not applicable

ARTICLE 24 — CERTIFICATES

Not applicable

ARTICLE 25 — CHECKS, REVIEWS, AUDITS AND INVESTIGATIONS — EXTENSION OF FINDINGS

25.1 Granting authority checks, reviews and audits

25.1.1 Internal checks

The granting authority may — during the action or afterwards — check the proper implementation of the action and compliance with the obligations under the Agreement, including assessing lump sum contributions, deliverables and reports.

25.1.2 Project reviews

The granting authority may carry out reviews on the proper implementation of the action and compliance with the obligations under the Agreement (general project reviews or specific issues reviews).

Such project reviews may be started during the implementation of the action and until the time-limit set out in the Data Sheet (see Point 6). They will be formally notified to the coordinator or beneficiary concerned and will be considered to start on the date of the notification.

If needed, the granting authority may be assisted by independent, outside experts. If it uses outside experts, the coordinator or beneficiary concerned will be informed and have the right to object on grounds of commercial confidentiality or conflict of interest.

The coordinator or beneficiary concerned must cooperate diligently and provide — within the deadline requested — any information and data in addition to deliverables and reports already submitted. The granting authority may request beneficiaries to provide such information to it directly. Sensitive information and documents will be treated in accordance with Article 13.

The coordinator or beneficiary concerned may be requested to participate in meetings, including with the outside experts.

For **on-the-spot visits**, the beneficiary concerned must allow access to sites and premises (including to the outside experts) and must ensure that information requested is readily available.

Information provided must be accurate, precise and complete and in the format requested, including electronic format.

On the basis of the review findings, a **project review report** will be drawn up.

The granting authority will formally notify the project review report to the coordinator or beneficiary concerned, which has 30 days from receiving notification to make observations.

Project reviews (including project review reports) will be in the language of the Agreement, unless otherwise agreed with the granting authority (see Data Sheet, Point 4.2).

25.1.3 Audits

The granting authority may carry out audits on the proper implementation of the action and compliance with the obligations under the Agreement.

Such audits may be started during the implementation of the action and until the time-limit set out in the Data Sheet (see Point 6). They will be formally notified to the beneficiary concerned and will be considered to start on the date of the notification.

The granting authority may use its own audit service, delegate audits to a centralised service or use external audit firms. If it uses an external firm, the beneficiary concerned will be informed and have the right to object on grounds of commercial confidentiality or conflict of interest.

The beneficiary concerned must cooperate diligently and provide — within the deadline requested — any information (including complete accounts, individual salary statements or other personal data) to verify compliance with the Agreement. Sensitive information and documents will be treated in accordance with Article 13.

For **on-the-spot** visits, the beneficiary concerned must allow access to sites and premises (including for the external audit firm) and must ensure that information requested is readily available.

Information provided must be accurate, precise and complete and in the format requested, including electronic format.

On the basis of the audit findings, a **draft audit report** will be drawn up.

The auditors will formally notify the draft audit report to the beneficiary concerned, which has 30 days from receiving notification to make observations (contradictory audit procedure).

The **final audit report** will take into account observations by the beneficiary concerned and will be formally notified to them.

Audits (including audit reports) will be in the language of the Agreement, unless otherwise agreed with the granting authority (see Data Sheet, Point 4.2).

25.2 European Commission checks, reviews and audits in grants of other granting authorities

Where the granting authority is not the European Commission, the latter has the same rights of checks, reviews and audits as the granting authority.

25.3 Access to records for assessing simplified forms of funding

The beneficiaries must give the European Commission access to their statutory records for the periodic assessment of simplified forms of funding which are used in EU programmes.

25.4 OLAF, EPPO and ECA audits and investigations

The following bodies may also carry out checks, reviews, audits and investigations — during the action or afterwards:

- the European Anti-Fraud Office (OLAF) under Regulations No 883/2013¹⁸ and No 2185/96¹⁹
- the European Public Prosecutor's Office (EPPO) under Regulation 2017/1939
- the European Court of Auditors (ECA) under Article 287 of the Treaty on the Functioning of the EU (TFEU) and Article 263 of EU Financial Regulation 2024/2509.

If requested by these bodies, the beneficiary concerned must provide full, accurate and complete information in the format requested (including complete accounts, individual salary statements or other personal data, including in electronic format) and allow access to sites and premises for on-the-spot visits or inspections — as provided for under these Regulations.

To this end, the beneficiary concerned must keep all relevant information relating to the action, at least until the time-limit set out in the Data Sheet (Point 6) and, in any case, until any ongoing checks, reviews, audits, investigations, litigation or other pursuits of claims have been concluded.

25.5 Consequences of checks, reviews, audits and investigations — Extension of findings

25.5.1 Consequences of checks, reviews, audits and investigations in this grant

Findings in checks, reviews, audits or investigations carried out in the context of this grant may lead to rejections (see Article 27), grant reduction (see Article 28) or other measures described in Chapter 5.

Rejections or grant reductions after the final payment will lead to a revised final grant amount (see Article 22).

Findings in checks, reviews, audits or investigations during the action implementation may lead to a request for amendment (see Article 39), to change the description of the action set out in Annex 1.

Checks, reviews, audits or investigations that find systemic or recurrent errors, irregularities, fraud or breach of obligations in any EU grant may also lead to consequences in other EU grants awarded under similar conditions ('extension to other grants').

Moreover, findings arising from an OLAF or EPPO investigation may lead to criminal prosecution under national law.

25.5.2 Extension from other grants

¹⁸ Regulation (EU, Euratom) No 883/2013 of the European Parliament and of the Council of 11 September 2013 concerning investigations conducted by the European Anti-Fraud Office (OLAF) and repealing Regulation (EC) No 1073/1999 of the European Parliament and of the Council and Council Regulation (Euratom) No 1074/1999 (OJ L 248, 18/09/2013, p. 1).

¹⁹ Council Regulation (Euratom, EC) No 2185/96 of 11 November 1996 concerning on-the-spot checks and inspections carried out by the Commission in order to protect the European Communities' financial interests against fraud and other irregularities (OJ L 292, 15/11/1996, p. 2).

Findings of checks, reviews, audits or investigations in other grants may be extended to this grant, if:

- (a) the beneficiary concerned is found, in other EU grants awarded under similar conditions, to have committed systemic or recurrent errors, irregularities, fraud or breach of obligations that have a material impact on this grant and
- (b) those findings are formally notified to the beneficiary concerned — together with the list of grants affected by the findings — within the time-limit for audits set out in the Data Sheet (see Point 6).

The granting authority will formally notify the beneficiary concerned of the intention to extend the findings and the list of grants affected.

If the extension concerns **rejections of lump sum contributions**: the notification will include:

- (a) an invitation to submit observations on the list of grants affected by the findings
- (b) the request to submit revised financial statements for all grants affected
- (c) the correction rate for extrapolation, established on the basis of the systemic or recurrent errors, to calculate the amounts to be rejected, if the beneficiary concerned:
 - (i) considers that the submission of revised financial statements is not possible or practicable or
 - (ii) does not submit revised financial statements.

If the extension concerns **grant reductions**: the notification will include:

- (a) an invitation to submit observations on the list of grants affected by the findings and
- (b) the **correction rate for extrapolation**, established on the basis of the systemic or recurrent errors and the principle of proportionality.

The beneficiary concerned has **60 days** from receiving notification to submit observations, revised financial statements or to propose a duly substantiated **alternative correction method/rate**.

On the basis of this, the granting authority will analyse the impact and decide on the implementation (i.e. start rejection or grant reduction procedures, either on the basis of the revised financial statements or the announced/alternative method/rate or a mix of those; see Articles 27 and 28).

25.6 Consequences of non-compliance

If a beneficiary breaches any of its obligations under this Article, lump sum contributions insufficiently substantiated will be ineligible (see Article 6) and will be rejected (see Article 27), and the grant may be reduced (see Article 28).

Such breaches may also lead to other measures described in Chapter 5.

ARTICLE 26 — IMPACT EVALUATIONS

26.1 Impact evaluation

The granting authority may carry out impact evaluations of the action, measured against the objectives and indicators of the EU programme funding the grant.

Such evaluations may be started during implementation of the action and until the time-limit set out in the Data Sheet (see Point 6). They will be formally notified to the coordinator or beneficiaries and will be considered to start on the date of the notification.

If needed, the granting authority may be assisted by independent outside experts.

The coordinator or beneficiaries must provide any information relevant to evaluate the impact of the action, including information in electronic format.

26.2 Consequences of non-compliance

If a beneficiary breaches any of its obligations under this Article, the granting authority may apply the measures described in Chapter 5.

CHAPTER 5 CONSEQUENCES OF NON-COMPLIANCE

SECTION 1 REJECTIONS AND GRANT REDUCTION

ARTICLE 27 — REJECTION OF CONTRIBUTIONS

27.1 Conditions

The granting authority will — at interim payment, final payment or afterwards — reject any lump sum contributions which are ineligible (see Article 6), in particular following checks, reviews, audits or investigations (see Article 25).

The rejection may also be based on the extension of findings from other grants to this grant (see Article 25).

Ineligible lump sum contributions will be rejected.

27.2 Procedure

If the rejection does not lead to a recovery, the granting authority will formally notify the coordinator or beneficiary concerned of the rejection, the amounts and the reasons why. The coordinator or beneficiary concerned may — within 30 days of receiving notification — submit observations if it disagrees with the rejection (payment review procedure).

If the rejection leads to a recovery, the granting authority will follow the contradictory procedure with pre-information letter set out in Article 22.

27.3 Effects

If the granting authority rejects lump sum contributions, it will deduct them from the lump sum contributions declared and then calculate the amount due (and, if needed, make a recovery; see Article 22).

ARTICLE 28 — GRANT REDUCTION

28.1 Conditions

The granting authority may — at beneficiary termination, final payment or afterwards — reduce the grant for a beneficiary, if:

- (a) the beneficiary (or a person having powers of representation, decision-making or control, or person essential for the award/implementation of the grant) has committed:
 - (i) substantial errors, irregularities or fraud or
 - (ii) serious breach of obligations under this Agreement or during its award (including improper implementation of the action, non-compliance with the call conditions, submission of false information, failure to provide required information, breach of ethics or security rules (if applicable), failure to cooperate with checks, reviews, audits and investigations, etc.), or
- (b) the beneficiary (or a person having powers of representation, decision-making or control, or person essential for the award/implementation of the grant) has committed — in other EU grants awarded to it under similar conditions — systemic or recurrent errors, irregularities, fraud or serious breach of obligations that have a material impact on this grant (extension of findings; see Article 25.5).

The amount of the reduction will be calculated for each beneficiary concerned and proportionate to the seriousness and the duration of the errors, irregularities or fraud or breach of obligations, by applying an individual reduction rate to their accepted EU contribution.

28.2 Procedure

If the grant reduction does not lead to a recovery, the granting authority will formally notify the coordinator or beneficiary concerned of the reduction, the amount to be reduced and the reasons why. The coordinator or beneficiary concerned may — within 30 days of receiving notification — submit observations if it disagrees with the reduction (payment review procedure).

If the grant reduction leads to a recovery, the granting authority will follow the contradictory procedure with pre-information letter set out in Article 22.

28.3 Effects

If the granting authority reduces the grant, it will deduct the reduction and then calculate the amount due (and, if needed, make a recovery; see Article 22).

SECTION 2 — SUSPENSION AND TERMINATION

ARTICLE 29 — PAYMENT DEADLINE SUSPENSION

29.1 Conditions

The granting authority may — at any moment — suspend the payment deadline if a payment cannot be processed because:

- (a) the required report (see Article 21) has not been submitted or is not complete or additional information is needed
- (b) there are doubts about the amount to be paid (e.g. ongoing extension procedure, queries about eligibility, need for a grant reduction, etc.) and additional checks, reviews, audits or investigations are necessary, or
- (c) there are other issues affecting the EU financial interests.

29.2 Procedure

The granting authority will formally notify the coordinator of the suspension and the reasons why.

The suspension will **take effect** the day the notification is sent.

If the conditions for suspending the payment deadline are no longer met, the suspension will be **lifted** — and the remaining time to pay (see Data Sheet, Point 4.2) will resume.

If the suspension exceeds two months, the coordinator may request the granting authority to confirm if the suspension will continue.

If the payment deadline has been suspended due to the non-compliance of the report and the revised report is not submitted (or was submitted but is also rejected), the granting authority may also terminate the grant or the participation of the coordinator (see Article 32).

ARTICLE 30 — PAYMENT SUSPENSION

30.1 Conditions

The granting authority may — at any moment — suspend payments, in whole or in part for one or more beneficiaries, if:

- (a) a beneficiary (or a person having powers of representation, decision-making or control, or person essential for the award/implementation of the grant) has committed or is suspected of having committed:
 - (i) substantial errors, irregularities or fraud or
 - (ii) serious breach of obligations under this Agreement or during its award (including improper implementation of the action, non-compliance with the call conditions, submission of false information, failure to provide required information, breach of ethics or security rules (if applicable), failure to cooperate with checks, reviews, audits and investigations, etc.), or
- (b) a beneficiary (or a person having powers of representation, decision-making or control, or person essential for the award/implementation of the grant) has committed — in other EU grants awarded to it under similar conditions — systemic or recurrent errors, irregularities, fraud or serious breach of obligations that have a material impact on this grant (extension of findings; see Article 25.5).

If payments are suspended for one or more beneficiaries, the granting authority will make partial payment(s) for the part(s) not suspended. If suspension concerns the final payment, the payment (or

recovery) of the remaining amount after suspension is lifted will be considered to be the payment that closes the action.

30.2 Procedure

Before suspending payments, the granting authority will send a **pre-information letter** to the beneficiary concerned:

- formally notifying the intention to suspend payments and the reasons why and
- requesting observations within 30 days of receiving notification.

If the granting authority does not receive observations or decides to pursue the procedure despite the observations it has received, it will confirm the suspension (**confirmation letter**). Otherwise, it will formally notify that the procedure is discontinued.

At the end of the suspension procedure, the granting authority will also inform the coordinator.

The suspension will **take effect** the day after the confirmation notification is sent.

If the conditions for resuming payments are met, the suspension will be **lifted**. The granting authority will formally notify the beneficiary concerned (and the coordinator) and set the suspension end date.

During the suspension, no prefinancing will be paid to the beneficiaries concerned. For interim payments, the periodic reports for all reporting periods except the last one (see Article 21) must not contain any financial statements from the beneficiary concerned (or its affiliated entities). The coordinator must include them in the next periodic report after the suspension is lifted or — if suspension is not lifted before the end of the action — in the last periodic report.

ARTICLE 31 — GRANT AGREEMENT SUSPENSION

31.1 Consortium-requested GA suspension

31.1.1 Conditions and procedure

The beneficiaries may request the suspension of the grant or any part of it, if exceptional circumstances — in particular *force majeure* (see Article 35) — make implementation impossible or excessively difficult.

The coordinator must submit a request for **amendment** (see Article 39), with:

- the reasons why
- the date the suspension takes effect; this date may be before the date of the submission of the amendment request and
- the expected date of resumption.

The suspension will **take effect** on the day specified in the amendment.

Once circumstances allow for implementation to resume, the coordinator must immediately request another **amendment** of the Agreement to set the suspension end date, the resumption date (one day

after suspension end date), extend the duration and make other changes necessary to adapt the action to the new situation (see Article 39) — unless the grant has been terminated (see Article 32). The suspension will be **lifted** with effect from the suspension end date set out in the amendment. This date may be before the date of the submission of the amendment request.

During the suspension, no prefinancing will be paid. Moreover, no work may be done. Ongoing work packages must be interrupted and no new work packages may be started.

31.2 EU-initiated GA suspension

31.2.1 Conditions

The granting authority may suspend the grant or any part of it, if:

- (a) a beneficiary (or a person having powers of representation, decision-making or control, or person essential for the award/implementation of the grant) has committed or is suspected of having committed:
 - (i) substantial errors, irregularities or fraud or
 - (ii) serious breach of obligations under this Agreement or during its award (including improper implementation of the action, non-compliance with the call conditions, submission of false information, failure to provide required information, breach of ethics or security rules (if applicable), failure to cooperate with checks, reviews, audits and investigations, etc.), or
- (b) a beneficiary (or a person having powers of representation, decision-making or control, or person essential for the award/implementation of the grant) has committed — in other EU grants awarded to it under similar conditions — systemic or recurrent errors, irregularities, fraud or serious breach of obligations that have a material impact on this grant (extension of findings; see Article 25.5)
- (c) other:
 - (i) linked action issues: not applicable
 - (ii) the action has lost its scientific or technological relevance, for EIC Accelerator actions: the action has lost its economic relevance, for challenge-based EIC Pathfinder actions and Horizon Europe Missions: the action has lost its relevance as part of the Portfolio for which it has been initially selected

31.2.2 Procedure

Before suspending the grant, the granting authority will send a **pre-information letter** to the coordinator:

- formally notifying the intention to suspend the grant and the reasons why and
- requesting observations within 30 days of receiving notification.

If the granting authority does not receive observations or decides to pursue the procedure despite the

observations it has received, it will confirm the suspension (**confirmation letter**). Otherwise, it will formally notify that the procedure is discontinued.

The suspension will **take effect** the day after the confirmation notification is sent (or on a later date specified in the notification).

Once the conditions for resuming implementation of the action are met, the granting authority will formally notify the coordinator a **lifting of suspension letter**, in which it will set the suspension end date and invite the coordinator to request an amendment of the Agreement to set the resumption date (one day after suspension end date), extend the duration and make other changes necessary to adapt the action to the new situation (see Article 39) — unless the grant has been terminated (see Article 32). The suspension will be **lifted** with effect from the suspension end date set out in the lifting of suspension letter. This date may be before the date on which the letter is sent.

During the suspension, no prefinancing will be paid. Moreover, no work may be done. Ongoing work packages must be interrupted and no new work packages may be started.

The beneficiaries may not claim damages due to suspension by the granting authority (see Article 33).

Grant suspension does not affect the granting authority's right to terminate the grant or a beneficiary (see Article 32) or reduce the grant (see Article 28).

ARTICLE 32 — GRANT AGREEMENT OR BENEFICIARY TERMINATION

32.1 Consortium-requested GA termination

32.1.1 Conditions and procedure

The beneficiaries may request the termination of the grant.

The coordinator must submit a request for **amendment** (see Article 39), with:

- the reasons why
- the date the consortium ends work on the action ('end of work date') and
- the date the termination takes effect ('termination date'); this date must be after the date of the submission of the amendment request.

The termination will **take effect** on the termination date specified in the amendment.

If no reasons are given or if the granting authority considers the reasons do not justify termination, it may consider the grant terminated improperly.

32.1.2 Effects

The coordinator must — within 60 days from when termination takes effect — submit a **periodic report** (for the open reporting period until termination).

The granting authority will calculate the final grant amount and final payment on the basis of the report submitted and taking into account the lump sum contributions for activities implemented before

the end of work date (see Article 22). Partial lump sum contributions for work packages that were not completed (e.g. due to technical reasons) may exceptionally be taken into account.

If the granting authority does not receive the report within the deadline, only lump sum contributions which are included in an approved periodic report will be taken into account (no contributions if no periodic report was ever approved).

Improper termination may lead to a grant reduction (see Article 28).

After termination, the beneficiaries' obligations (in particular Articles 13 (confidentiality and security), 16 (IPR), 17 (communication, dissemination and visibility), 21 (reporting), 25 (checks, reviews, audits and investigations), 26 (impact evaluation), 27 (rejections), 28 (grant reduction) and 42 (assignment of claims)) continue to apply.

32.2 Consortium-requested beneficiary termination

32.2.1 Conditions and procedure

The coordinator may request the termination of the participation of one or more beneficiaries, on request of the beneficiary concerned or on behalf of the other beneficiaries.

The coordinator must submit a request for **amendment** (see Article 39), with:

- the reasons why
- the opinion of the beneficiary concerned (or proof that this opinion has been requested in writing)
- the date the beneficiary ends work on the action ('end of work date')
- the date the termination takes effect ('termination date'); this date must be after the date of the submission of the amendment request.

If the termination concerns the coordinator and is done without its agreement, the amendment request must be submitted by another beneficiary (acting on behalf of the consortium).

The termination will **take effect** on the termination date specified in the amendment.

If no information is given or if the granting authority considers that the reasons do not justify termination, it may consider the beneficiary to have been terminated improperly.

32.2.2 Effects

The coordinator must — within 60 days from when termination takes effect — submit:

- (i) a **report on the distribution of payments** to the beneficiary concerned
- (ii) a **termination report** from the beneficiary concerned, for the open reporting period until termination, containing an overview of the progress of the work
- (iii) a second **request for amendment** (see Article 39) with other amendments needed (e.g. reallocation of the tasks and the estimated budget of the terminated beneficiary; addition of a new beneficiary to replace the terminated beneficiary; change of coordinator, etc.).

The granting authority will calculate the amount due to the beneficiary on the basis of the reports submitted in previous interim payments (i.e. beneficiary's lump sum contributions for completed and approved work packages).

Lump sum contributions for ongoing/not yet completed work packages will have to be included in the periodic report for the next reporting periods when those work packages have been completed.

If the granting authority does not receive the report on the distribution of payments within the deadline, it will consider that:

- the coordinator did not distribute any payment to the beneficiary concerned and that
- the beneficiary concerned must not repay any amount to the coordinator.

If the second request for amendment is accepted by the granting authority, the Agreement is **amended** to introduce the necessary changes (see Article 39).

If the second request for amendment is rejected by the granting authority (because it calls into question the decision awarding the grant or breaches the principle of equal treatment of applicants), the grant may be terminated (see Article 32).

Improper termination may lead to a reduction of the grant (see Article 31) or grant termination (see Article 32).

After termination, the concerned beneficiary's obligations (in particular Articles 13 (confidentiality and security), 16 (IPR), 17 (communication, dissemination and visibility), 21 (reporting), 25 (checks, reviews, audits and investigations), 26 (impact evaluation), 27 (rejections), 28 (grant reduction) and 42 (assignment of claims)) continue to apply.

32.3 EU-initiated GA or beneficiary termination

32.3.1 Conditions

The granting authority may terminate the grant or the participation of one or more beneficiaries, if:

- (a) one or more beneficiaries do not accede to the Agreement (see Article 40)
- (b) a change to the action or the legal, financial, technical, organisational or ownership situation of a beneficiary is likely to substantially affect the implementation of the action or calls into question the decision to award the grant (including changes linked to one of the exclusion grounds listed in the declaration of honour)
- (c) following termination of one or more beneficiaries, the necessary changes to the Agreement (and their impact on the action) would call into question the decision awarding the grant or breach the principle of equal treatment of applicants
- (d) implementation of the action has become impossible or the changes necessary for its continuation would call into question the decision awarding the grant or breach the principle of equal treatment of applicants
- (e) a beneficiary (or person with unlimited liability for its debts) is subject to bankruptcy

proceedings or similar (including insolvency, winding-up, administration by a liquidator or court, arrangement with creditors, suspension of business activities, etc.)

- (f) a beneficiary (or person with unlimited liability for its debts) is in breach of social security or tax obligations
- (g) a beneficiary (or person having powers of representation, decision-making or control, or person essential for the award/implementation of the grant) has been found guilty of grave professional misconduct
- (h) a beneficiary (or person having powers of representation, decision-making or control, or person essential for the award/implementation of the grant) has committed fraud, corruption, or is involved in a criminal organisation, money laundering, terrorism-related crimes (including terrorism financing), child labour or human trafficking
- (i) a beneficiary (or person having powers of representation, decision-making or control, or person essential for the award/implementation of the grant) was created under a different jurisdiction with the intent to circumvent fiscal, social or other legal obligations in the country of origin (or created another entity with this purpose)
- (j) a beneficiary (or person having powers of representation, decision-making or control, or person essential for the award/implementation of the grant) has committed:
 - (i) substantial errors, irregularities or fraud or
 - (ii) serious breach of obligations under this Agreement or during its award (including improper implementation of the action, non-compliance with the call conditions, submission of false information, failure to provide required information, breach of ethics or security rules (if applicable), failure to cooperate with checks, reviews, audits and investigations, etc.)
- (k) a beneficiary (or person having powers of representation, decision-making or control, or person essential for the award/implementation of the grant) has committed — in other EU grants awarded to it under similar conditions — systemic or recurrent errors, irregularities, fraud or serious breach of obligations that have a material impact on this grant (extension of findings; see Article 25.5)
- (l) despite a specific request by the granting authority, a beneficiary does not request — through the coordinator — an amendment to the Agreement to end the participation of one of its affiliated entities or associated partners that is in one of the situations under points (d), (f), (e), (g), (h), (i) or (j) and to reallocate its tasks, or
- (m) other:
 - (i) linked action issues: not applicable
 - (ii) the action has lost its scientific or technological relevance, for EIC Accelerator actions: the action has lost its economic relevance, for challenge-based EIC Pathfinder actions and Horizon Europe Missions: the action has lost its relevance as part of the Portfolio for which it has been initially selected

32.3.2 Procedure

Before terminating the grant or participation of one or more beneficiaries, the granting authority will send a **pre-information letter** to the coordinator or beneficiary concerned:

- formally notifying the intention to terminate and the reasons why and
- requesting observations within 30 days of receiving notification.

If the granting authority does not receive observations or decides to pursue the procedure despite the observations it has received, it will confirm the termination and the date it will take effect (**confirmation letter**). Otherwise, it will formally notify that the procedure is discontinued.

For beneficiary terminations, the granting authority will — at the end of the procedure — also inform the coordinator.

The termination will **take effect** the day after the confirmation notification is sent (or on a later date specified in the notification; ‘termination date’).

32.3.3 Effects

(a) for **GA termination**:

The coordinator must — within 60 days from when termination takes effect — submit a **periodic report** (for the last open reporting period until termination).

The granting authority will calculate the final grant amount and final payment on the basis of the report submitted and taking into account the lump sum contributions for activities implemented before termination takes effect (see Article 22). Partial lump sum contributions for work packages that were not completed (e.g. due to technical reasons) may exceptionally be taken into account.

If the grant is terminated for breach of the obligation to submit reports, the coordinator may not submit any report after termination.

If the granting authority does not receive the report within the deadline, only lump sum contributions which are included in an approved periodic report will be taken into account (no contributions if no periodic report was ever approved).

Termination does not affect the granting authority’s right to reduce the grant (see Article 28) or to impose administrative sanctions (see Article 34).

The beneficiaries may not claim damages due to termination by the granting authority (see Article 33).

After termination, the beneficiaries’ obligations (in particular Articles 13 (confidentiality and security), 16 (IPR), 17 (communication, dissemination and visibility), 21 (reporting), 25 (checks, reviews, audits and investigations), 26 (impact evaluation), 27 (rejections), 28 (grant reduction) and 42 (assignment of claims)) continue to apply.

(b) for **beneficiary termination**:

The coordinator must — within 60 days from when termination takes effect — submit:

- (i) a **report on the distribution of payments** to the beneficiary concerned

- (ii) a **termination report** from the beneficiary concerned, for the open reporting period until termination, containing an overview of the progress of the work
- (iii) a **request for amendment** (see Article 39) with any amendments needed (e.g. reallocation of the tasks and the estimated budget of the terminated beneficiary; addition of a new beneficiary to replace the terminated beneficiary; change of coordinator, etc.).

The granting authority will calculate the amount due to the beneficiary on the basis of the reports submitted in previous interim payments (i.e. beneficiary's lump sum contributions for completed and approved work packages).

Lump sum contributions for ongoing/not yet completed work packages will have to be included in the periodic report for the next reporting periods when those work packages have been completed.

If the granting authority does not receive the report on the distribution of payments within the deadline, it will consider that:

- the coordinator did not distribute any payment to the beneficiary concerned and that
- the beneficiary concerned must not repay any amount to the coordinator.

If the request for amendment is accepted by the granting authority, the Agreement is **amended** to introduce the necessary changes (see Article 39).

If the request for amendment is rejected by the granting authority (because it calls into question the decision awarding the grant or breaches the principle of equal treatment of applicants), the grant may be terminated (see Article 32).

After termination, the concerned beneficiary's obligations (in particular Articles 13 (confidentiality and security), 16 (IPR), 17 (communication, dissemination and visibility), 21 (reporting), 25 (checks, reviews, audits and investigations), 26 (impact evaluation), 27 (rejections), 28 (grant reduction) and 42 (assignment of claims)) continue to apply.

SECTION 3 OTHER CONSEQUENCES: DAMAGES AND ADMINISTRATIVE SANCTIONS

ARTICLE 33 — DAMAGES

33.1 Liability of the granting authority

The granting authority cannot be held liable for any damage caused to the beneficiaries or to third parties as a consequence of the implementation of the Agreement, including for gross negligence.

The granting authority cannot be held liable for any damage caused by any of the beneficiaries or other participants involved in the action, as a consequence of the implementation of the Agreement.

33.2 Liability of the beneficiaries

The beneficiaries must compensate the granting authority for any damage it sustains as a result of the implementation of the action or because the action was not implemented in full compliance with the Agreement, provided that it was caused by gross negligence or wilful act.

The liability does not extend to indirect or consequential losses or similar damage (such as loss of profit, loss of revenue or loss of contracts), provided such damage was not caused by wilful act or by a breach of confidentiality.

ARTICLE 34 — ADMINISTRATIVE SANCTIONS AND OTHER MEASURES

Nothing in this Agreement may be construed as preventing the adoption of administrative sanctions (i.e. exclusion from EU award procedures and/or financial penalties) or other public law measures, in addition or as an alternative to the contractual measures provided under this Agreement (see, for instance, Articles 137 to 148 EU Financial Regulation 2024/2509 and Articles 4 and 7 of Regulation 2988/95²⁰).

SECTION 4 FORCE MAJEURE

ARTICLE 35 — FORCE MAJEURE

A party prevented by force majeure from fulfilling its obligations under the Agreement cannot be considered in breach of them.

‘Force majeure’ means any situation or event that:

- prevents either party from fulfilling their obligations under the Agreement
- was unforeseeable, exceptional situation and beyond the parties’ control
- was not due to error or negligence on their part (or on the part of other participants involved in the action) and
- proves to be inevitable in spite of exercising all due diligence.

Any situation constituting force majeure must be formally notified to the other party without delay, stating the nature, likely duration and foreseeable effects.

The parties must immediately take all the necessary steps to limit any damage due to force majeure and do their best to resume implementation of the action as soon as possible.

CHAPTER 6 FINAL PROVISIONS

ARTICLE 36 — COMMUNICATION BETWEEN THE PARTIES

36.1 Forms and means of communication — Electronic management

EU grants are managed fully electronically through the EU Funding & Tenders Portal (‘Portal’).

²⁰ Council Regulation (EC, Euratom) No 2988/95 of 18 December 1995 on the protection of the European Communities financial interests (OJ L 312, 23.12.1995, p. 1).

All communications must be made electronically through the Portal in accordance with the Portal Terms and Conditions and using the forms and templates provided there (except if explicitly instructed otherwise by the granting authority).

Communications must be made in writing and clearly identify the grant agreement (project number and acronym).

Communications must be made by persons authorised according to the Portal Terms and Conditions. For naming the authorised persons, each beneficiary must have designated — before the signature of this Agreement — a ‘legal entity appointed representative (LEAR)’. The role and tasks of the LEAR are stipulated in their appointment letter (see Portal Terms and Conditions).

If the electronic exchange system is temporarily unavailable, instructions will be given on the Portal.

36.2 Date of communication

The sending date for communications made through the Portal will be the date and time of sending, as indicated by the time logs.

The receiving date for communications made through the Portal will be the date and time the communication is accessed, as indicated by the time logs. Formal notifications that have not been accessed within 10 days after sending, will be considered to have been accessed (see Portal Terms and Conditions).

If a communication is exceptionally made on paper (by e-mail or postal service), general principles apply (i.e. date of sending/receipt). Formal notifications by registered post with proof of delivery will be considered to have been received either on the delivery date registered by the postal service or the deadline for collection at the post office.

If the electronic exchange system is temporarily unavailable, the sending party cannot be considered in breach of its obligation to send a communication within a specified deadline.

36.3 Addresses for communication

The Portal can be accessed via the Europa website.

The address for paper communications to the granting authority (if exceptionally allowed) is the official mailing address indicated on its website.

For beneficiaries, it is the legal address specified in the Portal Participant Register.

ARTICLE 37 — INTERPRETATION OF THE AGREEMENT

The provisions in the Data Sheet take precedence over the rest of the Terms and Conditions of the Agreement.

Annex 5 takes precedence over the Terms and Conditions.

The Terms and Conditions take precedence over the Annexes other than Annex 5.

Annex 2 takes precedence over Annex 1.

ARTICLE 38 — CALCULATION OF PERIODS AND DEADLINES

In accordance with Regulation No 1182/71²¹, periods expressed in days, months or years are calculated from the moment the triggering event occurs.

The day during which that event occurs is not considered as falling within the period.

‘Days’ means calendar days, not working days.

ARTICLE 39 — AMENDMENTS

39.1 Conditions

The Agreement may be amended, unless the amendment entails changes to the Agreement which would call into question the decision awarding the grant or breach the principle of equal treatment of applicants.

Amendments may be requested by any of the parties.

39.2 Procedure

The party requesting an amendment must submit a request for amendment signed directly in the Portal Amendment tool.

The coordinator submits and receives requests for amendment on behalf of the beneficiaries (see Annex 3). If a change of coordinator is requested without its agreement, the submission must be done by another beneficiary (acting on behalf of the other beneficiaries).

The request for amendment must include:

- the reasons why
- the appropriate supporting documents and
- for a change of coordinator without its agreement: the opinion of the coordinator (or proof that this opinion has been requested in writing).

The granting authority may request additional information.

If the party receiving the request agrees, it must sign the amendment in the tool within 45 days of receiving notification (or any additional information the granting authority has requested). If it does not agree, it must formally notify its disagreement within the same deadline. The deadline may be extended, if necessary for the assessment of the request. If no notification is received within the deadline, the request is considered to have been rejected.

An amendment **enters into force** on the day of the signature of the receiving party.

An amendment **takes effect** on the date of entry into force or other date specified in the amendment.

²¹ Regulation (EEC, Euratom) No 1182/71 of the Council of 3 June 1971 determining the rules applicable to periods, dates and time-limits (OJ L 124, 8/6/1971, p. 1).

ARTICLE 40 — ACCESSION AND ADDITION OF NEW BENEFICIARIES

40.1 Accession of the beneficiaries mentioned in the Preamble

The beneficiaries which are not coordinator must accede to the grant by signing the accession form (see Annex 3) directly in the Portal Grant Preparation tool, within 30 days after the entry into force of the Agreement (see Article 44).

They will assume the rights and obligations under the Agreement with effect from the date of its entry into force (see Article 44).

If a beneficiary does not accede to the grant within the above deadline, the coordinator must — within 30 days — request an amendment (see Article 39) to terminate the beneficiary and make any changes necessary to ensure proper implementation of the action. This does not affect the granting authority's right to terminate the grant (see Article 32).

40.2 Addition of new beneficiaries

In justified cases, the beneficiaries may request the addition of a new beneficiary.

For this purpose, the coordinator must submit a request for amendment in accordance with Article 39. It must include an accession form (see Annex 3) signed by the new beneficiary directly in the Portal Amendment tool.

New beneficiaries will assume the rights and obligations under the Agreement with effect from the date of their accession specified in the accession form (see Annex 3).

Additions are also possible in mono-beneficiary grants.

ARTICLE 41 — TRANSFER OF THE AGREEMENT

In justified cases, the beneficiary of a mono-beneficiary grant may request the transfer of the grant to a new beneficiary, provided that this would not call into question the decision awarding the grant or breach the principle of equal treatment of applicants.

The beneficiary must submit a request for **amendment** (see Article 39), with

- the reasons why
- the accession form (see Annex 3) signed by the new beneficiary directly in the Portal Amendment tool and
- additional supporting documents (if required by the granting authority).

The new beneficiary will assume the rights and obligations under the Agreement with effect from the date of accession specified in the accession form (see Annex 3).

ARTICLE 42 — ASSIGNMENTS OF CLAIMS FOR PAYMENT AGAINST THE GRANTING AUTHORITY

The beneficiaries may not assign any of their claims for payment against the granting authority to

any third party, except if expressly approved in writing by the granting authority on the basis of a reasoned, written request by the coordinator (on behalf of the beneficiary concerned).

If the granting authority has not accepted the assignment or if the terms of it are not observed, the assignment will have no effect on it.

In no circumstances will an assignment release the beneficiaries from their obligations towards the granting authority.

ARTICLE 43 — APPLICABLE LAW AND SETTLEMENT OF DISPUTES

43.1 Applicable law

The Agreement is governed by the applicable EU law, supplemented if necessary by the law of Belgium.

Special rules may apply for beneficiaries which are international organisations (if any; see Data Sheet, Point 5).

43.2 Dispute settlement

If a dispute concerns the interpretation, application or validity of the Agreement, the parties must bring action before the EU General Court — or, on appeal, the EU Court of Justice — under Article 272 of the Treaty on the Functioning of the EU (TFEU).

For non-EU beneficiaries (if any), such disputes must be brought before the courts of Brussels, Belgium — unless an international agreement provides for the enforceability of EU court judgements.

For beneficiaries with arbitration as special dispute settlement forum (if any; see Data Sheet, Point 5), the dispute will — in the absence of an amicable settlement — be settled in accordance with the Rules for Arbitration published on the Portal.

If a dispute concerns administrative sanctions, offsetting or an enforceable decision under Article 299 TFEU (see Articles 22 and 34), the beneficiaries must bring action before the General Court — or, on appeal, the Court of Justice — under Article 263 TFEU.

For grants where the granting authority is an EU executive agency (see Preamble), actions against offsetting and enforceable decisions must be brought against the European Commission (not against the granting authority; see also Article 22).

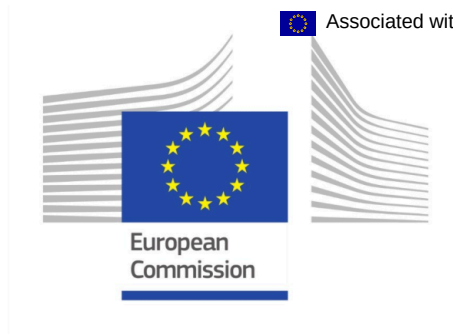
ARTICLE 44 — ENTRY INTO FORCE

The Agreement will enter into force on the day of signature by the granting authority or the coordinator, depending on which is later.

SIGNATURES

For the coordinator

For the granting authority



ANNEX 1



Horizon Europe (HORIZON)

Description of the action (DoA)

Part A

Part B

DESCRIPTION OF THE ACTION (PART A)

COVER PAGE

Part A of the Description of the Action (DoA) must be completed directly on the Portal Grant Preparation screens.

PROJECT	
Grant Preparation (General Information screen) — Enter the info.	
Project number:	101292277
Project name:	SoBigData Implementation Phase
Project acronym:	SoBigData IP
Call:	HORIZON-INFRA-2025-01
Topic:	HORIZON-INFRA-2025-01-DEV-02
Type of action:	HORIZON-CSA
Service:	REA/C/04
Project starting date:	fixed date: 1 June 2026
Project duration:	36 months

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Project reviews 27

PROJECT SUMMARY

Project summary

Grant Preparation (General Information screen) — Provide an overall description of your project (including context and overall objectives, planned activities and main achievements, and expected results and impacts (on target groups, change procedures, capacities, innovation etc)). This summary should give readers a clear idea of what your project is about.

Use the project summary from your proposal.

SoBigData is a pan-European RI dedicated to social mining and big data analytics. The RI serves as a dynamic nexus for innovative research, offering a fully open and collaborative environment where experts from computer science, social sciences, humanities, and related fields can leverage cutting-edge tools and advanced methodologies. Building on the solid technological foundations validated during the preparatory phase, the infrastructure is now moving toward a sustainable future, focusing on broader accessibility and an improved user experience. The Implementation Phase of the SoBigData RI focuses on putting into action the plans developed during its preparatory stage. During this phase, technological components, tools, and services, are refined and integrated for the public use. It also involves the support to establishing the ERIC and make it operational. More specifically, SoBigData IP has a central objective to integrate new services and enhance the way users interact with the RI, making services and facilities easier to navigate and use, while fostering active engagement across diverse communities, including researchers, industry, policymakers, and citizens. By consolidating access policies and expanding participation opportunities, SoBigData IP aims to create a more inclusive and impactful ecosystem. At the same time, the SoBigData IP is strengthening the RI pan-European relevance by aligning closely with EOSC and European Data Spaces, promoting interoperability, and supporting cross-border collaboration. This integration reinforces Europe's research capacity and enables evidence-based policymaking. Finally, the pathway to establishing SoBigData as an ERIC is underway. Guided by the SoBigData IP, the RI is consolidating its governance, legal, and financial frameworks to ensure long-term sustainability. This transition will secure SoBigData's position as a stable, trusted, and high-impact research infrastructure within the European landscape.

LIST OF PARTICIPANTS

PARTICIPANTS

Grant Preparation (Beneficiaries screen) — Enter the info.

Number	Role	Short name	Legal name	Country	PIC
1	COO	CNR	CONSIGLIO NAZIONALE DELLE RICERCHE	IT	999979500
2	BEN	UNIFI	UNIVERSITA DI PISA	IT	999862712
3	BEN	SNS	SCUOLA NORMALE SUPERIORE	IT	999886962
4	BEN	IMT	SCUOLA IMT (ISTITUZIONI, MERCATI, TECNOLOGIE) ALTI STUDI DI LUCCA	IT	965146412
5	BEN	UNIVAQ	UNIVERSITA DEGLI STUDI DELL'AQUILA	IT	999859511
6	BEN	UNIROMA1	UNIVERSITA DEGLI STUDI DI ROMA LA SAPIENZA	IT	999987745
7	BEN	SSSA	SCUOLA SUPERIORE DI STUDI UNIVERSITARI E DI PERFEZIONAMENTO S ANNA	IT	999884731
8	BEN	UNIBO	ALMA MATER STUDIORUM - UNIVERSITA DI BOLOGNA	IT	999993953
9	BEN	UNIPA	UNIVERSITA DEGLI STUDI DI PALERMO	IT	999734284
10	BEN	LUH	GOTTFRIED WILHELM LEIBNIZ UNIVERSITAET HANNOVER	DE	999981828

PARTICIPANTS*Grant Preparation (Beneficiaries screen) — Enter the info.*

Number	Role	Short name	Legal name	Country	PIC
11	BEN	ATHENA	ATHINA-EREVNITIKO KENTRO KAINOTOMIAS STIS TECHNOLOGIES TIS PLIROFORIAS, TON EPIKOINONION KAI TIS GNOSIS	EL	999562788
12	BEN	OpenAIRE	OPENAIRE AMKE	EL	903914192
13	BEN	UvA	UNIVERSITEIT VAN AMSTERDAM	NL	999985708
14	BEN	TU Delft	TECHNISCHE UNIVERSITEIT DELFT	NL	999977366
15	BEN	EGI	STICHTING EGI	NL	989221715
16	BEN	BSC	BARCELONA SUPERCOMPUTING CENTER CENTRO NACIONAL DE SUPERCOMPUTACION	ES	999655520
17	BEN	URV	UNIVERSITAT ROVIRA I VIRGILI	ES	999880560
18	BEN	UPF	UNIVERSIDAD POMPEU FABRA	ES	999867077
19	BEN	UCM	UNIVERSIDAD COMPLUTENSE DE MADRID	ES	999874546
20	BEN	KCL	KING'S COLLEGE LONDON	UK	999981052
21	BEN	REPHRAIN	UNIVERSITY OF BRISTOL	UK	999974262
22	BEN	CSD	CENTER FOR THE STUDY OF DEMOCRACY	BG	999548529
23	BEN	SLEX	SMARTEX SRL SOCIETA DI PRODOTTI E SERVIZI GIURIDICI INTERDISCIPLINARI	IT	925521039
24	BEN	TOUR4EU	TUSCAN ORGANISATION OF UNIVERSITIES AND RESEARCH 4 EUROPE	BE	903152742
25	BEN	X-officio	X-officio Research AB	SE	876844887
26	BEN	DFKI	DEUTSCHES FORSCHUNGSZENTRUM FUR KUNSTLICHE INTELLIGENZ GMBH	DE	999607602

LIST OF WORK PACKAGES

Work packages						
Grant Preparation (Work Packages screen) — Enter the info.						
Work Package No	Work Package name	Lead Beneficiary	Effort (Person-Months)	Start Month	End Month	Deliverables
WP1	Management	1 - CNR	7.80	1	18	D1.1 – Relevant Board Established D1.2 – Stakeholder Engagement Report 1 D1.3 – SoBigData IP - Policy Brief 1 D1.4 – SoBigData RI - Data management plan 2 D1.5 – SoBigData RI - Data management plan 1 D1.6 – Dissemination, exploitation and communication plan 1 D1.7 – Dissemination, exploitation and communication plan 2
WP2	Advancing Research Infrastructure Maturity (Phase 1)	23 - SLEX	28.15	1	6	D2.1 – ERIC Statute D2.2 – ERIC Governance Manual D2.3 – Access Policy Framework D2.4 – Scientific Case D2.5 – Financial and Budgeting D2.6 – Service Selection & Catalogue Review
WP3	National Nodes	1 - CNR	30.40	1	24	D3.1 – National Node Implementation Report
WP4	Advancing Research Infrastructure Maturity (Phase 2)	1 - CNR	60.90	7	24	D4.1 – User experience & Test Cases Report 1 D4.2 – Service Deployment & Integration Framework
WP5	Management Finalisation	1 - CNR	11.00	19	36	D5.1 – Stakeholder Engagement Report 2

Work packages <i>Grant Preparation (Work Packages screen) — Enter the info.</i>						
Work Package No	Work Package name	Lead Beneficiary	Effort (Person-Months)	Start Month	End Month	Deliverables
						D5.2 – SoBigData RI - Data management plan 3 D5.3 – SoBigData IP - Policy Brief 2
WP6	Advancing Research Infrastructure Maturity (Phase 3)	1 - CNR	23.95	25	36	D6.1 – Service Maintenance & Integration Framework D6.2 – Open Infrastructure Monitoring Tools D6.3 – Final report on dissemination, exploitation and communication

Work package WP1 – Management

Work Package Number	WP1	Lead Beneficiary	1 - CNR
Work Package Name	Management		
Start Month	1	End Month	18

Objectives

Led by CNR, WP1 ensures strong and efficient day-to-day management to meet the objectives related to the initialisation phase within time and budget constraints. WP1 focuses on: providing administrative and financial management of the initialisation phase of the project; enhancing cooperation between partners; enabling work progress; ensuring project reporting, contract management, and assuring compliance with the Commission's reporting requirements. Moreover, this WP refers to the early introduction of skills, systems, resources, and institutions needed for the ERIC operationalisation and will be responsible for defining actions for stakeholder engagement.

Description

T1.1 Initialisation Phase Administration and Financial Management [M1 - M24]. Task leader: CNR; Participants: ALL
This task encompasses essential leadership and project management aspects required for the project's initial phase planning, undertaking, and monitoring. CNR will manage and coordinate the project. It will establish and maintain the project management board and undertake the full range of managerial, administrative, supporting, and coordinating activities necessary and appropriate for a project of this size. The task will also form all the boards expected by the project. This task will manage funds and their transfer to partners, deal with all contractual matters, prepare and lead project meetings and reviews (propose agendas, prepare minutes). This task will establish all the project administration boards and revise the risks related to the project execution.

T1.2 Internal Capacity Building [M7 - M24]. Task Leader UNIPI; Participants: CNR, SNS, IMT, UNIVAQ, UNIROMA1, SSSA, UNIBO, UNIPA, LUH, ATHENA, UvA, TUDelft, EGI, BSC, URV, UPF, UCM, KCL, REPHRAIN, CSD, SLEX

This task will be responsible for strengthening the administrative, legal, and technological skills needed by the partners to operate the RI effectively and, before the ERIC is formally established, laying the foundation for the RI's long-term sustainability. The main actions are related to defining guidelines to train future staff with skills in management, data stewardship, legal compliance, technical operations, finance systems, HR structures, and governance tools, and ensuring everyone understands ERIC-specific legal frameworks, VAT exemptions, reporting duties, etc.

T1.3 Stakeholder Engagement [M7 - 24]. Task Leader TOUR4EU; Participants: CNR, UNIPI, SNS, IMT, UNIVAQ, UNIROMA1, SSSA, UNIBO, UNIPA, LUH, ATHENA, UvA, TUDelft, EGI, BSC, URV, UPF, UCM, KCL, REPHRAIN, CSD

The process of identifying, involving, and maintaining meaningful relationships with different stakeholders is a key point and influences the RI's mission, development, and operations. This task aims to define, plan, and organise tailored events to enable actual stakeholder engagement (with particular attention to private companies and public bodies). The consortium has proven experience in defining and executing this kind of events (e.g., Challenge Us, Digital Coffees, and Conferences).

T1.4 Co-design and Implementation of a KPI Framework with Open Infrastructure Monitoring Tools [M1 - M24]. Task Leader OpenAIRE; Participants: CNR, LUH, ATHENA, UvA, BSC, KCL

This task relates to co-designing, deploying, and operationalising a KPI framework aligned with ESFRI guidelines to monitor the scientific, technical, and societal performance of SoBigData RI from the start of the implementation phase. This task will identify key indicators in line with ESFRI's success criteria, including research output volume and quality, reuse and openness of data and software, user engagement, and societal impact. It will leverage the OpenAIRE Graph and OpenAIRE's Monitor service to develop a SoBigData-specific dashboard for tracking outputs, usage, impact, and Open Science practices. Through well-established Rules of Participation for the SoBigData Nodes (e.g., how to acknowledge, how to cite, where to publish, etc.) and best practices on metadata standards from related data sources for publications, datasets, software, and workflows, content will be harvested, enriched, and semantically linked to funding streams, infrastructure usage, and impact pathways. T4.1 includes co-defining KPIs with stakeholders (SoBigData scientific board, user community), establishing data flows and indicators within OpenAIRE Monitor, integrating OpenAIRE Graph to link research products to SoBigData RI, setting up routines for evidence-based reporting and visual dashboards, and piloting and refining the dashboard with selected SoBigData services.

Work package WP2 – Advancing Research Infrastructure Maturity (Phase 1)

Work Package Number	WP2	Lead Beneficiary	23 - SLEX
Work Package Name	Advancing Research Infrastructure Maturity (Phase 1)		
Start Month	1	End Month	6

Objectives

Led by SLEX, WP2 will ensure the legal, financial, operational, and technological readiness required for the submission and subsequent implementation of the SoBigData ERIC. Building on the outcomes of the preparatory phase and the progress achieved in the intervening period, this work package will consolidate all documentation essential for establishing the ERIC's structural and legal foundations. It will cover the development of the consortium's legal statutes, governance framework, core operational policies, and budgeting structures, alongside preparations for the technical readiness needed to deploy services. In addition, WP2 will define the access rules to the Research Infrastructure (RI) and establish the plan for technological updates required to introduce and implement the new services defined by WP4. Where possible, the Board of Government Representatives (BGR) may formally approve all the necessary documents, thus enabling the timely Step-1 submission of the ERIC application to the European Commission.

Description

T2.1 Access Policies Definition [M1 - M6]. Task Leader CNR; Participants: LUH, ATHENA, UvA, BSC, KCL, EGI, SLEX

This task will establish SoBigData ERIC access policies, informed by those developed in the SoBigData++ and SoBigData PPP projects. The policies will build on eight years of consolidated expertise in service delivery and data management, ensuring legal compliance, alignment with open science practices, and adherence to ethical principles. These outcomes will be essential for aligning the RI with the high standards set by ESFRI and requested by EC. In this context, the rules for TransNational Access (TNA), Virtual Access (VA), and Remote Access (RA) will also be inherited and updated.

T2.2 Financial & Budgeting [M1 - M6]. Task Leader X-officio; Participants: CNR, SSSA, LUH, ATHENA, UvA, BSC, KCL, SLEX

This task focuses on the preparation of the SoBigData ERIC long-term financial plan, including preliminary cost book (budget), membership contribution model, alternative funding resources (including possible service-based revenues), and sustainability strategies. The financial and contributions model will be submitted to the BGR for approval.

T2.3 Complementing Statutes with Other Relevant Policies [M1 - M6]. Task Leader: SLEX; Participants: CNR, LUH, ATHENA, UvA, BSC, KCL, TOUR4EU, SSSA

This task focuses on drafting, reviewing, and finalising the key policies that will guide SoBigData ERIC's functioning once established. Each policy will be prepared in close consultation with relevant legal, technical, and administrative experts and aligned with the ERIC Regulation and good governance practices. Policies will be reviewed by the BGR (and other relevant bodies for endorsement before adoption). This aspect will include Employment, Procurement, and IPR policies, access policy for Users, Data policy (to be led by SoBigData technical experts), and Dissemination policy.

T2.4 Consolidate Documents for Step-1 ERIC Application [M1 - M6]: Task Leader SLEX; Participants: CNR, LUH, ATHENA, UvA, BSC, KCL, X-officio

This task will formalise and validate the proposed governance model and the statute of the SoBigData ERIC, ensuring complete alignment with all participating national nodes. It encompasses the preparation of comprehensive documentation to be reviewed and approved by the Board of Government Representatives (BGR), thereby delivering a complete and compliant package for the Step-1 ERIC application. The task guarantees full adherence to the ERIC Regulation (EC) No 723/2009, covering the agreed governance structure, decision-making procedures, membership conditions, seat location, and financial commitments.

T2.5 Supporting BGR [M1 - M6]. Task Leader CNR; Participants: LUH, ATHENA, UvA, BSC, KCL, X-Officio, SLEX

In this task, the PMB will support the BGR in developing the internal bylaws, governance procedures, and operational rules accompanying the ERIC Statutes. These rules will define the functioning of the future General Assembly, executive bodies, and advisory committees, ensuring clarity and transparency in the ERIC's decision-making processes and organisational operations.

T2.6 Service Selection [M4 - M6]. Task Leader CNR; Participants: UNIPi, SNS, IMT, UNIVAQ, UNIROMA1, SSSA,

UNIBO, UNIPA, LUH, ATHENA, OpenAIRE, UvA, TUDelft, EGI, BSC, URV, UPF, UCM, KCL, REPHRAIN, CSD, DFKI

This task will revise and select the services representing priorities for the SoBigData RI. This list will include an evaluation of the feasibility, robustness, and sustainability, as well as coverage of the research spaces. This task will prepare the work for tasks T4.2 and T4.3 to have a holistic view of the existing and new services and how they will be implemented/updated and exposed to the users.

T2.7 SoBigData Catalogue Review [M1 - M6]. Task Leader CNR; Participants: EGI, OpenAIRE

A review of the actual metadata model of the SoBigData Catalogue will be performed to create vocabularies and design the improvements to be implemented in task T4.4. This will also take into consideration relevant standards coming from EOSC to guarantee that the alignment with standards and policies inherited from SoBigData RI PPP remains valid following the evolution of the EOSC framework. The primary focus of this review will be the compliance with FAIR principles and policies for the moderation step during the upload of new resources in the catalogue.

Work package WP3 – National Nodes

Work Package Number	WP3	Lead Beneficiary	1 - CNR
Work Package Name	National Nodes		
Start Month	1	End Month	24

Objectives

This WP focuses on the comprehensive management and strategic coordination of the RI node at the national level. It encompasses both operational oversight and strategic alignment with national policies, legal frameworks, and funding mechanisms.

Description

T3.1 Implementation of the Italian Node [M1 - M24]. Task leader: CNR; Participants: UNIPR, SNS, IMT, UNIVAQ, UNIROMA1, SSSA, UNIBO, UNIPA, SLEX

The Italian Node acts as the Central Hub of the distributed RI. The Central Hub will coordinate the RI and support the communication of all the lead institutions of the national nodes regarding administrative issues. Central Hub coordinates the management of some crucial aspects, including access, training, services, and dissemination, with the collaboration of the national nodes. Actions include planning, coordinating, and executing RI operations within the European and Italian contexts and ensuring alignment with national research priorities and the broader objectives of the European and overall SoBigData RI ecosystem. The Italian node must specifically ensure: i) the coordination of institutions belonging to each node and the other lead institutions; ii) the effective implementation of internal policies and governance frameworks that guide the management and performance evaluation of the RI node; iv) the engagement with relevant national stakeholders, including other strategic research institutions, public bodies, funders, and user communities; v) the participation in national roadmaps, funding programs and key initiatives to secure financial support and enhance the visibility and impact of the RI. iii) the establishment of a formal agreement among all partners within the Italian node, including compliance with Italian laws and alignment with the SoBigData RI structure.

T3.2 Implementation of the German Node [M1 - M24]. Task leader: LUH; Participants: DFKI

This task encompasses the main actions for the implementation of the German node. The actions include planning, coordinating, and executing RI operations within the German context. Ensure alignment with national research priorities and the broader objectives of the European and overall SoBigData RI ecosystem. This task must ensure i) the coordination of the institutions belonging to the node; ii) the effective implementation of internal policies and governance frameworks that guide the management and performance evaluation of the RI node; iii) the establishment of a formal agreement among all partners within the German node, ensuring compliance with national regulations and alignment with the overall SoBigData RI structure; iv) the engagement with relevant national stakeholders, including other strategic research institutions, public bodies, funders, and user communities; v) the participation in national roadmaps, funding programs and key initiatives to secure financial support and enhance the visibility and impact of the RI.

T3.3 Implementation of the Greek Node [M1 - M24]. Task leader: ATHENA; Participants: -

This task encompasses the main actions for the implementation of the Greek node. The actions include planning,

coordinating, and executing RI operations within the Greek context. Ensure alignment with national research priorities and the broader objectives of the European and overall SoBigData RI ecosystem. This task must ensure i) the coordination of the institutions belonging to the node; ii) the effective implementation of internal policies and governance frameworks that guide the management and performance evaluation of the RI node; iii) the establishment of a formal agreement among all partners within the Greek node, ensuring compliance with national regulations and alignment with the overall SoBigData RI structure; iv) the engagement with relevant national stakeholders, including other strategic research institutions, public bodies, funders, and user communities; v) the participation in national roadmaps, funding programs and key initiatives to secure financial support and enhance the visibility and impact of the RI.

T3.4 Implementation of the Dutch Node [M1 - M24]. Task leader: UvA; Participants: TUDelft, EGI

This task encompasses the main actions for the implementation of the Dutch node. The actions include planning, coordinating, and executing RI operations within the Dutch context. Ensure alignment with national research priorities and the broader objectives of the European and overall SoBigData RI ecosystem. This task must ensure i) the coordination of the institutions belonging to the node; ii) the effective implementation of internal policies and governance frameworks that guide the management and performance evaluation of the RI node; iii) the establishment of a formal agreement among all partners within the Dutch node, ensuring compliance with national regulations and alignment with the overall SoBigData RI structure; iv) the engagement with relevant national stakeholders, including other strategic research institutions, public bodies, funders, and user communities; v) the participation in national roadmaps, funding programs and key initiatives to secure financial support and enhance the visibility and impact of the RI.

T3.5 Implementation of the Spanish Node [M1 - M24]. Task leader: BSC; Participants: URV, UPF, UCM

This task encompasses the main actions for the implementation of the Spanish node. The actions include planning, coordinating, and executing RI operations within the Spanish context. Ensure alignment with national research priorities and the broader objectives of the European and overall SoBigData RI ecosystem. This task must ensure i) the coordination of the institutions belonging to the node; ii) the effective implementation of internal policies and governance frameworks that guide the management and performance evaluation of the RI node; iii) the establishment of a formal agreement among all partners within the Spanish node, ensuring compliance with national regulations and alignment with the overall SoBigData RI structure; iv) the engagement with relevant national stakeholders, including other strategic research institutions, public bodies, funders, and user communities; v) the participation in national roadmaps, funding programs and key initiatives to secure financial support and enhance the visibility and impact of the RI.

T3.6 Implementation of the UK Node [M1 - M24]. Task leader: KCL; Participants: REPHRAIN

This task encompasses the main actions for the implementation of the UK node. The actions include planning, coordinating, and executing RI operations within the UK context. Ensure alignment with national research priorities and the broader objectives of the SoBigData RI ecosystem. This task must ensure i) the coordination of the institutions belonging to the node; ii) the effective implementation of internal policies and governance frameworks that guide the management and performance evaluation of the RI node; iii) the establishment of a formal agreement among all partners within the UK node, ensuring compliance with national regulations and alignment with the overall SoBigData RI structure; iv) the engagement with relevant national stakeholders, including other strategic research institutions, public bodies, funders, and user communities; v) the participation in national roadmaps, funding programs and key initiatives to secure financial support and enhance the visibility and impact of the RI.

Work package WP4 – Advancing Research Infrastructure Maturity (Phase 2)

Work Package Number	WP4	Lead Beneficiary	1 - CNR
Work Package Name	Advancing Research Infrastructure Maturity (Phase 2)		
Start Month	7	End Month	24

Objectives

Led by CNR, this work package aims to ensure effective coordination to support the BGR during the consultation phase of the ERIC submission. Furthermore, WP4 is responsible for implementing, deploying, and integrating RI services. It will be responsible for the continuous updates to the technological RI and the relative validation. It serves as a bridge between strategic consultation, operational delivery, and long-term sustainability of services.

Description

T4.1 Managing BGR [M7 - M24]. Task Leader CNR; Participants: LUH, ATHENA, UvA, BSC, KCL, X-Officio, SLEX
Following task 2.5, this task will further assist the BGR in the formal submission of the ERIC application to the European Commission by the Italian Ministry, which includes compiling, clarifying, and integrating all required documentation, securing political support letters, and facilitating the inter-service consultation process with the Commission's officers.

T4.2 Improve User Experience [M7 - M24]. Task Leader CNR; Participants: UNIPI, SNS, IMT, UNIVAQ, UNIROMA1, SSSA, UNIBO, UNIPA, LUH, ATHENA, OpenAIRE, UvA, TUDelft, EGI, BSC, URV, UPF, UCM, KCL, REPHRAIN, CSD, DFKI

In this task, CNR and EGI will design new user interfaces and create internal paths to guide different types in the exploration of the services selected in task T2.6. This action will focus on improving user experience using RI facilities by adopting clear service design guidelines, clear information access, and visualisation, including improvements in user interface and access mechanisms. The SoBigData gateway will be continuously updated to address community needs, and it will be supported by tutorials and dissemination events to boost user engagement. Then, with the participation of the other partners, test cases based on real-world scenarios will be performed, selecting some early adopters. Feedback collected through these tests will impact the RI in service refinement and technological updating, ensure usability (improving user experience), and validate technical robustness.

T4.3 Technological Integration and Service Deployment [M7 - M24]. Task Leader CNR; Participants: UNIPI, SNS, IMT, UNIVAQ, UNIROMA1, SSSA, UNIBO, UNIPA, LUH, ATHENA, OpenAIRE, UvA, TUDelft, EGI, BSC, URV, UPF, UCM, KCL, REPHRAIN, CSD, DFKI

This task covers the technical integration of new computational resources into SoBigData, following the integration blueprints developed in SoBigData RI PPP. The integration must be functional to the operational deployment of services selected in task T2.6 (i.e., implementation, integration, and refinement). This includes configuring systems, ensuring interoperability, meeting compliance standards, and deploying the services in production environments. This task also ensures that the technological core of the RI is updated and aligned with RI requirements and the quality expected in this phase of the project.

T4.4 Interoperable Metadata Harmonization & EOSC Integration Framework [M7 - M24]. Task Leader CNR; Participants: EGI, OpenAIRE

This task exploits the work done in task 2.7 to harmonise metadata across all RI collections, ensuring compliance with FAIR principles and requesting data owners to meet high standards; audit existing metadata, align with FAIR principles, and adopt AI-readable formats (RDF, JSON-LD). This task will map resources to EOSC for seamless synchronisation and maintain long-term alignment with European dataspace. A dedicated team will follow developments in EOSC and dataspace to secure long-term alignment and visibility.

T4.5 Partnerships and Funding [M7 - M24]. Task Leader CNR; Participants: UNIPI, SNS, IMT, UNIVAQ, UNIROMA1, SSSA, UNIBO, UNIPA, LUH, ATHENA, OpenAIRE, UvA, TUDelft, EGI, BSC, URV, UPF, UCM, KCL, REPHRAIN, CSD, DFKI

This task involves the design and implementation of strategies to attract external funding, including the establishment of partnerships with private and public stakeholders, the promotion of the infrastructure's services to potential users, and the active participation in competitive calls at national and European levels. In addition, the task will coordinate research and innovation activities that highlight the infrastructure's unique capacities, thereby strengthening its visibility and attractiveness for investment. Through these combined efforts, the task aims to get a diversified and sustainable funding base to support the nodes and sustain growth.

Work package WP5 – Management Finalisation

Work Package Number	WP5	Lead Beneficiary	1 - CNR
Work Package Name	Management Finalisation		
Start Month	19	End Month	36

Objectives

Led by CNR, WP5 ensures strong and efficient day-to-day management for the project to meet the objectives related to the finalisation phase within time and budget constraints. WP5 provides administrative and financial management for the project's advancement, assuring compliance with the Commission's reporting requirements.

Description
T5.1 Finalisation Phase Administration and Financial Management [M25 - M36]. Task leader: CNR; Participants: ALL This task encompasses essential leadership and project management aspects required for the project's finalisation phase. CNR will maintain the central project management board and undertake the full range of managerial, administrative, supporting, and coordinating activities necessary and appropriate for a project of this size. T5.2 Finalize Internal Capacity Building [M19-M25]. Task Leader UNIPi; Participants: CNR, SNS, IMT, UNIVAQ, UNIROMA1, SSSA, UNIBO, UNIPA, LUH, ATHENA, UvA, TUDelft, EGI, BSC, URV, UPF, UCM, KCL, REPHRAIN, CSD, SLEX, DFKI This task will continue and finalize the action started in task T1.2 for strengthening the administrative, legal, and technological skills needed by the partners to operate the RI effectively and, before the ERIC is formally established, laying the foundation for the RI's long-term sustainability. T5.3 Long-term Plan for Stakeholder Engagement [M19 - M36]. Task Leader TOUR4EU; Participants: CNR, UNIPi, SNS, IMT, UNIVAQ, UNIROMA1, SSSA, UNIBO, UNIPA, LUH, ATHENA, UvA, TUDelft, EGI, BSC, URV, UPF, UCM, KCL, REPHRAIN, CSD The process of fostering and maintaining meaningful relationships with different stakeholders is a key point and influences the RIs' sustainability. This task aims to organise tailored events to enable actual stakeholder engagement (with particular attention to private companies and public bodies) and define a long-term plan for stakeholder engagement. T5.4 Completing Co-design and Implementation of the Open Infrastructure Monitoring Tools [M19 - M24]. Task Leader OpenAIRE; Participants: CNR, LUH, ATHENA, UvA, BSC, KCL This task completes the task T1.4 with the co-designing, deploying, and operationalising a KPI framework aligned with ESFRI guidelines to monitor the scientific, technical, and societal performance of SoBigData RI from the start of the implementation phase.

Work package WP6 – Advancing Research Infrastructure Maturity (Phase 3)

Work Package Number	WP6	Lead Beneficiary	1 - CNR
Work Package Name	Advancing Research Infrastructure Maturity (Phase 3)		
Start Month	25	End Month	36

Objectives
This WP is focused on supporting the ESFRI operational phase and the setup and operationalisation of the governance structure for the ERIC. It also oversees the release and the first five years of lifecycle management of RI services, ensuring alignment with governance decisions and user needs.

Description
T6.1 ERIC Establishment Support [M25 - M36]. Task leader: CNR; Participants: LUH, ATHENA, UvA, BSC, KCL, SLEX, X-officio Following task 4.1, in this task, the PMB will support the RI's governmental bodies toward the formal submission for the establishment of the SoBigData ERIC, including the election process, engaging national representatives, and formalising governance roles and naming of responsibilities to ensure the planning of the first five years of the RI. T6.2 Services Maintenance [M25 - M36]. Task leader: CNR; Participants: UNIPi, SNS, IMT, UNIVAQ, UNIROMA1, SSSA, UNIBO, UNIPA, LUH, ATHENA, OpenAIRE, UvA, TUDelft, EGI, BSC, URV, UPF, UCM, KCL, REPHRAIN, CSD, DFKI This task will manage released services and keep them updated: this includes defining versioning, deployment cycles, service documentation updates, and maintaining quality assurance processes aligned with community needs, governance oversight, and access rules updates. As part of this task, EGI will support the maintenance and operational availability of the Jupyter Notebook environment (including Galaxy Workflow). T6.3 Finalisation of the Open Infrastructure Monitoring Tools [M25 - M36]. Task Leader OpenAIRE; Participants: CNR, LUH, ATHENA, UvA, BSC, KCL This task will continue the work done in T1.4 and finalise the key indicators in line with ESFRI's success criteria. It will

release a SoBigData-specific dashboard for tracking outputs, usage, impact, and Open Science practices. As reported in Section 2.5.1, the expected output will be a fully operational monitoring framework, based on Open Science principles, enabling SoBigData RI to assess and demonstrate its performance, strategic relevance, and long-term societal impact.

T6.4 Partnerships and Funding Assessment [M25 - M36]. Task Leader CNR; Participants: UNIP, SNS, IMT, UNIVAQ, UNIROMA1, SSSA, UNIBO, UNIPA, LUH, ATHENA, OpenAIRE, UvA, TUDelft, EGI, BSC, URV, UPF, UCM, KCL, REPHRAIN, CSD, DFKI

In this task, the project will review and assess the results achieved in task T4.5 regarding financial provisioning and external engagement. This includes an evaluation of funds secured through collaborations with industry and public bodies, the outcomes of applications to competitive calls, and the effectiveness of research and service promotion activities. Based on this assessment, the task will identify strengths, gaps, and opportunities, revising the financial engagement strategy accordingly. The results will provide the foundation for a forward-looking plan that defines priorities, targets, and approaches to ensure RI sustainability in the operational phase.

STAFF EFFORT

Staff effort per participant <i>Grant Preparation (Work packages - Effort screen) — Enter the info.</i>							
Participant	WP1	WP2	WP3	WP4	WP5	WP6	Total Person-Months
1 - CNR	1.50	6.00	12.50	15.00	2.00	6.40	43.40
2 - UNIP1	0.20	0.30	1.00	2.00	0.20	0.30	4.00
3 - SNS	0.10	0.10	0.20	0.40	0.10	0.10	1.00
4 - IMT	0.10	0.10	0.20	0.40	0.10	0.10	1.00
5 - UNIVAQ	0.10	0.30	1.10	4.00	0.10	0.40	6.00
6 - UNIROMA1	0.10	0.20	0.50	1.70	0.10	0.20	2.80
7 - SSSA	0.10	3.00	1.20	4.50	0.10	1.20	10.10
8 - UNIBO	0.10	0.10	0.20	0.40	0.10	0.10	1.00
9 - UNIPA	0.10	0.10	0.20	0.40	0.10	0.10	1.00
10 - LUH	0.10	0.50	1.00	1.50	0.10	0.50	3.70
11 - ATHENA	0.15	0.50	1.00	2.60	0.15	0.50	4.90
12 - OpenAIRE	0.10	0.40		0.70	0.10	0.70	2.00
13 - UvA	0.15	1.00	1.60	0.70	0.15	0.50	4.10
14 - TUDelft	0.10	0.40	1.00	1.50	0.10	0.40	3.50
15 - EGI	0.10	0.10	0.10	2.10	0.10	0.10	2.60
16 - BSC	0.50	1.50	4.00	5.00	0.20	2.00	13.20
17 - URV	0.10	0.10	0.20	0.40	0.10	0.10	1.00
18 - UPF	0.10	0.10	0.20	0.40	0.10	0.10	1.00
19 - UCM	0.10	0.50	1.20	3.50	0.10	0.50	5.90

Staff effort per participant							
Grant Preparation (Work packages - Effort screen) — Enter the info.							
Participant	WP1	WP2	WP3	WP4	WP5	WP6	Total Person-Months
20 - KCL	0.90	0.90	0.90	0.90	0.90	0.90	5.40
21 - REPHRAIN	0.10	0.10	0.10	1.20	0.10	0.20	1.80
22 - CSD	0.10	0.10		0.40	0.10	0.10	0.80
23 - SLEX	0.10	5.00	1.00	5.10	0.10	5.00	16.30
24 - TOUR4EU	2.50	5.00			5.50	1.00	14.00
25 - X-officio	0.10	1.45		4.70	0.10	1.95	8.30
26 - DFKI	0.10	0.30	1.00	1.40	0.10	0.50	3.40
Total Person-Months	7.80	28.15	30.40	60.90	11.00	23.95	162.20

LIST OF DELIVERABLES

Deliverables <i>Grant Preparation (Deliverables screen) — Enter the info.</i> <i>The labels used mean:</i> <i>Public — fully open (🚩 automatically posted online)</i> <i>Sensitive — limited under the conditions of the Grant Agreement</i> <i>EU classified — RESTREINT-UE/EU-RESTRICTED, CONFIDENTIEL-UE/EU-CONFIDENTIAL, SECRET-UE/EU-SECRET under Decision 2015/444</i>						
Deliverable No	Deliverable Name	Work Package No	Lead Beneficiary	Type	Dissemination Level	Due Date (month)
D1.1	Relevant Board Established	WP1	1 - CNR	R — Document, report	PU - Public	6
D1.2	Stakeholder Engagement Report 1	WP1	24 - TOUR4EU	R — Document, report	PU - Public	18
D1.3	SoBigData IP - Policy Brief 1	WP1	1 - CNR	R — Document, report	SEN - Sensitive	18
D1.4	SoBigData RI - Data management plan 2	WP1	1 - CNR	R — Document, report	PU - Public	18
D1.5	SoBigData RI - Data management plan 1	WP1	1 - CNR	R — Document, report	PU - Public	3
D1.6	Dissemination, exploitation and communication plan 1	WP1	24 - TOUR4EU	R — Document, report	PU - Public	6
D1.7	Dissemination, exploitation and communication plan 2	WP1	24 - TOUR4EU	R — Document, report	PU - Public	18
D2.1	ERIC Statute	WP2	23 - SLEX	R — Document, report	SEN - Sensitive	6
D2.2	ERIC Governance Manual	WP2	23 - SLEX	R — Document, report	SEN - Sensitive	6
D2.3	Access Policy Framework	WP2	1 - CNR	R — Document, report	SEN - Sensitive	6
D2.4	Scientific Case	WP2	1 - CNR	R — Document, report	SEN - Sensitive	6
D2.5	Financial and Budgeting	WP2	25 - X-officio	R — Document, report	SEN - Sensitive	6
D2.6	Service Selection & Catalogue Review	WP2	1 - CNR	R — Document, report	PU - Public	6

Deliverables

Grant Preparation (Deliverables screen) — Enter the info.

The labels used mean:

Public — fully open (🚩 automatically posted online)

Sensitive — limited under the conditions of the Grant Agreement

EU classified — RESTREINT-UE/EU-RESTRICTED, CONFIDENTIEL-UE/EU-CONFIDENTIAL, SECRET-UE/EU-SECRET under Decision [2015/444](#)

Deliverable No	Deliverable Name	Work Package No	Lead Beneficiary	Type	Dissemination Level	Due Date (month)
D3.1	National Node Implementation Report	WP3	1 - CNR	R — Document, report	PU - Public	24
D4.1	User experience & Test Cases Report 1	WP4	1 - CNR	R — Document, report	PU - Public	24
D4.2	Service Deployment & Integration Framework	WP4	1 - CNR	R — Document, report	PU - Public	24
D5.1	Stakeholder Engagement Report 2	WP5	24 - TOUR4EU	R — Document, report	PU - Public	36
D5.2	SoBigData RI - Data management plan 3	WP5	1 - CNR	R — Document, report	PU - Public	36
D5.3	SoBigData IP - Policy Brief 2	WP5	1 - CNR	R — Document, report	SEN - Sensitive	36
D6.1	Service Maintenance & Integration Framework	WP6	1 - CNR	R — Document, report	PU - Public	36
D6.2	Open Infrastructure Monitoring Tools	WP6	12 - OpenAIRE	R — Document, report	PU - Public	36
D6.3	Final report on dissemination, exploitation and communication	WP6	24 - TOUR4EU	R — Document, report	PU - Public	36

Deliverable D1.1 – Relevant Board Established

Deliverable Number	D1.1	Lead Beneficiary	1 - CNR
Deliverable Name	Relevant Board Established		
Type	R — Document, report	Dissemination Level	PU - Public
Due Date (month)	6	Work Package No	WP1

Description
This deliverable reports the definition of the composition and installation of the boards involved in the project's management.

Deliverable D1.2 – Stakeholder Engagement Report 1

Deliverable Number	D1.2	Lead Beneficiary	24 - TOUR4EU
Deliverable Name	Stakeholder Engagement Report 1		
Type	R — Document, report	Dissemination Level	PU - Public
Due Date (month)	18	Work Package No	WP1

Description
This deliverable summarises stakeholder mapping and engagement activities undertaken by the SoBigData RI in the first two phases of the project.

Deliverable D1.3 – SoBigData IP - Policy Brief 1

Deliverable Number	D1.3	Lead Beneficiary	1 - CNR
Deliverable Name	SoBigData IP - Policy Brief 1		
Type	R — Document, report	Dissemination Level	SEN - Sensitive
Due Date (month)	18	Work Package No	WP1

Description
This document outlines how SoBigData IP creates a clear, impactful policy brief to inform policy for the project's first reporting period.

Deliverable D1.4 – SoBigData RI - Data management plan 2

Deliverable Number	D1.4	Lead Beneficiary	1 - CNR
Deliverable Name	SoBigData RI - Data management plan 2		
Type	R — Document, report	Dissemination Level	PU - Public
Due Date (month)	18	Work Package No	WP1

Description
This deliverable updates the strategies and procedures for managing research data generated, processed, and preserved within SoBigData RI.

Deliverable D1.5 – SoBigData RI - Data management plan 1

Deliverable Number	D1.5	Lead Beneficiary	1 - CNR
Deliverable Name	SoBigData RI - Data management plan 1		
Type	R — Document, report	Dissemination Level	PU - Public
Due Date (month)	3	Work Package No	WP1

Description
This deliverable outlines the strategies and procedures for managing research data generated, processed, and preserved within SoBigData RI.

Deliverable D1.6 – Dissemination, exploitation and communication plan 1

Deliverable Number	D1.6	Lead Beneficiary	24 - TOUR4EU
Deliverable Name	Dissemination, exploitation and communication plan 1		
Type	R — Document, report	Dissemination Level	PU - Public
Due Date (month)	6	Work Package No	WP1

Description
The plan concerns the activity and aligns with the project's dissemination, exploitation and communication goals, taking into account available opportunities. It also includes provisional planning for the following period and a description of the communication material created up to M6.

Deliverable D1.7 – Dissemination, exploitation and communication plan 2

Deliverable Number	D1.7	Lead Beneficiary	24 - TOUR4EU
Deliverable Name	Dissemination, exploitation and communication plan 2		
Type	R — Document, report	Dissemination Level	PU - Public
Due Date (month)	18	Work Package No	WP1

Description
The document updates the plan concerns the activity and aligns with the project's dissemination, exploitation and communication goals, taking into account available opportunities. It also includes provisional planning for the second period and a description of the communication material created up to M18.

Deliverable D2.1 – ERIC Statute

Deliverable Number	D2.1	Lead Beneficiary	23 - SLEX
Deliverable Name	ERIC Statute		
Type	R — Document, report	Dissemination Level	SEN - Sensitive
Due Date (month)	6	Work Package No	WP2

Description

This document reports the first version of the SoBigData ERIC statute.

Deliverable D2.2 – ERIC Governance Manual

Deliverable Number	D2.2	Lead Beneficiary	23 - SLEX
Deliverable Name	ERIC Governance Manual		
Type	R — Document, report	Dissemination Level	SEN - Sensitive
Due Date (month)	6	Work Package No	WP2

Description

This document reports the first version of the SoBigData ERIC governance.

Deliverable D2.3 – Access Policy Framework

Deliverable Number	D2.3	Lead Beneficiary	1 - CNR
Deliverable Name	Access Policy Framework		
Type	R — Document, report	Dissemination Level	SEN - Sensitive
Due Date (month)	6	Work Package No	WP2

Description

This document reports the initial version of the SoBigData RI access policy.

Deliverable D2.4 – Scientific Case

Deliverable Number	D2.4	Lead Beneficiary	1 - CNR
Deliverable Name	Scientific Case		
Type	R — Document, report	Dissemination Level	SEN - Sensitive
Due Date (month)	6	Work Package No	WP2

Description

This document reports the initial version of the scientific aspects concerning the SoBigData RI.

Deliverable D2.5 – Financial and Budgeting

Deliverable Number	D2.5	Lead Beneficiary	25 - X-officio
Deliverable Name	Financial and Budgeting		
Type	R — Document, report	Dissemination Level	SEN - Sensitive
Due Date (month)	6	Work Package No	WP2

Description

This document reports the first version of the SoBigData ERIC financial aspects.

Deliverable D2.6 – Service Selection & Catalogue Review

Deliverable Number	D2.6	Lead Beneficiary	1 - CNR
Deliverable Name	Service Selection & Catalogue Review		
Type	R — Document, report	Dissemination Level	PU - Public
Due Date (month)	6	Work Package No	WP2

Description

This deliverable reports the current selected services and the review of the catalogue metadata and features.

Deliverable D3.1 – National Node Implementation Report

Deliverable Number	D3.1	Lead Beneficiary	1 - CNR
Deliverable Name	National Node Implementation Report		
Type	R — Document, report	Dissemination Level	PU - Public
Due Date (month)	24	Work Package No	WP3

Description

This deliverable reports the implementation of each national node, institutional coordination, compliance with national laws, and alignment with the SoBigData RI structure.

Deliverable D4.1 – User experience & Test Cases Report 1

Deliverable Number	D4.1	Lead Beneficiary	1 - CNR
Deliverable Name	User experience & Test Cases Report 1		
Type	R — Document, report	Dissemination Level	PU - Public
Due Date (month)	24	Work Package No	WP4

Description

This deliverable reports the user experience improvements and test cases' results in using RI features and services.

Deliverable D4.2 – Service Deployment & Integration Framework

Deliverable Number	D4.2	Lead Beneficiary	1 - CNR
Deliverable Name	Service Deployment & Integration Framework		
Type	R — Document, report	Dissemination Level	PU - Public
Due Date (month)	24	Work Package No	WP4

Description

This deliverable reports the service implementation, including deployment procedures, technical specifications, and accessibility setup. It will describe the configuration of systems, compliance with interoperability and security standards, and EOSC synchronisation and resource mapping.

Deliverable D5.1 – Stakeholder Engagement Report 2

Deliverable Number	D5.1	Lead Beneficiary	24 - TOUR4EU
Deliverable Name	Stakeholder Engagement Report 2		
Type	R — Document, report	Dissemination Level	PU - Public
Due Date (month)	36	Work Package No	WP5

Description
This document summarises stakeholder mapping and engagement activities undertaken by the SoBigData RI in the last phase of the project, and it also includes the RI's long-term plan for stakeholder engagement.

Deliverable D5.2 – SoBigData RI - Data management plan 3

Deliverable Number	D5.2	Lead Beneficiary	1 - CNR
Deliverable Name	SoBigData RI - Data management plan 3		
Type	R — Document, report	Dissemination Level	PU - Public
Due Date (month)	36	Work Package No	WP5

Description
This deliverable updates the strategies and procedures for managing research data generated, processed, and preserved within SoBigData RI.

Deliverable D5.3 – SoBigData IP - Policy Brief 2

Deliverable Number	D5.3	Lead Beneficiary	1 - CNR
Deliverable Name	SoBigData IP - Policy Brief 2		
Type	R — Document, report	Dissemination Level	SEN - Sensitive
Due Date (month)	36	Work Package No	WP5

Description
This document outlines how SoBigData IP creates a clear, impactful policy brief to inform policy for the project's second reporting period.

Deliverable D6.1 – Service Maintenance & Integration Framework

Deliverable Number	D6.1	Lead Beneficiary	1 - CNR
Deliverable Name	Service Maintenance & Integration Framework		
Type	R — Document, report	Dissemination Level	PU - Public
Due Date (month)	36	Work Package No	WP6

Description
This deliverable reports the service maintenance. It will describe the service documentation, configuration of systems, compliance with interoperability and security standards, EOSC synchronisation and resource mapping.

Deliverable D6.2 – Open Infrastructure Monitoring Tools

Deliverable Number	D6.2	Lead Beneficiary	12 - OpenAIRE
Deliverable Name	Open Infrastructure Monitoring Tools		
Type	R — Document, report	Dissemination Level	PU - Public
Due Date (month)	36	Work Package No	WP6

Description

Reports on service implementation, including deployment procedures, technical specifications, and accessibility setup. The report will also include the testing outcomes with early adopters, detailing use case execution, user feedback, identified issues, and proposed improvements.

Deliverable D6.3 – Final report on dissemination, exploitation and communication

Deliverable Number	D6.3	Lead Beneficiary	24 - TOUR4EU
Deliverable Name	Final report on dissemination, exploitation and communication		
Type	R — Document, report	Dissemination Level	PU - Public
Due Date (month)	36	Work Package No	WP6

Description

The final report includes a summary of actions taken and an analysis of key achievements in dissemination, exploitation and communication. The document includes the dissemination and exploitation activities that the SoBigData RI plans to implement over a period of up to 4 years after the end of the project.

LIST OF MILESTONES

Milestones <i>Grant Preparation (Milestones screen) — Enter the info.</i>					
Milestone No	Milestone Name	Work Package No	Lead Beneficiary	Means of Verification	Due Date (month)
1	Initialization	WP2	1 - CNR	Kick-off meeting organised; all project advisory bodies established; first version of the relevant documents required for the ERIC submission prepared.	6
2	Consultation	WP4	1 - CNR	Finalisation of all required documents to be sent to the Italian MUR; report on the status of ERIC submission procedure.	24
3	Advancement	WP4, WP3	1 - CNR	Service implementation and provision status; validation of service usability and robustness; user experience improvements and accessibility measures.	24
4	Finalisation	WP5, WP6	1 - CNR	Final service implementation and provision status: All key outputs and all project objectives reached.	36

LIST OF CRITICAL RISKS

Critical risks & risk management strategy			
Grant Preparation (Critical Risks screen) — Enter the info.			
Risk number	Description	Work Package No(s)	Proposed Mitigation Measures
1	Scientific Risks - Recruiting and/or retaining skilled staff: Lack of highly specialised staff. Likelihood: 2/5 Severity: Medium	WP1	Consortium partners are attractive workplaces, and staff are motivated. Recruitment strategies are aligned with excellence standards, offering competitive salaries and benefits.
2	Technological Risks - Hardship in access to volumes of open data: Difficulties in accessing and sharing data. Likelihood: 1/5 Severity: High	WP4, WP2, WP6	Evaluation and regulation of access types (VA, TNA, RA) with sustainable service design, including Intellectual property and dataset licensing. Degree in place: Technical and organisational measures are included in service design, with the monitoring of shared data volume.
3	Strategic maintenance of resources: the technological infrastructure is becoming outdated. This aspect includes obsolescence and hardware/software upgrades, cyber attacks and data breaches, outages on HPC nodes or network, and a lack of key competencies. Likelihood: 1/5 Severity: High	WP4, WP6	Continuous monitoring of emerging technologies, yearly budget allocation for upgrades, and dynamic business model development. Degree in place: Maintenance strategies are planned, with budget monitoring and vulnerability detection.
4	Insufficient funding - failure to secure sustainable funding commitments. Likelihood: 2/5 Severity: High	WP3	Negotiation strategies, dedicated fund preparation, downsizing activities, and seeking further funds. Degree in place: Funding strategies are actively managed, with budget monitoring reports every 6 months.
5	Political support - changes in the political environment affecting support. Likelihood: 2/5 Severity: High	WP4, WP2, WP6	Close contact with national governments, monitoring political developments, and designing stakeholder engagement strategies. Degree in place: The governance structure maintains close contact with governments by monitoring funding opportunities.
6	Financial Risks - slow negotiations with funding bodies: Delays in securing long-term financial commitments, coordination among multi-disciplinary partners, transition to ERIC, and	WP4, WP2, WP6	Timely involvement of the Board of Governmental Representatives, aligning negotiation strategies with national funding streams. Degree in place: Negotiation strategies are integrated into governance, with monitoring of funding opportunities.

Critical risks & risk management strategy <i>Grant Preparation (Critical Risks screen) — Enter the info.</i>			
Risk number	Description	Work Package No(s)	Proposed Mitigation Measures
	international governance changes and updates to EU Regulations. Likelihood: 3/5 Severity: Low		
7	Intellectual Property Rights (IPRs) and ethical legal matters Legal protection of data and datasets. Likelihood: 1/5 Severity: Medium	WP4, WP6	Ethical-legal compliance integrated into research activities, a responsible approach by design and default, and continuous training. Degree in place: Compliance measures are actively managed, monitoring claims and services provided.
8	Health emergencies, wars, or massive cyber-attacks - Impact of force majeure conditions. Likelihood: 2/5 Severity: High	WP5, WP1	Management of international crises, alternative solutions for meetings and events, and monitoring pandemic evolution. Degree in place: Crisis management strategies are in place, with monitoring of services to be blocked or suspended.
9	Conflict of interest Tension between ethical requirements and service development. Likelihood: 1/5 Severity: Low	WP5, WP1	Conflict of interest management within the statute includes declarations of the absence of conflict of interest. Degree in place: Conflict management strategies are integrated into governance, with monitoring of declarations.
10	Image damage, inadequate communication of goals, ethical values, and results, and difficulties in communicating the offer. Likelihood: 1/5 Severity: Low	WP5, WP1	Incident response procedures, timely stakeholder communication, security measures, and advanced encryption. Degree in place: Transparent and targeted communication strategies, regular publication of results, awareness campaigns on ethical values, and active involvement of stakeholders. Development of simple-language dissemination materials, targeted information campaigns.

PROJECT REVIEWS

Project Reviews			
Grant Preparation (Reviews screen) — Enter the info.			
Review No	Timing (month)	Location	Comments
RV1	18		
RV2	36		

DESCRIPTION OF THE ACTION (PART B)

'HISTORY OF CHANGES' Table

Grant Preparation

Part A		
date	Page/section	Nature of change and reason/justification of change proposed (if applicable)
18/02/2026		Added three deliverables related to “policy briefs” at the end of each reporting period
18/02/2026		Added two deliverables related to data management plan - M18 and M36
18/02/2026		Added two deliverables related to communication, result exploitation and dissemination - M9 and M36
22/02/2026		Updated duration and the task description of WP1 and WP5 in accordance with the new reporting periods
22/02/2026		Updated the WP1 and WP5 deliverable deadlines in accordance with the new duration of the WPs
27/02/2026		Updated the effort in accordance with the new duration of the WPs
11/03/2026		- Added DFKI as new beneficiary - Updated the description of tasks with the new partner DFKI
12/02/2026		Updated the budget - The budget for (BE2 (22%), BE3 (15%), BE6 (30%), BE9 (26%), BE11 (11%), BE12 (11%), BE13 (50%), BE14 (24%), BE15 (10%), BE17 (23%), BE18 (33%), BE20 (29%), BE22 (12%), BE25 (19%)) has been updated implementing the ESR recommendations for the reduction of personnel costs. - The budget for BE10 LUH has been shifted to to accommodate the budget for the newly added beneficiary (BEN 26 DFKI). The DFKI will work together with ben LUH already in the consortium for the formation of the German node. The new beneficiary is needed to strengthen the number of institutions supporting the creation of the node required by the German ministry. - Rebalanced the budget between WP1 and WP5 due to the changed duration of the two WPs. The rebalanced involved: BE1, BE4, BE5, BE7, BE21. - Corrected a mistake for BE1, BE5, BE7, BE13 moved Travel costs from WP6 to WP5 and balanced between WP1 and WP5 due to change in WPs durations. - Balanced travel costs between WP1 and WP5 due to change in WPs durations for BE2, BE4, BE6, BE10, BE11, BE15, BE16, BE21, B25.

19/03/2026		Updated deadline and description D4.3. Due to the change of the deadline the document was moved in WP1 becoming D1.6
19/03/2026		Added new deliverable D1.7 - Dissemination, exploitation and communication plan 2 at M18 as required by EC Rules.
19/03/2026		Policy brief deliverables updated as "SEN".
19/03/2026		Updated the description of D6.3 Final report on dissemination, exploitation and communication as required by EC Rules.
19/03/2026		Added missing participating people as researchers into EC portal. Dr. Tom Emery is related to Odissei RI and he does not belong to any of the partners involved into the project.
26/03/2026		The original PMs allocated to BEN 10 LUH was 7,5. The introduction of BEN 26 DFKI implied a different allocation of the original PMs (also considering the different unitary PM costs among the two partners). New allocation is BEN 10 LUH: 3,7 and BEN 26 DFKI: 3,4. This minor reduction of 0.4 PMs will not jeopardise the project implementation.
26/03/2026		The change of duration of WP1 (from 24 to 18 months) and WP5 (from 12 to 18 months) required a small revision of the original effort (and costs). The WP1 passed from 8PMs to 7,80 while WP5 passed from 10,70 to 11. There is also a change in WP2 -0,2PM, WP3 -0.2PM and WP4 -0,1PM. The small differences in the total of WP1-WP5 and the ones introduced for WP2, WP3 and WP4 are due by the introduction of BEN 26 DFKI. These differences will not imply any negative effects in the project implementation.
30/03/2026		- For BEN 01 CNR total cost reduction of EUR 6212.61 (from personnel costs) to release budget for covering the travel costs of the newly added BEN 26 DFKI. Changed the effort distribution among senior and junior staff for WP1, WP5, and WP6. Total effort remained unchanged. This amount is mainly used to cover the travel costs of BEN 26 DFKI (from BE1 personnel to BE26 travel). This change is required to ensure that BE26 can effectively contribute to project in-person meetings and events and will not imply any negative effects in the project implementation for BEN 01 CNR.
17/04/2026		Budget updated due to BEN 25 X-officio and REA management about X-officio involvement in different grants. Breakdown of personnel effort is as follows: - Markus Pasterk total 0.5PM (only for year 2026) - New employee total 5.8PM: 1PM (2026), 2PM (2027), 2.8PM (2028) - Ohad Graber-Soudry total 2PM (only for year 2029) / SME Owner The total effort remained the same.

		The overall budget for BEN25 X-officio is: WP1: 7,181.25 €; WP2: 13,503.13 €; WP3: 0.00 €; WP4: 43,768.75 €; WP5: 6,773.86 €; WP6: 26,646.14 €; Tot: 97,873.13 €
24/04/2026		Updated the BEN25 X-officio PMs distribution along the WPs considering the new breakdown of the personnel effort. After a meeting with the Coordinator, X-officio confirmed that the work is now distributed correctly over the entire project's lifetime (and compliant with X-officio - REA agreement). The original scheduling was a misallocation of the effort, since it foresaw to allocate 7.5 PMs, the 90% of the X-officio effort, in the first six months of the project. The X-officio role does not change compared to proposal stage. This updating implies a shifting of PMs from WP2 to WP4 and WP6 and will not imply any negative effects in the project implementation. The new effort distribution for BEN25 X-officio is: WP1: 0.10; WP2: 1.45; WP3: 0.00; WP4: 4.70; WP5: 0.10; WP6:1.95; Tot: 8.30 PMs

Part B		
date	Page/section	Nature of change and reason/justification of change proposed (if applicable)
12/02/2026	All document	Created DESCRIPTION OF THE ACTION (PART B) following the rules of the template
16/02/2026	Section 4	Added Section 4 - taken from the proposal part A
22/02/2026	Section 3	- Corrected the number of the expected reporting periods. From 3 (M12, M24, M36) to 2 (M18, M36) - Updated <i>Figure 3.1.2 SoBigData IP Gantt</i> in accordance with the new duration of WP1 and WP5 based on the new reporting periods
11/03/2026	Section 4	Updated Section 4
11/03/2026	Section 2.5.1	Corrected the KPIs as requested by the evaluation letter
18/03/2026	All the doc	Checked and corrected the number of beneficiaries
19/03/2026	Section 2.5.1	Restored the original value (erroneously changed) for the KPI: Average Number of accesses to SoBigData Lab & Service per month: 500
19/03/2026	Section 3	Added Table 3.1g 'Subcontracting cost item' declaring No

		subcontracting is foreseen in the project
19/03/2026	Section 3	- The KPI for the phase 3 “number of new services deployed:5” has been corrected as suggested by the review since in the proposal was not quantified. This is related to phase 2 KPI: “number of services to be deployed in phase 3: 5”. In phase 2, we plan to deploy at least 5 new services, that should be deployed in phase 3. - Corrected the KPI “Number of services to be deployed after the end of the project: 15”



SoBigData IP: SoBigData Implementation Phase

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1. Excellence

SoBigData RI (<https://sobigdata.eu/>) is a pan-European research infrastructure focused on social mining and big data analytics. It provides an open and collaborative environment where academic researchers from computer science, social sciences, humanities, and related fields, along with other stakeholders, can access advanced tools and methodologies. SoBigData, organised as a distributed research infrastructure comprising national nodes, integrates heterogeneous data sources with robust computational resources, enabling the extraction of insights in compliance with an ethical approach and adhering to EU data protection legislation¹. Its mission is to support scientific research, evidence-based policymaking, and industrial innovation. Principles of openness and collaboration guide the engagement strategy, implemented through the pooling of resources, facilities, equipment, data, and expertise across Europe. This coordinated approach increases efficiency, promotes knowledge exchange, and enhances impact.

SoBigData RI builds on the assets and expertise of its participating institutions, ensuring activities are adapted to specific national contexts. By leveraging institutional competencies and supporting national collaborations, the research infrastructure creates a sustainable ecosystem that reflects the diversity of its members. Objectives and services that are currently provided and will be provided in the future align with national roadmaps, ensuring that each node's development is consistent with national and European priorities.

Stakeholder participation is actively promoted, engaging both established organisations and new entrants in the research and innovation landscape. National-level events are organised to present SoBigData's services, demonstrate impact, and extend the reach of each national node. The overall strategy is designed to maintain an active and resilient stakeholder community committed to the long-term development of the SoBigData RI. This approach is shared by the six countries preparing to join the step-1 SoBigData ERIC application: Italy, Germany, Greece, Spain, the Netherlands, and the UK (along with Bulgaria, which is expected to participate in the RI as observer).

1.1 Objectives

SoBigData RI's mission remains to become a leading European reference point for ethical and responsible big data analytics, focusing on creating societal impact and promoting open science and FAIR (Findable, Accessible, Interoperable, Reusable) principles. SoBigData RI strives to upgrade its technical backbone continuously and embed best practices in data management, security, and ethical governance. Its commitment to excellence ensures the quality of its services and responsiveness to emerging research topics. SoBigData RI's focus is to leverage responsible data science, AI and computational social science to tackle major societal challenges, supporting research and policy-making across diverse domains aligned with Horizon Europe Pillar II clusters². SoBigData RI's preparatory phase project produced new insights that have contributed to its technical framework's robustness and innovative potential³. The RI's cloud-based services and delivery model have been validated at scale with an increasing number of invocations. Extensive pilot experiments have demonstrated that the infrastructure can efficiently handle massive workloads and complex algorithmic processes, ensuring high reliability even under peak operational conditions. Starting from this solid technological base, the RI's next phase will focus on following this trend, in order to guarantee its future sustainability and improve user access aspects to deliver its services to a broader audience. Hence, we are listing three specific objectives which will guide the activities of the project:

¹ https://commission.europa.eu/law/law-topic/data-protection/legal-framework-eu-data-protection_en

² https://research-and-innovation.ec.europa.eu/funding/fundingopportunitiesfunding-programmes-and-open-calls/horizon-europe/horizon-europe-work-programmes_en

³ SoBigData RI PPP public deliverables: <https://data.d4science.net/hpPaf>

Objective 1 - User Strategy, Access Policy and Engagement: The first objective is to enhance SoBigData RI's user experience by making its resources, services, and tools easier to access, navigate, and use effectively. Building on a well-established access policy that already guarantees transparency, fairness, sustainability, and compliance with ethical, legal, and open science principles, the focus will shift to improving usability, simplicity, and responsiveness to user needs. At the same time, this objective aims to deepen engagement with diverse communities, including researchers, innovators, policymakers, industry actors, and citizens, through tailored opportunities for participation, collaboration, and co-creation. Particular attention will be given to fostering dialogue, collaboration, and cooperation with industry to support innovation and data-driven value creation, as well as with policymakers to provide evidence-based insights and strengthen the role of SoBigData RI in shaping responsible and impactful data policies. By combining improved interfaces and support services with targeted engagement strategies, this objective seeks to establish a user-centered and inclusive ecosystem that maximises the scientific, societal, and policy impact of SoBigData RI. The process will entail the development or improvement of services that align with the research infrastructure's goals and user needs and are based on negotiations with the Board of Governmental Representatives (BGR). During the preparation phase, the consortium selected several services distributed from the first set of member states which will participate in the ERIC establishment process. Finally, the different types of access to the RI, i.e., Transnational Access (TNA) and Virtual Access (VA), will be consolidated, and the policies for Remote Access (RA) will be implemented.

Objective 2 - Pan-European Relevance: The second objective is to strengthen the pan-European relevance of SoBigData RI by consolidating its role as a distributed research infrastructure that integrates resources, expertise, and services from its European nodes into a coherent and accessible ecosystem. This objective emphasises the alignment with the European Open Science Cloud (EOSC) and active contribution to the development of European Data Spaces, ensuring that SoBigData RI supports the principles of open science, FAIR data, and trustworthy AI. By fostering interoperability with other European research infrastructures and facilitating cross-border access to data, tools, and methodologies, SoBigData RI will promote collaboration among European researchers, public bodies and industries. Through this integration and alignment, the infrastructure will enhance Europe's scientific capacity, support innovation, and contribute to evidence-based policymaking while reinforcing its position in the European data and research landscape.

Objective 3 - Legal status and sustainability of the SoBigData ERIC: This objective involves several critical steps to ensure its long-term sustainability and compliance with European regulations. BGR will comprise a political representative and scientific representative from each national node, and will play a pivotal role in this process, overseeing the governance, legal framework, financial principles, and business plan for the future ERIC. The BGR is tasked with approving the legal model, governance structure, and financial plan, as well as appointing the General Director. The BGR will act as the predecessor of the ERIC's decision-making body. The RI's alignment with the ESFRI Roadmap 2021 and its transition to ERIC status solidify its role as a leading research infrastructure in Europe. The SoBigData-IP Management Team will support the BGR in the process of becoming an ERIC. This objective will include the consolidation of the RI's financial plan, designed to provide a stable and sustainable financial foundation for the SoBigData ERIC.

1.2 Coordination and/or support measures and methodology

The SoBigData IP project will act on the abovementioned objectives to advance the RI's status towards the future SoBigData ERIC. SoBigData will be organised as a distributed RI composed of national nodes. Its structure will include VREs providing access to datasets and tools; thematic research suites built on the existing research spaces; services such as TNA and RA; training

activities; and support for interdisciplinary research. Activities will be designed to support academic research, industry innovation, consulting towards civil society, and policymakers.

SoBigData RI is set to commence this implementation phase with a solid background regarding its:

- **Existing technological structure** - The SoBigData RI's backbone is a robust, distributed, and scalable e-infrastructure already serving more than 14,000 registered users and an average of 1 million service invocations per month;
- **DIGIT and SSH (Social Science and Humanities) services** – The SoBigData RI currently integrates advanced interoperable DIGITAL services (JupyterHub, Galaxy Workflow, Cloud Computing Platform, Catalogue, VREs) implementing FAIR and Open Science principles along with over 100 specialized software services (SSH libraries, methods and applications) that are designed to support and assist research at each stage of its lifecycle.
- **Scientific excellence and social impact** – SoBigData RI, through its vast European network of excellence, addresses major societal challenges such as AI explainability, misinformation, sustainability, disaster response, and AI in health. This track record is reinforced by user feedback, statistics, and a high-impact scientific output in terms of publications and outreach.

1.2.1 Governance

The SoBigData RI is currently coordinated by a management team of individuals affiliated with CNR. The RI's management team (MT) comprises: Dr. Roberto Trasarti (scientific coordinator), Dr. Valerio Grossi (project manager), and Dr. Michela Natilli (infrastructure manager). The management team is supported by Dr. Pasquale Pagano and Dr. Massimiliano Assante, the RI's technological leaders, who are in charge of its technological infrastructure, D4Science (www.d4science.org). The management team's work is carried out alongside PIs of the various institutions that comprise SoBigData nodes, each representing a specific expertise in a diverse set of technical and scientific domains. To date, the MT has directly reported to the assembly of participants in the project. At this stage, the SoBigData IP will focus on implementing the governance structure of the future SoBigData RI.

At proposal submission, SoBigData is actively forming a BGR (delegates from Italy, Greece, the Netherlands, Spain, and the UK have been invited by the Italian Ministry for Universities and Research - MUR) that is expected to evolve into the GA in the future ERIC. The established BGR will accompany the RI's evolution process until the ERIC is established as a legal entity. Furthermore, during the implementation phase, the RI will continue to explore the possibility of extending the current founding countries' list.

The current governance structure and the BGR will facilitate the transition toward the future Board of Directors (BoD), which will be part of the SoBigData ERIC. This main operational body will support decisions taken within the General Assembly (GA). The GA will be the highest-level decision-making authority within the future SoBigData ERIC. The GA will comprise political representatives along with scientific ones from each Member and Observer, ensuring a broad representation of all participating countries and institutions.

The GA will be tasked to define the ERIC's strategic vision, approve the annual budget and financial reports, appoint and dismiss the Board of Directors (BoD) and the General Director, decide on Statute amendments, and handle admission and withdrawal of Members and Observers. The GA will also be in charge of ensuring compliance with ERIC regulations and other legal frameworks. The BoD will be the executive body of the SoBigData ERIC and will be responsible for overseeing both management and implementation of strategic decisions defined within the GA.

The General Director will lead the BoD and will be supported by the Infrastructure Manager, who will act as deputy director and assist in operational duties. To date, the expected Governance

structure envisages other roles to complement the larger set of responsibilities embroiled to the BoD to steer the ERIC's management. Moreover, other relevant advisory and operational bodies are envisaged to assist the BoD in fulfilling the ERIC's mission. These bodies will also strengthen the engagement of SoBigData RI's user community and relevant stakeholders in defining its priorities and services. A key component of this strategy is to reinforce strong links with both the private sector and public bodies, promoting responsible innovation and leveraging data science to address societal challenges.

1.2.2 Financial Strategy and Sustainability

As a result of the SoBigData RI PPP, SoBigData RI will be based on a mixed funding model. It will combine national contributions, competitive European funding mechanisms such as Horizon Europe, and an albeit limited revenue stream generated by services such as training and consulting. In SoBigData IP, the consortium is agreeing to provide in-kind contributions in terms of human and technical resources to integrate and deploy services (in order to adapt to the challenges represented by the budget, which is meant to sustain only partially the activities required to become operational). The various partner institutions will act as active SoBigData representatives and will work to obtain resources for RI development. As in the past, the RI relied on competitive funding, and now it has reached a point of development where it can serve a diverse range of communities and consortia. Thus, SoBigData RI is now involved in multiple project proposals and is also a service provider for data management, cloud computing, and AI tools. This represents an important funding source and promotes the RI's development according to European research objectives.

Another funding source will originate from the agreement consolidation with national bodies (a process which is already yielding its first results). Moreover, the RI is also funded by *Fondo ordinario per gli enti e le istituzioni di ricerca (FOE)*⁴, a fund set up by the Italian university and research ministry (MUR)⁵, as "ERIC to be" which guarantees additional basic funds to the central hub during the implementation phase. Finally, a limited amount of funds will be generated by services such as training and consulting through ad-hoc agreements with industrial and governmental stakeholders. This mixed funding system will sustain the implementation phase and will be managed in a flexible way to adapt to changes to design a consolidated strategy for funding procurement, developing a step-by-step plan moving from the implementation to the full operational status.

SoBigData IP will integrate this model into the future sustainability of SoBigData ERIC. Exploiting the work done in SoBigData RI PPP, the RI has already identified and initially quantified the main elements of expenditure, considering both fixed and variable costs. The expected funding sources will lay out in detail the range of available and economic resources, with a specific focus on revenue diversification. Specific attention will be devoted to relevant aspects such as the costs for: *Governance Personnel* (at least essential to cover the costs associated with the management roles needed for the ERIC's governance); *Node-based Staff and Research* (technical and administrative staff as well as researchers that will contribute their specialised skills within each node of the RI); *Infrastructural and Operational costs* (connected with the maintenance and upgrade of the technological infrastructure); *Training and Events* (organised to ensure that the internal workforce will be continuously updated and to foster external communities and stakeholder engagement); *Service implementation, deployment, and maintenance*; *Insurance*; *Unexpected costs*⁶.

Moreover, SoBigData RI has developed a budget simulation as output of the SoBigData RI PPP, which includes the current six nodes engaged within the ERIC negotiations. The Budget simulation compares different scenarios of sustainability and economic stability, assessing the impact of the future transition to the ERIC framework. This analysis will provide key decision-making elements

⁴ Decreto ministeriale per il riparto del Fondo ordinario per gli enti e le istituzioni di ricerca per l'anno 2025 - <https://www.senato.it/service/PDF/PDFServer/DF/443329.pdf>

⁵ Ministero dell'Università e della Ricerca: <https://www.mur.gov.it/>

⁶ see WP9 - SoBigData RI PPP deliverables - <https://data.d4science.net/hpPaf>

that will ensure that the SoBigData RI will be able to maintain its efficiency and adaptability in an evolving scientific, technological, and economic environment. This projection will be evaluated and adjusted according to the BGR negotiations in order to be approved.

1.2.3 Technological framework

While the current computational and storage capacities are substantial, they are planned for significant expansion during the implementation phase. The core infrastructure currently operates with 4,376 cores. It also federates three external nodes, adding another 1,950 cores for a total of 6,326 cores. Moreover, the e-infrastructure is equipped with 24 high-performance NVIDIA A100 GPUs dedicated to accelerating machine learning, deep learning, and data-intensive computational tasks. The current storage capacity is 1,395 TB, and the infrastructure has 25 TB of RAM, with an additional 2.5 TB from the three federated nodes. Thus, the RI's capacities are on a clear growth trajectory. When the new data center founded by the national project SoBigData.it (<https://pnrr.sobigdata.it/> - National Recovery and Resilience Plan project) becomes operational in 2026, the capacity is projected to increase to 10,396 cores, 2,177 TB of storage, and 77 TB of RAM.

Operationally, the platform has sustained an average of over 2,100 sessions per month over the last 30 months, with registered peaks of 8,000 sessions in a single month. This very relevant and consistent usage demonstrates the platform's reliability and its ability to handle significant and fluctuating demand. Furthermore, the global reach is substantial, with users from 141 different countries and more than 2,000 cities actively using the infrastructure. This widespread adoption is supported by the fact that over 14,000 registered users exploit the SoBigData RI. The platform's scalability and reliability are proven by the management of around 1 million invocations each month over the last 30 months, with a managed peak of 224 million invocations in a single month. This ability to handle massive computational loads proves that the architecture is a fully functional and scalable system designed for real-world, large-scale research. These statistics are reported in the SoBigData++ final report and the SoBigData++ deliverable D7.4 - Periodic and Assessment Report on VA Activities ⁴⁷.

1.2.4 User Strategy and Access Policy

SoBigData RI is consolidating its community, attracting new users and stakeholders through a combination of dissemination strategies, targeted training initiatives, and continuous engagement of potential stakeholders, such as public bodies and industries. Data regarding usage and access (mentioned in the previous section) demonstrate that the current service offering attracts a significant and growing number of users. Service evolution has been continuous in quantity and quality-wise since 2021, as shown in the periodic deliverables of the SoBigData++ project and validated by a constant increase in users over the years. Hence, the IP project will implement a new type of access, called Remote Access (RA). RA will adopt the TNA approach in a remote setting: the user will submit a request to execute a project or a set of experiments entirely remotely. Alongside access provision, the RI is currently adopting and will continue to adopt flexible solutions in the future, including in-person, remote, online, and hybrid events. SoBigData RI has accrued consistent experience in event organisation. Historically, events have proven to be capable of engaging a multidisciplinary community of users and stakeholders.

The SoBigData RI website (www.sobigdata.eu) is designed to engage users and consolidate the RI's position as an essential resource for responsible data science, big data, and AI research in Europe. Other dissemination activities include content creation designed for online fruition, such as tutorial videos, interviews, social media posts, and the RI magazine (<https://sobigdata.eu/magazine>) on diverse platforms regarding research activities and event organisation.

⁴⁷ <https://data.d4science.net/U8fZ>

Due to the nature of the RI, SoBigData's user strategy will be based on a mixed approach to identifying, engaging, and retaining users by aligning their needs with SoBigData's offering. This offering will grow with the future SoBigData ERIC and include business-oriented services and tools. The RI will also focus on improving user experience during the implementation phase. This improvement will be based on a strategy of diversification of service provision, simplified access, engagement intensification, and pursuit of long-term satisfaction and user retention.

Aligned with these activities, SoBigData is enhancing its community by collaborating with other research projects, providing data management, storage services, and computational resources. Currently, the RI catalogue is used by the FAIR project (<https://fondazione-fair.it/en/>) and PRESERVE (<https://www.preserve-h2020.eu/>) as a catalogue repository and service provision. Other projects such as ITSEER (<https://www.itseer.it/>), Blue Cloud 2026 (<https://www.blue-cloud.org/>), and Software Heritage (<https://www.softwareheritage.org/>) use RI facilities, such as the SoBigData lab, to support their analytical method development, storing and sharing protected results.

2. Impact

Throughout the preparatory phase project (and the SoBigData++ Project), the SoBigData RI demonstrated a strong ability to foster an open research and innovation culture, attracting new users and innovation-oriented experiments co-designed with businesses, industries, and public entities. SoBigData RI currently contributes, and will contribute to tackling major societal challenges by leveraging responsible data science, AI, and computational social science to support research and policy-making across topics aligned with Horizon Europe Pillar II clusters⁸.

In *Health*, SoBigData is actively tackling disease diffusion by enabling advanced data analytics for early diagnosis, precision medicine, and public health monitoring. SoBigData enhances healthcare access by supporting the digital transformation of healthcare systems through secure data-sharing and AI-driven decision-making. Using new technologies, SoBigData advances AI and big data analytics to personalise treatments and improve outcomes. In *Culture, Creativity, and Inclusive Society*, SoBigData strengthens democracy and governance by analysing online discourse, misinformation, and public sentiment. It also studies social and economic transformations through digitalisation's impact on education and inequalities to inform inclusive policies. In *Civil Security*, the RI enhances disaster resilience by applying AI to predict and mitigate natural disasters, pandemics, and cyber threats. Its models support emergency response by improving crisis anticipation, resource allocation, and coordination efforts. In *Digital, Industry, and Space*, SoBigData strengthens Europe's technological autonomy by fostering innovation in AI, cloud computing, and secure data processing. It advances world-class data and computing technologies by developing machine learning and privacy-preserving data analytics. Supporting digital competitiveness and green transition also promotes ethical AI development. In *Climate, Energy, and Mobility*, the RI supports sustainable transport by optimising urban mobility, reducing emissions, and improving traffic management with AI-powered models. It enhances transport resilience by analysing mobility patterns and predictive maintenance to improve automation. In all these areas, the RI works continuously to strengthen its community, supporting researchers with its DIGITAL services (e.g., Data Storage, Data Management, Cloud computing, and VREs) and provides existing and new AI tools (e.g., Extracting Behavioural Models and Optimising complex systems). The RI is currently involved in diverse proposals in the Horizon Work Programme 2025 calls, where new communities of researchers and leading institutions in the fields have requested its services.

At a broader level, SoBigData RI reduces redundancy and operational expenses, allowing national institutions to reallocate resources toward innovative research and development initiatives.

⁸https://research-and-innovation.ec.europa.eu/funding/funding-opportunities/funding-programmes-and-open-calls/horizon-europe/horizon-europe-work-programmes_en

Furthermore, with SoBigData IP, the RI (starting from the list defined in SoBigData RI PPP) will offer new services developed within the nodes of the RI. Furthermore, the RI will also implement all the aspects to demonstrate transparency in its operations and accountability to society. These aspects involve continuous dialogue with various stakeholders, as well as promoting FAIR principles, and organising educational initiatives that raise awareness about the benefits and risks associated with the use of big data and artificial intelligence systems. The following subsections will outline the major fields where the RI will impact through the implementation phase.

2.1 Technological Aspects

Currently, the RI supports several technological facilities that represent its DIGIT services. The SoBigData e-infrastructure (<https://sobigdata.d4science.org/>) offers a comprehensive and integrated suite of DIGIT services to support the entire research lifecycle. These services are designed to work together to create a cohesive and robust environment for social mining and data analytics.

SoBigData services are provided through **Virtual Research Environments (VREs)**, web-based tools that create collaborative spaces for sharing data or performing experiments on projects, initiatives, or simple groups of researchers. A VRE can be public or private and is managed by its owner through a web portal for access control. It is designed to enhance research innovation and to include dedicated and ad-hoc specialised elements of the RI DIGIT services:

The **SoBigData Catalogue** provides a tool for general-purpose publishing of research items, including data, methods, libraries, and tools, promoting their FAIRness. The Catalogue is based on the D4science catalogue engine, which is widely adopted by several communities, including those in marine science, humanities, and health science, and it is built upon CKAN (<https://ckan.org/>), an open-source data portal platform. This strategic choice provides a robust foundation for managing a wide array of research objects and datasets. The use of CKAN, a widely adopted data management system, ensures that the SoBigData Catalogue adheres to recognised standards for data publication and metadata management. The service is central to the platform's vision of a collaborative and reproducible research ecosystem, facilitating the sharing and reuse of scientific outputs and fostering open science practices within the community.

The **SoBigData Workspace** offers a personal and collaborative storage space for users to manage their research products, including data, software code, and documents. Its key features include centralised storage automatically replicated on multiple storage devices and locations to guarantee fault tolerance, low latency, and scalability. This service empowers collaborative capabilities by allowing researchers to share their data and resources with colleagues or entire VREs.

Jupyter Hub provides the SoBigData community with a versatile and robust environment for online coding and data analytics (integrated with ready-to-use specialised libraries developed by SoBigData researchers). A key technical complexity that SoBigData has successfully navigated is the addition of the workspace as a sidecar container within the JupyterLab environment. For end-users, this means that their research materials are immediately accessible, eliminating the need to transfer files and streamlining the entire workflow manually. Furthermore, because the RI workspace enables easy sharing of data and methods among colleagues, this technical integration provides a powerful collaborative capability. Researchers can work together on the same Jupyter notebooks, sharing their code, data, and analytical pipelines in a dynamic environment. This deeply integrated approach transforms JupyterLab from a coding tool into a true collaborative hub, fostering open science and accelerating joint research projects within the SoBigData community. The distributed nature of the infrastructure further enhances this capability.

Galaxy Workflow is a web-based platform designed for data-intensive research, empowering users to perform, reproduce, and share complex computational analyses through a user-friendly graphical interface. The platform's GUI simplifies the data analysis process, making it accessible to researchers with varying computational expertise. At the same time, its emphasis on reproducibility and transparency ensures that every step of a workflow is meticulously recorded.

The SoBigData Cloud Computing Platform (CCP) is a service that provides on-demand and scalable access to computing resources, allowing researchers to execute containerised methods, such as algorithms, scripts, models, and computational pipelines, without needing to manage the underlying physical infrastructure or software dependencies. Furthermore, the RI supports the provision of virtual machines that are accessible to all its users (upon creation of an account) within the Jupyter Hub with a minimum configuration.

In addition, **the Storage and Data Management Services** provide robust solutions for archiving, versioning, and secure data handling via a dedicated web portal and API, ensuring that critical datasets remain accessible and well-managed. High-security standards and advanced privacy tools are integrated throughout the data lifecycle to protect sensitive information while maintaining open access when appropriate. The SoBigData IP will be responsible for selecting, implementing, and operationalising new services (and updating existing ones) provided by the nodes. These new services will support not only researchers but also industry and public entities by providing access to advanced technologies, high-quality data, and interdisciplinary expertise. Access methods will be versatile, offering public, private, and restricted modes that cater to a wide array of user requirements and facilitate collaboration and integration with external platforms provided by OpenAIRE, EGI, Zenodo, and European Open Science Cloud (EOSC). To ensure the RI's evolution, a working group of researchers will be established to update and implement the digital backbone. Additional details on the pathways envisaged in the project are described in Section 2.4.

2.2 Research Spaces

Recalling ESFRI areas, SoBigData RI is a DIGIT infrastructure that provides services seamlessly across research domains. Its **computational network** and **DIGIT** services are designed to adapt to users' specific needs. Focusing on scientific domains and application fields such as the Social Sciences and Humanities (SSH) area, SoBigData has established a network of researchers and institutions committed to addressing pressing social issues, which, due to their nature, require a multidisciplinary approach. This network is crucial for identifying real-world problems, acquiring data, developing specialised SCI services, and demonstrating the impact of the RI.

The scientific SoBigData collaboration operates in specific research topics called *research spaces* (www.sobigdata.eu/research_spaces) aimed at applying data science to real-world scenarios. Each research space blends computational tools and resources with cutting-edge research on a set of specific topics, and it shares tools, data, and methods to address pressing societal issues. The RI ensures that its scientific contributions are both broadly applicable across disciplines and deeply specialised within critical domains, fostering innovation and impactful discoveries.

The research spaces already active are:

i) Societal Debates and Misinformation (CNR, BSC, UNIPI, UvA, CSD) focuses on public debates, analysing both discussions on social media and journalistic production to understand which are the most debated topics. These analyses can identify themes, assess how they are discussed, and track them in time and space. This research space analyses individuals' discussions using data from online social networks to investigate topics that are relevant to society.

ii) Demography, Economy, and Finance 2.0 (SNS, IMT, UNIROMA1, SSSA) focuses on examining both established intricate socio-economic financial systems, including emerging ones such as blockchain and cryptocurrency markets. The research delves into their diverse applications, including smart property, the Internet of Things, energy trading, and smart contracts. The interplay between conventional systems and these domains is explored through comprehensive research, seeking to understand their implications and potential impacts on various sectors.

iii) Sustainable Cities for Citizens (IMT, BSC, CNR, URV, UNIVAQ) focuses on mobile phone traces, vehicular GPS, and social data, all of which are Big Data sources and proxies of human behaviour. If analysed, results can be helpful to both public bodies and citizens. Public bodies can better understand urban mobility using tools that quantify traffic and the city's usage, thus making

better decisions in mobility management. Citizens can access real-time traffic information and choose the best and fastest route.

iv) *Social Impact of AI and Explainable Machine Learning* (SNS, UNIPI, LUH, UPF, KCL, TUDelft) studies the rise of the ‘black box’ society in the last decade. By observing many examples of the expected input/output behaviour, the algorithms’ internal reasoning is often obscure, even for their own developers. The research space assesses black box AI systems for automated decision making, which are usually based on machine learning trained with big data, and that map out user features into a class predicting individual behavioural traits.

v) *Health Studies* (UNIROMA1, UNIVAQ, LUH) focuses on medical, nutrition, and environmental research to address health issues. It employs machine learning and AI, including Network Medicine, combining systems biology and network science for disease understanding and personalised treatments. The field builds BioMedical knowledge graphs using specialised tools for research papers. Studying personal activities on health and human behaviour involves sensing technologies for reliable data. Integrating big data with AI unveils complexities and achieves challenging goals.

vi) *Disaster Response and Recovery* (UNIVA, CNR) relies on methods and tools to analyse, monitor, and improve post-disaster reconstruction processes in socio-economic areas, spatial planning, and environmental health in cooperation with national and international institutions. The application of ICT-enhanced solutions to response and recovery phases of the disaster management cycle can improve the efficiency of “search and rescue” activities, emergency relief, reconstruction, and rehabilitation. This includes the study of methodologies devoted to the creation of evacuation plans from enriched city graphs, methodologies based on predictive approaches to guide the decision-makers in the definition of (urban and socio-economic) reconstruction policies, and the definition of collaborative virtual spaces for the monitoring of the territory.

vii) *Societal and Industrial Impact of Next-Generation Internet & beyond 5G Networks* (CNR, UNIBO, UNIPA) focuses on 5/6G networks and next-generation Internet to enable new services impacting society and manufacturing. It investigates specifically the adoption of smart radio environments, open-RAN paradigms, and novel network virtualisation technologies. Considering the integration of social data and industrial activities, this research space focuses on the impact of communication services on specific applications, such as mobility, vehicular traffic management, and manufacturing processes. In addition, this research space investigates the effect of Next Generation Internet paradigms by developing user and device-centric services for groups of mobile users based on direct communication between far-edge devices, validating them in the same application areas.

viii) *Pervasive Intelligence in Cyber-Physical Systems for Future Society* (CNR, UNIBO, UNIPA) focuses on leveraging extensive traffic data to develop “Zero Touch” networking for the growing number of devices in society. It aims to study AI models for dynamic resource allocation, emphasising responsiveness to changes in services, application requirements, and user-generated traffic. The research space also investigates Cyber-Physical systems emulating biological brain mechanisms for self-control in scenarios like industrial settings. The focus is on decentralised computation paradigms using networking technologies (e.g., IoT and edge devices) to make AI pervasive, moving intelligence from centralised data centres to users’ devices. The goal is to foster advanced services based on human-centric AI. Each research space is designed to foster interdisciplinary collaboration by bringing together over 250 researchers, access to extensively curated datasets, and a user community of more than 14,000 registered members.

The outlined research spaces reflect only the current scientific direction of SoBigData, and they will therefore be subject to evolution, being revised during the SoBigData IP based on the services implemented and the policies adopted/requested by the implementation of the national nodes.

SoBigData IP envisions deeper collaborations with other leading research infrastructures to expand its multidisciplinary impact further. Strategic partnerships with CESSDA-ERIC (<https://www.cessda.eu/>), SHARE-ERIC (<https://share-eric.eu/>), and RISIS (<https://www.risis2.eu/>) will enable the integration of comprehensive social science data archives, health and ageing datasets,

and innovative policy studies, respectively. Furthermore, cooperation with SLICES will leverage advanced data analytics and distributed computing expertise, while collaboration with E-BRAINS (<https://www.ebrains.eu/>) will promote interdisciplinary research in health studies. The participation in common research proposals and projects is another way to create common strategies in the ERA. SoBigData is also collaborating with Zenodo (<https://zenodo.org/>), CLARIN (<https://www.clarin.eu/content/clarin-nutshell>), ODISSEI (<https://odissei-data.nl/>), and with OpenAIRE (<https://www.openaire.eu/>) and EGI (<https://www.egi.eu/>). These joint efforts will amplify the technical and scientific capabilities of the SoBigData RI, ensuring that its services continue to contribute to a more integrated and impactful European research landscape.

2.3 Socio-economic impact

SoBigData RI is making a significant socio-economic impact by providing state-of-the-art tools and resources for big data analytics. SoBigData supports data-driven innovation, enabling the development of AI-based solutions. The RI empowers the development of ethical and explainable AI tools to address societal challenges such as misinformation, social inequality, and fairness in AI. A key aspect of its impact is the focus on human capital development. SoBigData trains researchers, data scientists, and professionals through workshops, master courses, summer schools, and its Academy (<https://www.sobigdata.eu/academy>), equipping them with essential skills in computational social sciences, ethics, and responsible AI. The RI facilitates interdisciplinary collaboration, encouraging knowledge exchange across different domains. By offering access to open datasets and advanced analytical platforms, SoBigData promotes transparency and reproducibility in research. The research infrastructure also contributes to policy impact and governance by providing data-driven insights supporting evidence-based policymaking in urban planning, migration, and social inclusion. It aligns with European strategies for digital sovereignty and ethical AI by adhering to FAIR data principles. Furthermore, SoBigData strengthens Europe's digital research ecosystem through its advanced virtual research environments, enabling international collaboration and knowledge sharing among academic, industrial, and governmental entities.

In terms of scientific production, SoBigData is contributing to the advancement of knowledge in fields such as big data, artificial intelligence, and computational social sciences. Its research outputs include numerous high-impact publications in open-access top-tier academic journals and conferences, reinforcing the scientific community's understanding of key topics such as data privacy, AI ethics, and data-driven policy. Through its extensive network, SoBigData connects researchers and institutions across Europe and beyond. Its commitment to sustainability ensures a long-term impact by establishing a foundation for research excellence in ethical data science and equipping professionals with crucial digital and data literacy skills. By fostering open science, interdisciplinary collaboration, and responsible AI, SoBigData RI enhances Europe's leadership in big data research, contributing to socio-economic development and preparing future generations for an increasingly data-driven world.

Moreover, SoBigData RI delivers significant socio-economic benefits by replacing costly, fragmented infrastructures with a unified, efficient platform that streamlines research and public policy support. This integrated model not only cuts costs but also enhances the quality and accessibility of data through standardised, interoperable systems, which in turn support more efficient and evidence-based policymaking. In addition, the infrastructure's open-access data dissemination practices empower policymakers with timely, high-quality datasets and analytical outputs. By driving innovation and facilitating collaborative research across Europe, SoBigData RI acts as a catalyst for sustainable socio-economic development, building research capacity, supporting industry growth, and enhancing the overall competitiveness of the European research ecosystem.

2.4 Project's pathways towards impact

SoBigData IP will contribute to the implementation of SoBigData RI for analysing social data combined with user-driven research environments and operational ethical and legal standards. The key advantage of SoBigData RI is that it will be available for social data experiments, taking advantage of synergies within the European RIs scenario, the research excellence industry, and public administrations. Work will be carried out by implementing elements and procedures to guarantee full integration and cohesive federation of operational units inside each national node. The consortium conceived the SoBigData IP work plan to overcome potential barriers and prevent the most common risks right from the beginning of the project. In particular, SoBigData RI aims to enable sustainable services that respond to the demand for cross-disciplinary data-driven research and innovation. These ambitions require partner institutions to bring their expertise, particularly in cutting-edge technologies, finance, and law, to respond to the challenges posed by cross-border, cross-sectoral data transfers and processing by multiple stakeholders through a federated, interactive platform. The same set of skills and expertise is also pivotal to tackling the pressing need for an open ecosystem with adequate means for accessing big social data and algorithms for extracting knowledge from them, without forgetting the aim of democratising the benefits of data science within an ethical framework that harmonises individual rights and collective interests. The legal infrastructure of the SoBigData RI (designed during the preparation phase project) identified the administrative, ethical, financial, legal, and technical barriers as well as the force majeure conditions that might risk the fulfilment of the SoBigData RI goals and developed strategies to cope with these risks. SoBigData RI PPP compared statutes of some European RI and their Risk Management Plans. The analysis was carried out on quantitative and qualitative elements. Quantitative elements are those that can be measured with a unit of measurement, while qualitative elements are the analysis of risk elements that presuppose a given quality of the subjects involved in the research structure. In this regard, keyword-based research has been conducted on the open-access and online repositories often preferred to disseminate the EU-funded project results. Common risks emerging from the combined analysis of Risk management plans of research infrastructures and literature review were classified according to the following principles: neutrality (when an external entity defines them); generality (if the same risks are valid for many RIs); specificity (if risks are valid for homogeneous bodies and allow both temporal and spatial comparison). The definition and the selection of Key Performance Indicators (KPIs) in the living self-learning process support the risk-based assessment by considering the interests and needs of stakeholders and beneficiaries of investments in the given research infrastructure. Possible risks deriving from the activities of the RI, in fact, shall not only be reduced but sometimes totally prevented to avoid that the possible occurrence could impact the achievement of every strategic objective of the plan⁹.

Based on these premises, the work plan is achieved by proactive risk management based on modular work packages, clear responsibilities, and minimisation of critical paths:

Pathway 1 - Improve User Experience and Services: A key challenge for SoBigData is to provide services that are both powerful and easy to use for a wide community of researchers, policymakers, industry representatives, and civil society. The preparatory phase already delivered a single entry portal where users can access datasets, computational tools, and training materials. However, this offering must be improved to become an even more coherent and integrated environment where users feel supported in accessing and using the tools they need. The RI has already developed a diverse set of tools requiring different levels of expertise (i.e., Jupyter Hub for coders and Galaxy Workflow for non-coders), but they must be improved in usability. Training resources such as tutorials, interactive guides, and use case demonstrators will illustrate how the SoBigData RI can be leveraged to address pressing societal questions and help its users. User testing and structured feedback will guide continuous service improvement, ensuring that usability and accessibility remain at the center of the infrastructure. Within SoBigData IP, a special focus will be dedicated to continuously increasing the availability of new services and improving user experience, enriching

⁹ The detailed list of barriers, risks and mitigation measures can be found in the deliverable D2.4 - PPP - SoBigData RI Risk management plan - <https://data.d4science.net/k51a0>

the RI catalogue of products (datasets, methods, applications, and experiments) in WP2 (T2.6) and WP4 (T4.2). The RI will promote capacity building and knowledge transfer to close expertise and funding gaps between nodes, strengthening the economic position of organisations. The SoBigData Gateway¹⁰ will be regularly updated to meet the evolving needs of its research communities. Dissemination activities, tutorial videos, and communication through social media will further engage users and strengthen SoBigData's role as an essential resource for big data research in Europe.

Pathway 2 - Enhancing Interoperability Framework: The capacity of SoBigData to support cutting-edge research depends on the quality and interoperability of its metadata. SoBigData IP will undertake a systematic review to harmonise metadata across all collections, ensuring compliance with FAIR principles and requesting data owners to meet elevated quality standards (tasks T2.7 and T4.3). A clear policy for the moderation of new resources will be developed. The adoption of standards will increase consistency and make the data more accessible for both humans and machines. By introducing AI-readable metadata formats such as RDF or JSON-LD, SoBigData RI will enable automated discovery and integration of resources. A training guide for accessing resources through APIs and connectors will help users automate processes and facilitate interoperability. Within the broader digital infrastructure renewal, during the SoBigData IP, the RI will continue to expand the number of available resources (datasets, methods, and analytical processes) and enhance available research areas, ensuring that metadata is consistently updated and integrated into research spaces and publications.

Pathway 3 - Data spaces and EOSC integration: The implementation phase will firmly position SoBigData RI within the EOSC and connect it with emerging European data spaces¹¹. The RI currently complies with EOSC standards for the descriptors of its resources, but still requires improvements in automatic integration with the EOSC Resource Hub. By participating in data spaces, SoBigData RI will contribute its expertise in responsible data analytics and enrich initiatives addressing European priorities. A dedicated team will follow developments in EOSC and data spaces to secure long-term alignment and visibility. SoBigData IP will integrate and federate resources under a unique umbrella, avoiding effort duplication and exploiting economies of scale by promoting common standards, encouraging the sharing of resources, and establishing joint research, development, and training capabilities. This integration will not replace existing RIs but add value by providing a permanent European home for AI, big data, and social mining applications (T4.4).

Pathway 4 - Implementing the integration blueprints developed in PPP: The development of a distributed yet coherent computational infrastructure is essential for SoBigData. The implementation phase will build on the blueprints produced during the preparatory phase and validated through the experience developed during the SoBigData.it project (<https://pnrr.sobigdata.it/>), where the Italian node has been involved in the strengthening of the RI resources. SoBigData.it represents a pilot that SoBigData RI PPP exploited to produce blueprints, which the RI European nodes in SoBigData IP will implement. A federated architecture will connect computational resources across European nodes with harmonised authentication and workload management. Containerised services will ensure that tools can be deployed consistently across the network. The Italian pilot demonstrated the model's viability, and this integration approach will be extended to other nodes, creating a robust European-wide computational infrastructure. SoBigData IP will expand platform functionalities and continuously update technological capabilities (tasks T2.6, T4.3), enabling new services and remote access solutions (T6.2). All the new services deployed during SoBigData IP will be done under a methodological design that reflects the RIs' ethical awareness at every development stage. The RI will provide flexible access—both transnational and virtual—including in-person, online, and hybrid events. This distributed model ensures that national computational and research sites are federated under a common European framework. The working group for the update and implementation of the digital backbone will be established, including: Dr. Tiziana Ferrari (EGI), Dr. Pasquale Pagano (CNR), Dr. Ulises Cortes (BSC), Dr. Vassilis Katsouros (ATHENA), Prof. Awais

¹⁰ SoBigData Gateway - <https://sobigdata.d4science.org/>

¹¹ <https://digital-strategy.ec.europa.eu/en/policies/data-spaces>

Rashid (REPHRAIN), Prof. Tom Emery (ODISSEI), Dr. Andrea Passarella (CNR), and Dr. Natalia Manola (OpenAIRE).

Pathway 5 - Financial Sustainability: The long-term success of SoBigData depends on a stable and diversified financial model. During the Preparatory Phase, the project established a strategy that combines European and national research funding with new revenue streams. In the Implementation Phase, the RI will consolidate this plan and create new partnerships with industry and public administrations, opening consultancy services, specialised training, and ad hoc access to selected resources. A transparent cost-sharing scheme among nodes will guarantee equitable governance of shared infrastructure. Engagement with public authorities will secure contracts for mission-driven services addressing policy priorities such as ethical AI and digital transformation. This diversified approach will ensure that SoBigData remains resilient and sustainable beyond the lifecycle of individual projects. The organisational model of hub and nodes, coordinated by lead institutions, is designed to promote the inflow of funds and cover implementation costs not explicitly covered by this project. Project partners SLEX and X-officio will support the consortium in formalising and validating the statute and business model of the future SoBigData ERIC (tasks T2.2, T4.1). This collaborative framework fosters stronger inter-institutional relationships, enhancing the RI network's stability, scalability, and strategic alignment.

Pathway 6 - Roadmap to ERIC: The Implementation Phase will prepare the ground for the transition of SoBigData into a European Research Infrastructure Consortium (ERIC). A feasibility study, alignment with ERIC legal and financial requirements, and sustained dialogue with national ministries have already been initiated. Draft statutes, governance models, and financial frameworks were outputs of the Preparatory Phase. SoBigData IP will consolidate all aspects related to the definition of an ERIC and support negotiations required to become an RI national node, including discussions of financial support and membership rules. At least three Member States must support the creation of ERIC. WP2 and WP4 will consolidate statutes emerging from the first negotiation rounds, formalising and validating the governance model with the involvement of the BGR. During the implementation phase, each national lead institution will coordinate its national node, managing local service implementation, communication, and engagement of new institutions. They will also participate in national and international calls as part of SoBigData RI. In particular, the following specific institutions are designated to act as formally declared Principal Investigators (PIs), assuming a central role in the coordination and oversight of node activities. The Central Hub is coordinated by CNR, and involves nine institutions: CNR, SSSA, IMT, UNIP, SNS, UNIBO, UNIPA, UNIVAQ, UNIROMA1. The other SoBigData RI nodes will be led by: LUH for the German node with the involvement of DFKI, BSC for the Spanish node, ATHENA for the Greek node, UvA for the Dutch node, and KCL for the UK node. The Dutch node includes TUDelft and EGI. ODISSEI, the Dutch Research Infrastructure for Social Sciences, will be a key player, advancing computational social science, data management, and economic analysis for large-scale data-driven research. The Spanish node comprises four institutions: BSC as leader, URV, UPF, and UCM - a new acquisition during the Preparation Phase Project. The German node is led by LUH, represented by two different departments: the L3S Research Center and the Institute for Legal Informatics (IRI). ATHENA will lead the Greek node, and OpenAIRE will be part of the node. The UK node comprises KCL, which will be the leader of the node, and REPHRAIN. These aspects are covered by WP2, WP3, WP4, and WP6 through specific tasks (T2.1, T2.3, T2.4, T4.1, WP3 tasks for managing national nodes, and T6.1). This roadmap will lead to the preparation of documents required for ESFRI evaluation and Step-1 submission, securing SoBigData RI's transition into a European legal entity with recognised governance and financial stability. In particular, Pathway 1 relates to Objective 1, Pathways 2, 3 and 4 relate to Objective 2 and Pathways 5 and 6 relate to Objective 3.

Taken together, these six pathways provide a comprehensive roadmap for the implementation phase of SoBigData. By simultaneously improving user experience, strengthening metadata, deepening integration with EOSC and European dataspace, expanding and federating computational infrastructure, ensuring financial sustainability, and preparing for the transition to ERIC, SoBigData will consolidate its role as a leading European Research Infrastructure. This coordinated strategy will not only enhance the scientific and societal impact of the RI but also guarantee its long-term

resilience, scalability, and relevance in addressing Europe's digital and data-driven priorities. In addition, the activities across the first four pathways will require additional effort, which will be supported through the in-kind contributions of the various nodes. The FOE, the fund set up by the Italian Ministry of University and Research, will also sustain these efforts for the central hub. This combined support ensures that the overall implementation of the pathways is reinforced nationally, through the commitment of individual nodes, and centrally through structural funding.

2.5 Measures to maximise impact - Dissemination, exploitation and communication

The implementation phase is conceived to ensure the sustainability of the RI. In this context, the project will start to implement the long-term communication strategies defined in the SoBigData RI PPP Deliverable D5.4 "A long-term dissemination, communications, and marketing strategy¹²". SoBigData IP will also start implementing the strategies already geared towards the needs of the SoBigData ERIC. More specifically, during the implementation phase, SoBigData RI will continue to disseminate scientific results through its communication channels and to promote the exploitation of RI services by showcasing software components, datasets, survey templates, and simulation libraries in different events in which the RI will be involved. The RI, especially in the last part of the SoBigData RI PPP, was involved in many initiatives and projects, creating a research network where the RI's features, tools, and services support research in different communities. Finally, special events and strategies for stakeholder engagement will be developed and implemented during the SoBigData IP.

Project partner TOUR4EU will lead the project's communication and dissemination activities, ensuring broad visibility for its objectives, activities, and outcomes. The communication strategy is devoted to consolidating the RI identity and will be managed through the website and social media channels. Dissemination events will be organised at both the EU and national levels. The website will serve as the central hub for communication, offering regularly updated and accessible content on the RI objectives, activities, results, and milestones, thereby ensuring transparency and continuous visibility. Social media channels will complement the website, acting as dynamic platforms for storytelling and engagement. Through these channels, the RI will share updates, success stories, testimonials, and other relevant content, with the goal of creating an active and engaged community around SoBigData's core themes. This approach will foster active participation and support the development of a solid stakeholder network, enabling collaboration, knowledge exchange, and interactions.

Furthermore, TOUR4EU leads stakeholder engagement activities that will include developing and implementing tailored dissemination events. Mapping all the stakeholders and their interests is of paramount importance to achieving project objectives. The stakeholder mapping will identify relevant actors at the local, national, and European levels and classify them according to their level of influence, interest, and potential role in dissemination and uptake. This activity will support the design of targeted communication and engagement actions, strengthen the project's outreach capacity, and help build meaningful relationships for long-term stakeholder involvement and knowledge exchange.

The communication and dissemination strategy will combine both traditional and innovative activities to strengthen its potential outreach. It will select pertinent messages and target and adapt to audiences beyond the RI's community, including stakeholders and the public. Moreover, it will aim to create cross-fertilisation across different dissemination tools to broaden dissemination outputs outside one specific target. Dissemination will also be fostered by tailored events and workshops for policymakers, ensuring media appearances while targeting a broad audience. Regular contacts with media representatives will be established at the local, national, and European levels. Building on a multi-sectoral and multi-stakeholder approach, at the European level, TOUR4EU will foster strong

¹² SoBigData RI PPP public deliverables: <https://data.d4science.net/hpPaf>

collaboration with the European Parliament, European Commission, relevant EU agencies, and other EU-funded projects. This cooperation aims to boost the project's visibility, ensure alignment with EU policy objectives and thematic strategies, and showcase the project's contributions to policy development and innovation uptake. SoBigData IP will exploit existing community networks, the press, and the media to build a broader public audience. The members of these target groups (e.g., CORDIS, ANSA Europa, Euractiv, UNILION network) will be provided with dedicated messages to effectively report on the RI results.

One of TOUR4EU's objectives will be to reinforce and strengthen the engagement with the European news agencies. Enhancing communication and visibility at the European level is essential to foster transparency, promote RI initiatives, and ensure a wider public engagement. To this purpose, press releases are planned to be written and sent at regular intervals, especially during relevant moments of the RI's path, such as the achievement of results, meetings, and attendance at specialised events and conferences. With the support of TOUR4EU, the RI will organise two main European-level events (which will be organised with an in-kind contribution) specifically tailored toward relevant policymakers and private companies.

2.5.1 Key Performance Indicators

The KPIs outlined in this section have been selected to reflect both operational efficiency and strategic impact of the SoBigData IP project. The KPIs listed in Table 2.5.1.1 will serve as benchmarks for evaluating success concerning the project's goals, ensuring accountability, and enabling continuous improvement.

Work Package	KPIs
WP1 - Management (phases 1 & 2)	- <i>Project meetings organised: 2 in person and 2 online</i> - <i>Courses for internal capacity building: 2</i> - <i>Number of public bodies and private companies engaged: 20</i> - <i>First release of OpenAIRE Graph: 1</i> - <i>First release of OpenAIRE's Monitor service: 1</i>
WP2 - Advancing Research Infrastructure Maturity (phase 1)	- <i>First release of access policy: 1</i> - <i>First release of ERIC statute: 1</i> - <i>First financial and budgeting document: 1</i> - <i>Number of services to be deployed in phase 2: 10</i>
WP4 - Advancing Research Infrastructure Maturity (phase 2)	- <i>Total Number of users registered to the RI: 16,000</i> - <i>Number of new services deployed: 10</i> - <i>Data Management plan updated</i> - <i>Number of services to be deployed in phase 3: 5</i>
WP5 - Management Finalisation (phase 3)	- <i>Project meetings organised: 1 in person and 1 online</i>
WP6 - Advancing Research Infrastructure Maturity (phase 3)	- <i>Number of new services deployed: 5</i> - <i>Number of total users registered to the RI: 17,000</i> - <i>Average Number of accesses to SoBigData Lab & Service per month: 500</i> - <i>Final release of OpenAIRE Graph: 1</i> - <i>Final release of OpenAIRE's Monitor service: 1</i> - <i>Data Management plan updated</i> - <i>Number of services to be deployed after the end of the project: 15</i>

Table 2.5.1.1: SoBigData IP KPIs list

2.5.2 SoBigData Monitor Dashboard: embedding KPIs from the Start for Effective Monitoring and Impact Assessment

As emphasised by the ESFRI Report for Monitoring Research Infrastructures, defining and operationalising Key Performance Indicators (KPIs) from the outset is essential to measure success, guide strategic decision-making, and demonstrate value to stakeholders. For SoBigData RI, the transition from design to the implementation phase marks a critical moment for embedding these KPIs into the core operational fabric of the research infrastructure. Early definition of KPIs ensures that data collection mechanisms, technical instrumentation, and governance processes are aligned with expected outcomes, from scientific excellence and open science practices to societal impact and innovation uptake. Furthermore, KPIs' definition facilitates continuous evaluation and enables timely course correction and evidence-based reporting to funders, users, and policymakers. Within this context, OpenAIRE offers mature, interoperable tools and infrastructure that can support SoBigData RI in building these capabilities.

By collaborating with OpenAIRE, SoBigData RI can ensure that monitoring is not an afterthought but a structural element of its operations, enabling a robust, transparent, and community-driven implementation aligned with European Open Science and Research Infrastructure policy. A fully operational monitoring framework, based on Open Science principles, will be developed, enabling SoBigData RI to assess and demonstrate its performance, strategic relevance, and long-term societal impact.

The SoBigData MONITOR Dashboard will represent a strategic tool that enables real-time tracking, evaluation, and communication of SoBigData RI's scientific outputs, societal impact, and policy alignment. Emphasis will be placed on configuring the dashboard to reflect RI-specific KPIs relevant to SoBigData's RI mission concerning its impact, uptake, collaboration, and policy compliance. The data reported by the SoBigData MONITOR Dashboard will also be used to guide corrective/remedial actions if required.

2.6 Summary

KEY ELEMENT OF THE IMPACT SECTION

SPECIFIC NEEDS	EXPECTED RESULTS
This project continues the expected Lifecycle Approach defined by ESFRI. The needs include the work towards establishing the ERIC as a legal entity of the RI, the implementation, and the provision of RI services.	The plan is the final implementation of a harmonised distributed RI related to AI and Social Mining based on FAIR and FACT principles. The expected results are the consolidation of documents required to establish the legal status, including financial aspects for guaranteeing sustainability and stability for long-term operation (toward ERIC establishment); service provision and user engagement, including stakeholder involvement, science innovation, and knowledge transfer.
D & E & C MEASURES	TARGET GROUPS
D&C towards decision and policymakers: Policy dialogues, BGR involvement, local and international events, one-to-one meetings, pitch, website, and social media. D&C towards the scientific community: scientific publications, blog, social media, website, presentations at conferences, and webinars. D&C towards stakeholders: info days, pitch, website, social media, training/roadshow for consultants, business, policymakers. Exploitation: open access to all project results and the SoBigData RI;	Policymakers, such as MS, Governmental representatives, relevant ministries, local government, and EC, should promote access to the most up-to-date and actionable knowledge to support the implementation of policy measures. Academia: Researchers and the scientific community will benefit from SoBigData RI services to improve the quality of their research. Main sectors: Computer science communities, data scientists and affiliated disciplines, social scientists, and privacy researchers. Business activities: to foster the adoption of innovative strategies for increasing the success and sustainability of their operations. Other Horizon Europe and ESFRI Infrastructure projects: finding opportunities for integration and developing synergies. Training Initiatives: become a sandbox for training initiatives of Ph.D. courses and other training initiatives.
OUTCOMES	IMPACTS
Toward the ERIC establishment and policymakers to support the implementation of policy measures. Increased visibility of SoBigData RI in target groups. Awareness of the stakeholders and expansion of the RI's network to foster collaboration between industry, RI, and other stakeholders. Increased involvement of the scientific community. Communication of cutting-edge services, facilities, and resources of the SoBigData RI.	Scientific Impact: the experience accrued through H2020 SoBigData projects will be part of the strategies and plan for long-term science production. Societal Impact: training the next generation of responsible social data scientists engaged in AI and Social Mining research questions to become ambassadors to facilitate data citizenship and data democracy. Economic Impact: SoBigData IP will impact the industry by providing a wide range of innovation services aimed at research, industrial, and other types of stakeholders. The project will implement strategies aimed at existing RIs and service providers, as well as national and European research and funding programs to ensure maximum coordination and impact from future investments. Technological Impact: Implementation of state-of-the-art dynamic digital assets to remote sites without the need for expensive on-site expertise. The diffusion of standards and policy for the distributed RI.

3. Quality and efficiency of the implementation

SoBigData IP is designed around three phases, the first and last each ending with one milestone and the second phase ending with two milestones. Every project partner will contribute meaningfully to each phase, driving forward sequential and overlapping tasks across the WPs. Figure 3.1.1 shows the linkage between the project phases, pathways, and objectives of the project.

Initialisation phase (Months 1 - 6)

In the first six months, SoBigData IP will focus on laying the groundwork for both RI services and the SoBigData ERIC institutional framework. Work aligned with **Pathway 1 (Improve User Experience)** begins by refining access models and consolidating the service provision toward a coherent user environment, ensuring that the infrastructure can welcome a wide range of research communities with the right balance of usability and flexibility. In parallel, efforts under **Pathway 2 (Improved Metadata)** initiated a systematic review of resource descriptions, setting the stage for FAIR compliance and harmonised data management practices across the RI. Alongside these technical and service-oriented developments, attention was also directed to long-term stability through **Pathway 5 (Financial Sustainability)**, with strategies elaborated for diversified funding, cost-sharing schemes among nodes, and the engagement of industry partners. At the same time, **Pathway 6 (Roadmap to ERIC)** was launched, as the BGR continued (started at the end of the SoBigData RI PPP project) negotiations among Member States, drafted governance and statutory frameworks, and laid the groundwork for the eventual ERIC submission. This initialisation period therefore served both the internal consolidation of service and data standards and the external consolidation of governance and financial models.

Consultation & Advancement phase (Months 7 - 24)

The second phase will mark a significant shift towards implementation: all six pathways will be activated. Through **Pathway 1**, the user experience will acquire a central role with the launch of new services via the SoBigData Gateway, tested by early adopters and supported by training resources to ensure accessibility. At the same time, **Pathway 2** will advance the harmonisation of metadata, enabling machine-readable formats and policies that increase the interoperability and discoverability of resources. The project will also enter into the European research ecosystem more organically through **Pathway 3 (Dataspace and EOSC integration)**, enabling EOSC integration in a more automatic way, which will position SoBigData within emerging European dataspace. Building on the integration blueprints developed in SoBigData PPP, **Pathway 4 (Integration Blueprints)** will oversee the expansion of a distributed and federated computational infrastructure, as nodes across Europe begin to adopt harmonised authentication and federated management models tested in the central hub in Italy. To secure the long-term viability of the infrastructure, **Pathway 5** will progress the diversification of financial models, reinforcing partnerships with industry and public administrations, and opening consultancy and training services. Finally, **Pathway 6** will enter at a crucial moment, as the Italian node, with support from other Member States, will prepare all the documents required for the ERIC application to the European Commission, while national nodes coordinate implementation activities and support negotiations. This advancement phase will therefore be both technical and political, combining service deployment with the delicate consultations required for the ERIC formation process.

Finalisation phase (Months 25 - 36)

The last phase of the project will move towards consolidation and transition into an operational European research infrastructure. With **Pathway 4**, the distributed architecture will include new computational resources, expand platform functionalities, and ensure that computational services are consistently available across the federated network of nodes (according to internal policies between nodes). **Pathway 5** will evolve into a robust framework for sustainability, embedding transparent cost-sharing mechanisms, diversified revenue streams, and strengthened industry partnerships into the governance structure. In parallel, **Pathway 6** will reach its decisive moment as

the negotiations around the ERIC statutes and membership rules, preparing the ground for the General Assembly and the transition to a legally recognised European Research Infrastructure Consortium. The finalisation stage will thus bring together the project's technological, financial, and governance dimensions, ensuring that SoBigData will be positioned not only as a functioning RI but as one ready for long-term sustainability and European recognition.

The project expects two reporting periods: RP1 at M18, and final RP2 at M36.

3.1 Work plan and resources

SoBigData IP will be implemented via six Work Packages (WPs) subdivided into distinct tasks. As reported in Section 3, the project duration is 36 months, divided into three main phases. Figure 3.1.1 provides an overall visual representation of the work package structure through a PERT chart, highlighting how the six WPs are interrelated. Figure 3.1.2 visualises their timing in the form of a GANT chart.

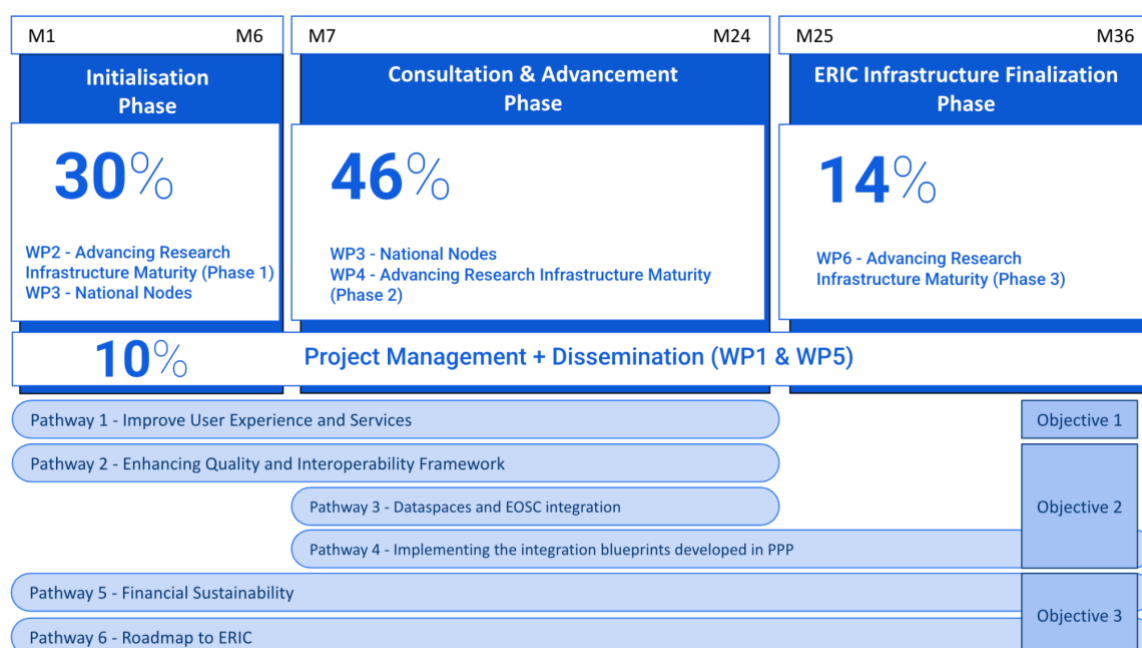


Figure 3.1.1 Work Packages organisation and budget distribution

3.1.1 Overall structure of work plan

The six WPs are organised based on each of the project's phases. Every phase has its own management WP (WP1, WP3, and WP5). These WPs are in charge of the overall project management and also include aspects related to the future ERIC, with special attention on strengthening the administrative, legal, and technological skills for the central HUB and the nodes, as well as the involvement of stakeholders. WP2, 4, and 6 include tasks contributing to the six pathways expected in the project. Moreover, WP2, 3, 4, and 6 will be responsible for putting SoBigData RI in a position to submit (through the MUR) the ERIC establishment procedure required by the European Commission and will follow its development, identifying and addressing legal issues such as IPR protection, monitoring the risk, and HR management frameworks and systems.¹³

¹³ A clear IPR management policy along with a HR Education and Training policy and Risk management have been drafted during the SoBigData RI PPP, and available in the deliverables D2.3 - PPP - IPR Management Policy and (a) model content provider agreement(s) - <https://data.d4science.net/UPMU6>; D2.2 - PPP - Agreed statutes of SoBigData RI and necessary legal documents - <https://data.d4science.net/kWSIH>; D2.5 - PPP - HR policy and HR training policy.pdf - <https://data.d4science.net/eQr2j> and D2.4 - PPP - SoBigData RI Risk management plan - <https://data.d4science.net/k51a0>.

The management structure of the SoBigData IP (inherited and stable with respect to SoBigData RI PPP) is instrumental for achieving the implementation objectives for the future SoBigData ERIC. The project organisational structure (shown in Fig. 3.1.1.1) provides the foundation to ensure the timely and accurate completion of the project's objectives.

	Leader	M1 M4		M7 M10		M13 M16		M19 M22		M25 M28 M31 M34			
		Phase 1		Phase 2		Phase 2		Phase 2		Phase 3			
		Q1	Q2	Q1	Q2	Q3	Q4	Q5	Q6	Q1	Q2	Q3	Q4
WP1 Management	CNR												
T1.1 Initialisation Phase Administration and Financial Management	CNR												
T1.2 Internal Capacity Building	UNIFI												
T1.3 Stakeholder Engagement	TOUR4EU												
T1.4 Co-design and Implementation of a KPI Framework with Open Infrastructure Monitoring Tools	OpenAIRE												
WP2 Advancing Research Infrastructure Maturity (Phase 1)	SLEX												
T2.1 Access Policies Definition	CNR												
T2.2 Financial & Budgeting	X-officio												
T2.3 Complementing Statutes with Other Relevant Policies	SLEX												
T2.4 Consolidate Documents for Step-1 ERIC Application	SLEX												
T2.5 Supporting BGR	CNR												
T2.6 Service Selection	CNR												
T2.7 SoBigData Catalogue Review	CNR												
WP3 National Nodes	CNR												
T3.1 Implementaion of the Italian Node	CNR												
T3.2 Implementaion of the German Node	LUH												
T3.3 Implementaion of the Greek Node	ATHENA												
T3.4 Implementaion of the Dutch Node	UvA												
T3.5 Implementaion of the Spanish Node	BSC												
T3.6 Implementaion of the UK node	KCL												
WP4 Advancing Research Infrastructure Maturity (Phase 2)	CNR												
T4.1 Managing BGR	CNR												
T4.2 Improve User Experience	CNR												
T4.3 Technological Integration and Service Deployment	CNR												
T4.4 Interoperable Metadata Harmonization & EOSC Integration Framework	CNR												
T4.5 Partnerships and Funding	CNR												
WP5 Management Finalisation	CNR												
T5.1 Finalisation Phase Administration and Financial Management	CNR												
T5.2 Finalize Internal Capacity Building	UNIFI												
T5.3 Long-term Plan for Stakeholder Engagement	TOUR4EU												
T5.4 Completing Co-design and Implementation of the Open Infrastructure Monitoring Tools	OpenAIRE												
WP6 Advancing Research Infrastructure Maturity (Phase 3)	CNR												
T6.1 ERIC Establishment Support	CNR												
T6.2 Services Maintenance	CNR												
T6.3 Finalization of the Open Infrastructure Monitoring Tools	OpenAIRE												
T6.4 Partnerships and Funding Assessment	CNR												

Figure 3.1.2 SoBigData IP Gantt

The Project Management Team (PMT) will be formed by the Coordinator (Dr. Roberto Trasarti - CNR), the Project Manager (Dr. Valerio Grossi - CNR), the Infrastructure Manager (Dr. Michela Natilli - CNR), the Communication Manager (Daniele Fadda - CNR), and the Financial Officer (Ilaria Barsanti - CNR). The Project Management Board (PMB) consists of all national node representative leaders (one for each node of the RI), WP leaders, and Prof. Fosca Giannotti from SNS, Prof. Dino Pedreschi from UNIFI as deputy coordinators. PMB is led and chaired by the Coordinator (who also represents the central hub). The PMB is the main decision-making body of the project. It is responsible for strategic planning, operational management, and decision-making for all activities and managerial matters.

The BGR is the body that will ensure the smooth transition of the RI into the implementation of the SoBigData ERIC. The procedure for establishing this board started during the SoBigData RI PPP. The Italian university and research ministry (MUR) has already contacted each member state belonging to RI to form this board. Finally, the project will also have a Project Advisory Board (PAB) comprising three external scientific experts to supervise and provide feedback to the PMB. PMT has connections with the project PAB and the Project Management Board (PMB) to ensure that project activities, outcomes, and strategies are harmonised with planned requirements and

expectations. The PMB has contact with the rest of the partners represented in the General Partners Meeting (GPM). The Coordinator (supported by PMT and node representative leaders) has connections with MUR and the BGR.

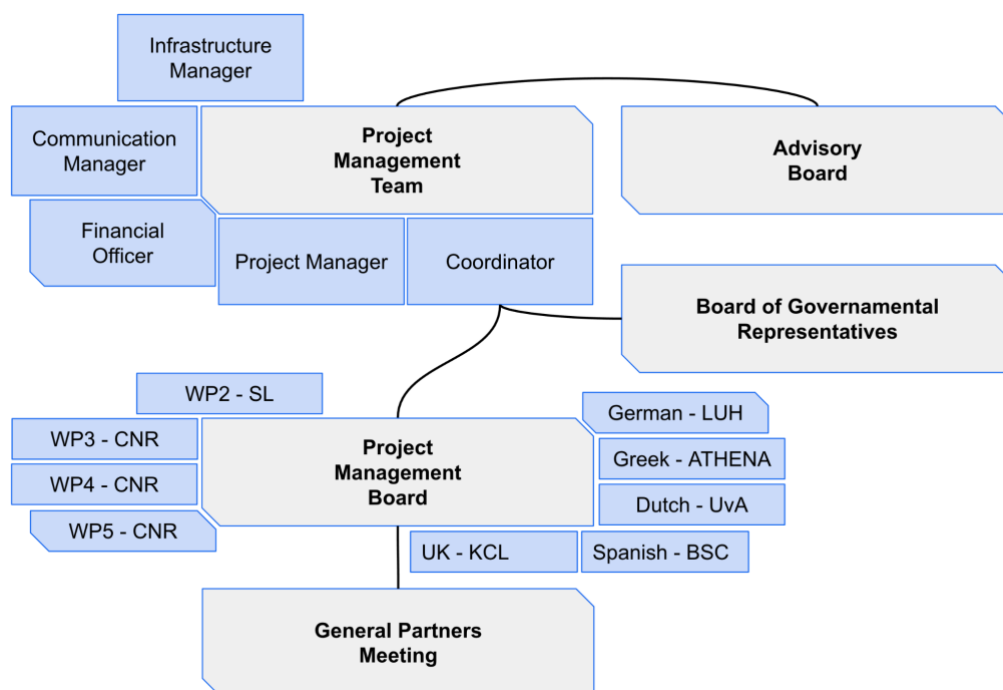


Figure 3.1.1.1 The organisational structure of the SoBigData IP

All the employees' item costs reported in the project's budget are weighted averages reflecting the actual costs of personnel working in the various institutions and the effort expected. This means that costs of Seniors and Juniors at different stages of their careers may differ in different WPs and from national costs¹⁴.

Table 3.1g 'Subcontracting cost item'

No subcontracting is foreseen in the project

3.2 Capacity of participants and consortium as a whole

The SoBigData IP consortium comprises 26 partners from 9 countries. 6 countries will host a RI node: Greece, Spain, Italy, Germany, the Netherlands, and the UK, and additional three countries: Bulgaria (as observer), Belgium, and Sweden (supporting the SoBigData IP action). The core consortium has been consolidated through the preparation phase. It represents the leading European research and data centre groups that shaped the big social data analytics arena in the past decade.

The partners participating in the different SoBigData RI nodes represent a mix of data and research centres that focus on AI, big data analytics, data science applications from multiple perspectives: 1) e-infrastructures, data centres, online services developers (CNR, EGI, OpenAIRE, BSC, ATHENA, UNIVAQ, DFKI); 2) AI, big data analytics, data mining and machine learning (CNR, UNIFI, SNS,

¹⁴ Considering as reference the EC lump sum personnel averages:

https://dashboard.tech.ec.europa.eu/qs_digit_dashboard_mt/public/sense/app/10526974-8664-4f61-8b86-8ecd3a3c8aec/

UNIVAQ); text, social media mining (UNIFI, CNR, LUH); social network analysis (CNR, KCL, IMT); web intelligence (LUH, CNR, UPF); mobility analytics (CNR, UNIFI, UPF); visual analytics (CNR, UvA); complex network science (SNS, IMT); complex systems focussed on modelling social and economic phenomena (IMT, SNS); Ethics and Legal aspects of data protection (LUH, SSSA, REPHRAIN); Privacy preserving techniques with testbeds on national data archives (UNIFI, URV, REPHRAIN, CNR); emerging new technologies 5G and beyond (UNIBO and UNIPA). Different partners have expertise in various scientific domains: Digital Humanities (KCL, REPHRAIN, UCM); Macroeconomics, Monetary Economics, Labour Economics and Inequalities (SSSA, SNS); Statistics, Demography and Quality of Life (UNIROMA1); Computational Social Science and Media Studies (UvA, UNIFI, KCL, CNR, UCM); Risk reduction, post-disaster processes, city resilience and urban sustainability (UNIVAQ, IMT); Models and policies for sustainable use of energy, urban resources, and infrastructures (IMT); Ethical data Science (TUDelft, SSSA); Technology transfer company; Innovation managers, legal and financial aspects (SSSA). The SoBigData IP consortium will pursue its objectives (see Section 1.1) by operating at various levels: 1) Membership - while the legal and organizational structure of the RI will be finally defined during the implementation phase, the SoBigData IP consortium already possesses organizational maturity, originating in the robust design underpinning of the H2020 SoBigData and SoBigData++ projects and HE SoBigData RI PPP (grant agreements No. 654024, 871042, 101079043); 2) User strategy & Networking - the SoBigData RI has a large and committed user base (+14,000 registered users). Generally, the RI will continue to undertake European and international research networking activities. At the same time, SoBigData IP will enhance a network of cooperating institutions (and projects) by integrating rules and requisites defined in law(s) and regulation(s). 3) Excellence - the SoBigData RI's scientific leadership includes some leading figures in big data analytics, computational social science, digital humanities, city planning, and Artificial Intelligence. All partners have extensive experience in acquiring, managing, and analysing real-world big data and AI applications from heterogeneous sources and have the capacity to transform their findings into tools and technologies usable by the scientific community at large. As reported in Section 3.1, SoBigData IP is coordinated by CNR (Italy). The coordinator and the node representative leader for Italy is Dr. Roberto Trasarti, senior researcher at CNR, who led the H2020 SoBigData++ and SoBigData RI PPP projects. Other leading researchers are **SNS**: Professor Fosca Giannotti, the previous coordinator of SoBigData projects (2015-2021). Currently, she is the Italian delegate of Cluster 4 (Digital, Industry, and Space) in Horizon Europe and Director of the Regional Center on Big Data and AI (CBDAI). She is also PI of the ERC project “XAI – Science and Technology for the Explanation of Decision Making”; **UNIFI**: Professor Dino Pedreschi is member of the Italian delegation OECD of Global Alliance on Trustworthy AI, AI expert at the Italian Ministry of Research and Google Research Award recipient in 2008; **TUDelft**: Professor Jeroen Van Den Hoven is full professor of moral philosophy at TUDelft and director of 4TU Centre for Ethics and Technology. He is the editor-in-chief of the journal ‘Ethics and Information Technology’ (Springer). He is a permanent member of the European Group on Ethics (EGE) to the European Commission. **UNIVAQ**: Professor Antiniscia Di Marco was a member of the scientific committee of the Territori Aperti Italian Project and is responsible for the Territori Aperti research infrastructure. She is the research leader of the data science and bioinformatics group at UNIVAQ, which covers data analysis of health data and quality of AI-based systems (e.g., fairness, efficiency, and effectiveness). She is the coordinator of PINKAMP, a project devoted to promoting the participation of females in STEM studies. **SSSA** and **SLEX**: Professor Giovanni Comandé is a full professor of Comparative law at Scuola Superiore Sant’Anna, coordinates Lider Lab, a laboratory devoted to rights and regulation, and several projects related to SoBigData IP (e.g., www.legalityattentivedatascientists.eu), and is the founder and President of SmartLex (**SLEX**), a leading SME with experience in law and technology developing software for legality attentive informatics. He is also the National representative for the ELSI in the European '1+ Million Genomes' Initiative that is leading towards the establishment of the European Genomic Infrastructure as EDIC, offering, with his expertise and involvement, a bridge between two reputed and innovative legal instruments of the EC.

Other leading researchers are also node representative leaders. Node representative leader for **Germany**: Professor Wolfgang Nejdl and Dr. Marco Fisichella (**LUH**). Professor Nejdl is full

professor of computer science at Leibniz Universität Hannover since 1995. Prof. Nejdl has been involved in numerous European projects and currently leads the L3S Research Center and the Data Science Institute at Leibniz Universität Hannover. Dr. Fisichella has over 15 years of experience in AI across industry and academia. Since April 2021, he has led a research group at the L3S Research Center. Previously, he served as Director of R&D at Otto Group (2015–2021). He is the coordinator of the German node within the SoBigData PPP. Node representative for the **Netherlands**: Professor Richard Rogers (*UvA*). Professor Rogers is University Professor and holds the Chair in New Media & Digital Culture at the University of Amsterdam. He is also Director of the Govcom.org Foundation (Amsterdam) and the Digital Methods Initiative. Previously, Rogers worked as Senior Advisor to Infodrome, the Dutch Governmental Information Society initiative. Node representative leader for the **United Kingdom**: Dr. Mark Coté (*KCL*). Dr. Coté is Reader in Data and Society and Chair of Arts & Humanities Peer Review College at the Department of Digital Humanities at King's College London. He has been PI or CI on EPSRC, H2020, and AHRC grants valued at more than £10 million. Dr. Coté is currently a PI and Strategic Board member of REPHRAIN, the UK's national research centre for online harm mitigation and data empowerment. Node representative leader for **Spain**: Professor Ulises Cortes (*BSC*). Professor Cortes is a professor of Artificial Intelligence at the Polytechnic University of Catalonia (*UPC*) and director of the High Performance Artificial Intelligence Group at the Barcelona Supercomputing Center (*BSC*). He is a founding member of the Catalan Association for Artificial Intelligence (ACIA) and a member of the Advisory Council on Artificial Intelligence, Ethics, and Digital Rights of the city of Barcelona, of the Catalan Observatory for Ethics in Artificial Intelligence (OIEAC), of the executive board of the Spanish Association for Artificial Intelligence (AEPIA), of the board of the European Association for Artificial Intelligence (EurAi), and of the Global Partnership on Artificial Intelligence (GPAI). Node Representative for **Greece**: Dr. Vassilis Katsouros. Dr. Katsouros is the Director of the Institute for Language and Speech Processing (ILSP) at the Athena Research Center (ATHENA). He is the research director at ILSP, the Institute of Language and Speech Processing, and has been a member of the Board of Athena RC and Vice-President since 2019. He has also been a member of the Board at the Information Society S.A. since June 2019.

4 Ethics self-assessment

The Consortium will ensure that all ethics issues related to activities in the grant are addressed in compliance with ethical principles, the applicable international and national law, and the provisions set out in the Grant Agreement. This includes the ethics issues identified in this report and any additional ethics issues that may emerge in the course of the grant. In case any substantial new ethics issues arise, the Consortium will inform the granting authority. For each ethics issue applicable, the Consortium will follow the guidance provided in the How to complete your ethics self-assessment¹⁵.

4.1 Ethical dimension of the objectives, methodology and likely impact

The SoBigData RI positions on ethics are not a supplementary concern but represent an integral part of its objectives and methodologies. SoBigData IP ensures compliance with ethical principles and relevant legislation through robust governance, proportional data handling, informed consent, legal-ethical auditing, fostering Open Science practices and research that ensures adherence to the European Convention of Human Rights and the EU Charter of Fundamental Rights standards. The SoBigData IP project fulfils formal legal obligations and establishes an ongoing ecosystem of accountability and transparency across its methodology, outputs, and long-term impact.

SoBigData IP will contribute to the societal impact of the RI. Under this perspective, the broader societal impact is the implementation of a European RI that provides a platform and a practice ecosystem that promotes the ethical use of the data and contributes to training new generations of responsible data scientists. This objective is functional to the promotion of the “fifth freedom” (free movement of research, innovation, and knowledge in the EU) in line with the Commission’s

¹⁵ https://ec.europa.eu/info/funding-tenders/opportunities/docs/2021-2027/common/guidance/how-to-complete-your-ethics-self-assessment_en.pdf

“European Strategy on Research and Technology Infrastructures”. In this regard, the RI will provide the means to efficiently and securely store and manage research data, in compliance with the FAIR principles, thus facilitating the reuse of data for research and enabling the building of a strong infrastructure ecosystem as required by the Strategy.

The RI defends democracy not through surveillance or censorship but through resilience, inclusion, and empowerment: the datasets and methodologies of the RI are already used and can be used in the future to carry out research regarding misinformation, echo chambers, and polarization as threats to democratic processes, and to find effective remedies and counteractions, also with the development of Artificial Intelligence tools. The RI can also facilitate the detection of systemic risks in the Union posed by Very Large Online Platforms and Very Large Search Engines, enabling researchers to carry out significant studies in line with the objectives of the Digital Services Act. The SoBigData IP will be a critical element to enable the RI to function for such purposes.

The SoBigData IP project does not imply directly manipulating and managing sensitive datasets. Still, it is involved in improving and updating the SoBigData catalogue (in terms of metadata management, publication procedure, and information visualisation). The RI catalogue is already configured to manage personal data and sensitive information. It is essential to highlight that in case of activities with minors or vulnerable groups, the SoBigData RI (put in place in the project) will ensure the protection of minors who might be involved, and guarantee a safe environment for vulnerable groups, including the provision of clear and understandable information regarding the study and the processing of their personal data, and the involvement of the holder of parental responsibility when required by the applicable legislation. All the new services deployed during SoBigData IP will be done under a methodological design that reflects the RIs' ethical awareness at every development stage.

The RI combines computational, social, legal, and ethical expertise to ensure that detection and countermeasures are scientifically robust, socially and ethically grounded, and normatively compliant. Each partner institution maintains sovereignty over its own services and datasets while contributing to a global model via encrypted updates, significantly reducing risks of privacy breaches or centralised data exploitation. In addition, bias-mitigation and fairness checks are embedded in the model design, with explicit attention to underrepresented languages and minority discourses that could otherwise be misclassified.

4.2 Compliance with ethical principles and relevant legislation

SoBigData IP (as the SoBigData RI implementer) adheres to the EU vision of Responsible Research and Innovation and operationalises values that drive Europe's Digital Decade and the Commission's European Strategy on Research and Technology Infrastructures. Since 2015, the role of H2020 SoBigData projects is to operationalise the ELSEC (Ethical, Social, Legal, Economic, and Cultural Aspects) values within AI and machine learning. Moreover, the FAIR (Findable, Accessible, Interoperable) principles and the FACT (Fair, Accountable, Confidential and Transparent) principles are applied in SoBigData RI's activities for data science and the development of AI applications.

The primary goal of the SoBigData RI is to provide advanced tools for understanding and managing societal complexity, enabling research for the benefit of society. A necessary step to achieve this goal is the inclusion of a sustainable and ethical framework in the ERIC statute (see WP2 task T2.4). This can be demanding in an environment where regulations tend to change. The fact that the potential of technology is not always captured in time by the legislative system can result in gaps that need to be anticipated and, if possible, prevented. The RI is facing a continuous evolution of the ethical-legal framework: after the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR), the Digital Services Act (DSA), and the AI Act, several legislative initiatives are developing new ethical-legal dimensions impacting data processing for statistics as well as scientific purposes and innovation. For these reasons, the SoBigData IP plan to implement a pipeline for data science experiments and services that adheres to the legal-ethical principles, accommodates within-infrastructure ethical

issues, as well as aims at answering new questions on the scope, interpretation, and application of the GDPR, DSA, AI act, and the new regulations or directives that will be adopted by the European Union in this field, along with the expanding role of AI, machine learning and data mining.

ANNEX 2

ESTIMATED BUDGET (LUMP SUM BREAKDOWN) FOR THE ACTION

Forms of funding	Estimated EU contribution						Maximum grant amount ¹
	Estimated eligible lump sum contributions (per work package)						
	WP1 Management	WP2 Advancing Research Infrastructure Maturity (Phase 1)	WP3 National Nodes	WP4 Advancing Research Infrastructure Maturity (Phase 2)	WP5 Management Finalisation	WP6 Advancing Research Infrastructure Maturity (Phase 3)	
	Lump sum contribution	Lump sum contribution	Lump sum contribution	Lump sum contribution	Lump sum contribution	Lump sum contribution	
	a	b	c	d	e	f	g = a + b + c + d + e + f
1 - CNR	24 919.75	48 222.10	100 462.70	109 393.40	22 166.75	52 790.10	357 954.80
2 - UNIP1	3 883.15	2 074.70	9 108.45	14 550.90	4 195.15	2 186.65	35 999.00
3 - SNS	3 440.63	690.63	1 381.25	2 762.50	2 315.63	690.63	11 281.27
4 - IMT	3 712.50	587.50	1 175.00	2 350.00	3 712.50	587.50	12 125.00
5 - UNIVAQ	3 638.63	1 915.89	7 024.93	25 545.20	3 638.63	2 554.52	44 317.80
6 - UNIROMA1	3 816.25	1 382.50	3 456.25	11 751.25	3 816.25	1 382.50	25 605.00
7 - SSSA	4 306.25	14 437.50	5 775.00	21 656.25	3 031.25	5 775.00	54 981.25
8 - UNIBO	3 762.50	637.50	1 275.00	2 550.00	2 262.50	637.50	11 125.00
9 - UNIPA	3 441.53	691.53	1 383.06	2 766.12	2 191.53	691.53	11 165.30
10 - LUH	4 100.00	4 562.50	9 125.00	13 687.50	4 100.00	4 562.50	40 137.50
11 - ATHENA	4 159.63	3 448.75	6 897.50	17 933.50	4 159.63	3 448.75	40 047.76
12 - OpenAIRE	3 814.75	2 759.00	0.00	4 828.25	2 252.25	4 828.25	18 482.50
13 - UvA	6 135.75	9 655.00	15 448.00	6 758.50	4 448.25	4 827.50	47 273.00
14 - TUDelft	4 216.53	3 866.12	9 665.30	14 497.95	966.53	7 116.12	40 328.55
15 - EGI	4 296.25	1 046.25	1 046.25	21 971.25	4 296.25	1 046.25	33 702.50
16 - BSC	5 833.12	8 124.98	21 666.60	27 083.25	4 208.25	10 833.30	77 749.50
17 - URV	3 529.50	654.50	1 309.00	2 618.00	2 092.00	654.50	10 857.50
18 - UPF	649.06	3 524.05	1 298.13	2 596.25	2 086.55	649.06	10 803.10
19 - UCM	6 606.63	3 033.13	7 279.50	21 231.88	4 606.63	3 033.13	45 790.90
20 - KCL	13 865.55	9 168.05	9 168.05	9 168.05	11 516.80	14 636.80	67 523.30
21 - REPHRAIN	3 976.63	976.63	976.63	11 719.50	3 976.63	1 953.25	23 579.27
22 - CSD	3 866.00	616.00	0.00	2 464.00	2 241.00	616.00	9 803.00
23 - SLEX	5 687.50	34 375.00	6 875.00	35 062.50	687.50	37 125.00	119 812.50
24 - TOUR4EU	16 250.00	23 437.50	0.00	0.00	30 937.50	4 375.00	75 000.00
25 - X-officio	7 181.25	13 503.13	0.00	43 768.75	6 773.86	26 646.14	97 873.13
26 - DFKI	3 707.05	3 083.60	10 278.65	14 390.10	3 707.05	5 139.30	40 305.75
Σ consortium	152 796.39	196 474.04	232 075.25	443 104.85	140 386.87	198 786.78	1 363 624.18

¹ The 'maximum grant amount' is the maximum grant amount fixed in the grant agreement (on the basis of the sum of the beneficiaries' lump sum shares for the work packages).

ANNEX 3

ACCESSION FORM FOR BENEFICIARIES

UNIVERSITA DI PISA (UNIPD), PIC 999862712, established in LUNGARNO PACINOTTI 43/44, PISA 56126, Italy,

hereby agrees

to become beneficiary

in Agreement No 101292277 — SoBigData IP ('the Agreement')

between CONSIGLIO NAZIONALE DELLE RICERCHE (CNR) **and** the **European Research Executive Agency (REA)** ('EU executive agency' or 'granting authority'), under the powers delegated by the European Commission ('European Commission'),

and mandates

the coordinator to submit and sign in its name and on its behalf any **amendments** to the Agreement, in accordance with Article 39.

By signing this accession form, the beneficiary accepts the grant and agrees to implement it in accordance with the Agreement, with all the obligations and terms and conditions it sets out.

SIGNATURE

For the beneficiary

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ACCESSION FORM FOR BENEFICIARIES

SCUOLA NORMALE SUPERIORE (SNS), PIC 999886962, established in PIAZZA DEI CAVALIERI 7, PISA 56126, Italy,

hereby agrees

to become beneficiary

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For the beneficiary

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SCUOLA IMT (ISTITUZIONI, MERCATI, TECNOLOGIE) ALTI STUDI DI LUCCA (IMT),
PIC 965146412, established in PIAZZA SAN PONZIANO 6, LUCCA 55100, Italy,

hereby agrees

to become beneficiary

in Agreement No 101292277 — SoBigData IP ('the Agreement')

between CONSIGLIO NAZIONALE DELLE RICERCHE (CNR) **and** the **European Research Executive Agency (REA)** ('EU executive agency' or 'granting authority'), under the powers delegated by the European Commission ('European Commission'),

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For the beneficiary

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ACCESSION FORM FOR BENEFICIARIES

UNIVERSITA DEGLI STUDI DELL'AQUILA (UNIVAQ), PIC 999859511, established in PIAZZA SANTA MARGHERITA 2, L AQUILA 67100, Italy,

hereby agrees

to become beneficiary

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between CONSIGLIO NAZIONALE DELLE RICERCHE (CNR) **and** the **European Research Executive Agency (REA)** ('EU executive agency' or 'granting authority'), under the powers delegated by the European Commission ('European Commission'),

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ACCESSION FORM FOR BENEFICIARIES

UNIVERSITA DEGLI STUDI DI ROMA LA SAPIENZA (UNIROMA1), PIC 999987745,
established in Piazzale Aldo Moro 5, ROMA 00185, Italy,

hereby agrees

to become beneficiary

in Agreement No 101292277 — SoBigData IP ('the Agreement')

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ACCESSION FORM FOR BENEFICIARIES

SCUOLA SUPERIORE DI STUDI UNIVERSITARI E DI PERFEZIONAMENTO S ANNA (SSSA), PIC 999884731, established in PIAZZA MARTIRI DELLA LIBERTA 33, PISA 56127, Italy,

hereby agrees

to become beneficiary

in Agreement No 101292277 — SoBigData IP ('the Agreement')

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For the beneficiary

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ACCESSION FORM FOR BENEFICIARIES

ALMA MATER STUDIORUM - UNIVERSITA DI BOLOGNA (UNIBO), PIC 999993953,
established in VIA ZAMBONI 33, BOLOGNA 40126, Italy,

hereby agrees

to become beneficiary

in Agreement No 101292277 — SoBigData IP ('the Agreement')

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For the beneficiary

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ACCESSION FORM FOR BENEFICIARIES

UNIVERSITA DEGLI STUDI DI PALERMO (UNIPA), PIC 999734284, established in PIAZZA MARINA 61, PALERMO 90133, Italy,

hereby agrees

to become beneficiary

in Agreement No 101292277 — SoBigData IP ('the Agreement')

between CONSIGLIO NAZIONALE DELLE RICERCHE (CNR) **and** the **European Research Executive Agency (REA)** ('EU executive agency' or 'granting authority'), under the powers delegated by the European Commission ('European Commission'),

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SIGNATURE

For the beneficiary

ANNEX 3

ACCESSION FORM FOR BENEFICIARIES

GOTTFRIED WILHELM LEIBNIZ UNIVERSITAET HANNOVER (LUH), PIC 999981828,
established in WELFENGARTEN 1, HANNOVER 30167, Germany,

hereby agrees

to become beneficiary

in Agreement No 101292277 — SoBigData IP ('the Agreement')

between CONSIGLIO NAZIONALE DELLE RICERCHE (CNR) **and** the **European Research Executive Agency (REA)** ('EU executive agency' or 'granting authority'), under the powers delegated by the European Commission ('European Commission'),

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SIGNATURE

For the beneficiary

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ACCESSION FORM FOR BENEFICIARIES

ATHINA-EREVNITIKO KENTRO KAINOTOMIAS STIS TECHNOLOGIES TIS PLIROFORIAS, TON EPIKOINONION KAI TIS GNOSIS (ATHENA), PIC 999562788, established in ARTEMIDOS 6 KAI EPIDAVROU, MAROUSSI 151 25, Greece,

hereby agrees

to become beneficiary

in Agreement No 101292277 — SoBigData IP ('the Agreement')

between CONSIGLIO NAZIONALE DELLE RICERCHE (CNR) **and the European Research Executive Agency (REA)** ('EU executive agency' or 'granting authority'), under the powers delegated by the European Commission ('European Commission'),

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SIGNATURE

For the beneficiary

ANNEX 3

ACCESSION FORM FOR BENEFICIARIES

OPENAIRE AMKE (OpenAIRE), PIC 903914192, established in 6 ARTEMIDOS STR & EPIDAVROU, MAROUSI 151 25, Greece,

hereby agrees

to become beneficiary

in Agreement No 101292277 — SoBigData IP ('the Agreement')

between CONSIGLIO NAZIONALE DELLE RICERCHE (CNR) **and** the **European Research Executive Agency (REA)** ('EU executive agency' or 'granting authority'), under the powers delegated by the European Commission ('European Commission'),

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SIGNATURE

For the beneficiary

ANNEX 3

ACCESSION FORM FOR BENEFICIARIES

UNIVERSITEIT VAN AMSTERDAM (UvA), PIC 999985708, established in SPUI 21, AMSTERDAM 1012WX, Netherlands,

hereby agrees

to become beneficiary

in Agreement No 101292277 — SoBigData IP ('the Agreement')

between CONSIGLIO NAZIONALE DELLE RICERCHE (CNR) **and the European Research Executive Agency (REA)** ('EU executive agency' or 'granting authority'), under the powers delegated by the European Commission ('European Commission'),

and mandates

the coordinator to submit and sign in its name and on its behalf any **amendments** to the Agreement, in accordance with Article 39.

By signing this accession form, the beneficiary accepts the grant and agrees to implement it in accordance with the Agreement, with all the obligations and terms and conditions it sets out.

SIGNATURE

For the beneficiary

ANNEX 3

ACCESSION FORM FOR BENEFICIARIES

TECHNISCHE UNIVERSITEIT DELFT (TUDelft), PIC 999977366, established in STEVINWEG 1, DELFT 2628 CN, Netherlands,

hereby agrees

to become beneficiary

in Agreement No 101292277 — SoBigData IP ('the Agreement')

between CONSIGLIO NAZIONALE DELLE RICERCHE (CNR) **and** the **European Research Executive Agency (REA)** ('EU executive agency' or 'granting authority'), under the powers delegated by the European Commission ('European Commission'),

and mandates

the coordinator to submit and sign in its name and on its behalf any **amendments** to the Agreement, in accordance with Article 39.

By signing this accession form, the beneficiary accepts the grant and agrees to implement it in accordance with the Agreement, with all the obligations and terms and conditions it sets out.

SIGNATURE

For the beneficiary

ANNEX 3

ACCESSION FORM FOR BENEFICIARIES

STICHTING EGI (EGI), PIC 989221715, established in SCIENCE PARK 140, AMSTERDAM 1098 XG, Netherlands,

hereby agrees

to become beneficiary

in Agreement No 101292277 — SoBigData IP ('the Agreement')

between CONSIGLIO NAZIONALE DELLE RICERCHE (CNR) **and** the **European Research Executive Agency (REA)** ('EU executive agency' or 'granting authority'), under the powers delegated by the European Commission ('European Commission'),

and mandates

the coordinator to submit and sign in its name and on its behalf any **amendments** to the Agreement, in accordance with Article 39.

By signing this accession form, the beneficiary accepts the grant and agrees to implement it in accordance with the Agreement, with all the obligations and terms and conditions it sets out.

SIGNATURE

For the beneficiary

ANNEX 3

ACCESSION FORM FOR BENEFICIARIES

BARCELONA SUPERCOMPUTING CENTER CENTRO NACIONAL DE SUPERCOMPUTACION (BSC), PIC 999655520, established in CALLE JORDI GIRONA 31, BARCELONA 08034, Spain,

hereby agrees

to become beneficiary

in Agreement No 101292277 — SoBigData IP ('the Agreement')

between CONSIGLIO NAZIONALE DELLE RICERCHE (CNR) **and the European Research Executive Agency (REA)** ('EU executive agency' or 'granting authority'), under the powers delegated by the European Commission ('European Commission'),

and mandates

the coordinator to submit and sign in its name and on its behalf any **amendments** to the Agreement, in accordance with Article 39.

By signing this accession form, the beneficiary accepts the grant and agrees to implement it in accordance with the Agreement, with all the obligations and terms and conditions it sets out.

SIGNATURE

For the beneficiary

ANNEX 3

ACCESSION FORM FOR BENEFICIARIES

UNIVERSITAT ROVIRA I VIRGILI (URV), PIC 999880560, established in CARRER DE ESCORXADOR, TARRAGONA 43003, Spain,

hereby agrees

to become beneficiary

in Agreement No 101292277 — SoBigData IP ('the Agreement')

between CONSIGLIO NAZIONALE DELLE RICERCHE (CNR) **and** the **European Research Executive Agency (REA)** ('EU executive agency' or 'granting authority'), under the powers delegated by the European Commission ('European Commission'),

and mandates

the coordinator to submit and sign in its name and on its behalf any **amendments** to the Agreement, in accordance with Article 39.

By signing this accession form, the beneficiary accepts the grant and agrees to implement it in accordance with the Agreement, with all the obligations and terms and conditions it sets out.

SIGNATURE

For the beneficiary

ANNEX 3

ACCESSION FORM FOR BENEFICIARIES

UNIVERSIDAD POMPEU FABRA (UPF), PIC 999867077, established in PLACA DE LA MERCE, 10-12, BARCELONA 08002, Spain,

hereby agrees

to become beneficiary

in Agreement No 101292277 — SoBigData IP ('the Agreement')

between CONSIGLIO NAZIONALE DELLE RICERCHE (CNR) **and** the **European Research Executive Agency (REA)** ('EU executive agency' or 'granting authority'), under the powers delegated by the European Commission ('European Commission'),

and mandates

the coordinator to submit and sign in its name and on its behalf any **amendments** to the Agreement, in accordance with Article 39.

By signing this accession form, the beneficiary accepts the grant and agrees to implement it in accordance with the Agreement, with all the obligations and terms and conditions it sets out.

SIGNATURE

For the beneficiary

ANNEX 3

ACCESSION FORM FOR BENEFICIARIES

UNIVERSIDAD COMPLUTENSE DE MADRID (UCM), PIC 999874546, established in AVENIDA DE SENECA 2, MADRID 28040, Spain,

hereby agrees

to become beneficiary

in Agreement No 101292277 — SoBigData IP ('the Agreement')

between CONSIGLIO NAZIONALE DELLE RICERCHE (CNR) **and** the **European Research Executive Agency (REA)** ('EU executive agency' or 'granting authority'), under the powers delegated by the European Commission ('European Commission'),

and mandates

the coordinator to submit and sign in its name and on its behalf any **amendments** to the Agreement, in accordance with Article 39.

By signing this accession form, the beneficiary accepts the grant and agrees to implement it in accordance with the Agreement, with all the obligations and terms and conditions it sets out.

SIGNATURE

For the beneficiary

ANNEX 3

ACCESSION FORM FOR BENEFICIARIES

KING'S COLLEGE LONDON (KCL), PIC 999981052, established in STRAND, LONDON WC2R 2LS, United Kingdom,

hereby agrees

to become beneficiary

in Agreement No 101292277 — SoBigData IP ('the Agreement')

between CONSIGLIO NAZIONALE DELLE RICERCHE (CNR) **and** the **European Research Executive Agency (REA)** ('EU executive agency' or 'granting authority'), under the powers delegated by the European Commission ('European Commission'),

and mandates

the coordinator to submit and sign in its name and on its behalf any **amendments** to the Agreement, in accordance with Article 39.

By signing this accession form, the beneficiary accepts the grant and agrees to implement it in accordance with the Agreement, with all the obligations and terms and conditions it sets out.

SIGNATURE

For the beneficiary

ANNEX 3

ACCESSION FORM FOR BENEFICIARIES

UNIVERSITY OF BRISTOL (REPHRAIN), PIC 999974262, established in BEACON HOUSE QUEENS ROAD, BRISTOL BS8 1QU, United Kingdom,

hereby agrees

to become beneficiary

in Agreement No 101292277 — SoBigData IP ('the Agreement')

between CONSIGLIO NAZIONALE DELLE RICERCHE (CNR) **and the European Research Executive Agency (REA)** ('EU executive agency' or 'granting authority'), under the powers delegated by the European Commission ('European Commission'),

and mandates

the coordinator to submit and sign in its name and on its behalf any **amendments** to the Agreement, in accordance with Article 39.

By signing this accession form, the beneficiary accepts the grant and agrees to implement it in accordance with the Agreement, with all the obligations and terms and conditions it sets out.

SIGNATURE

For the beneficiary

ANNEX 3

ACCESSION FORM FOR BENEFICIARIES

CENTER FOR THE STUDY OF DEMOCRACY (CSD), PIC 999548529, established in ALEXANDER ZHENDOV STREET 5, SOFIA 1113, Bulgaria,

hereby agrees

to become beneficiary

in Agreement No 101292277 — SoBigData IP ('the Agreement')

between CONSIGLIO NAZIONALE DELLE RICERCHE (CNR) **and** the **European Research Executive Agency (REA)** ('EU executive agency' or 'granting authority'), under the powers delegated by the European Commission ('European Commission'),

and mandates

the coordinator to submit and sign in its name and on its behalf any **amendments** to the Agreement, in accordance with Article 39.

By signing this accession form, the beneficiary accepts the grant and agrees to implement it in accordance with the Agreement, with all the obligations and terms and conditions it sets out.

SIGNATURE

For the beneficiary

ANNEX 3

ACCESSION FORM FOR BENEFICIARIES

SMARTEX SRL SOCIETA DI PRODOTTI E SERVIZI GIURIDICI INTERDISCIPLINARI (SLEX), PIC 925521039, established in VIA LENIN 132G, SAN GIULIANO TERME 56017, Italy,

hereby agrees

to become beneficiary

in Agreement No 101292277 — SoBigData IP ('the Agreement')

between CONSIGLIO NAZIONALE DELLE RICERCHE (CNR) **and the European Research Executive Agency (REA)** ('EU executive agency' or 'granting authority'), under the powers delegated by the European Commission ('European Commission'),

and mandates

the coordinator to submit and sign in its name and on its behalf any **amendments** to the Agreement, in accordance with Article 39.

By signing this accession form, the beneficiary accepts the grant and agrees to implement it in accordance with the Agreement, with all the obligations and terms and conditions it sets out.

SIGNATURE

For the beneficiary

ANNEX 3

ACCESSION FORM FOR BENEFICIARIES

TUSCAN ORGANISATION OF UNIVERSITIES AND RESEARCH 4 EUROPE (TOUR4EU),
PIC 903152742, established in ROND POINT ROBERT SCHUMAN 14, BRUXELLES 1040,
Belgium,

hereby agrees

to become beneficiary

in Agreement No 101292277 — SoBigData IP ('the Agreement')

between CONSIGLIO NAZIONALE DELLE RICERCHE (CNR) **and the European Research Executive Agency (REA)** ('EU executive agency' or 'granting authority'), under the powers delegated by the European Commission ('European Commission'),

and mandates

the coordinator to submit and sign in its name and on its behalf any **amendments** to the Agreement, in accordance with Article 39.

By signing this accession form, the beneficiary accepts the grant and agrees to implement it in accordance with the Agreement, with all the obligations and terms and conditions it sets out.

SIGNATURE

For the beneficiary

ANNEX 3

ACCESSION FORM FOR BENEFICIARIES

X-officio Research AB (X-officio), PIC 876844887, established in Klostergatan 8b, Lund 222 22, Sweden,

hereby agrees

to become beneficiary

in Agreement No 101292277 — SoBigData IP ('the Agreement')

between CONSIGLIO NAZIONALE DELLE RICERCHE (CNR) **and** the **European Research Executive Agency (REA)** ('EU executive agency' or 'granting authority'), under the powers delegated by the European Commission ('European Commission'),

and mandates

the coordinator to submit and sign in its name and on its behalf any **amendments** to the Agreement, in accordance with Article 39.

By signing this accession form, the beneficiary accepts the grant and agrees to implement it in accordance with the Agreement, with all the obligations and terms and conditions it sets out.

SIGNATURE

For the beneficiary

ANNEX 3

ACCESSION FORM FOR BENEFICIARIES

DEUTSCHES FORSCHUNGSZENTRUM FÜR KUNSTLICHE INTELLIGENZ GMBH (DFKI), PIC 999607602, established in TRIPPSTADTER STRASSE 122, KAISERSLAUTERN 67663, Germany,

hereby agrees

to become beneficiary

in Agreement No 101292277 — SoBigData IP ('the Agreement')

between CONSIGLIO NAZIONALE DELLE RICERCHE (CNR) **and** the **European Research Executive Agency (REA)** ('EU executive agency' or 'granting authority'), under the powers delegated by the European Commission ('European Commission'),

and mandates

the coordinator to submit and sign in its name and on its behalf any **amendments** to the Agreement, in accordance with Article 39.

By signing this accession form, the beneficiary accepts the grant and agrees to implement it in accordance with the Agreement, with all the obligations and terms and conditions it sets out.

SIGNATURE

For the beneficiary

ANNEX 4 XXX LUMP SUM MGA — MULTI & MONO

FINANCIAL STATEMENT FOR THE ACTION FOR REPORTING PERIOD [NUMBER]

	EU contribution											
	Eligible lump sum contributions (per work package)											Requested EU contribution
	WP1 [name]	WP2 [name]	WP3 [name]	WP4 [name]	WP5 [name]	WP6 [name]	WP7 [name]	WP8 [name]	WP9 [name]	WP10 [name]	WP [XX]	
	Forms of funding	[Lump sum contribution// Financing not linked to costs]	[Lump sum contribution// Financing not linked to costs]	[Lump sum contribution// Financing not linked to costs]	[Lump sum contribution// Financing not linked to costs]	[Lump sum contribution// Financing not linked to costs]	[Lump sum contribution// Financing not linked to costs]	[Lump sum contribution// Financing not linked to costs]	[Lump sum contribution// Financing not linked to costs]	[Lump sum contribution// Financing not linked to costs]	[Lump sum contribution// Financing not linked to costs]	
Status of completion	COMPLETED	COMPLETED	COMPLETED	COMPLETED	COMPLETED	COMPLETED	COMPLETED	PARTIALLY COMPLETED	PARTIALLY COMPLETED	COMPLETED	NOT COMPLETED	
	a	b	c	d	e	f	g	h	i	j	k	l = a + b+ c + d+ e+ f+ g+ h+ i+ j+ k
1 – [short name beneficiary]												
1.1 – [short name affiliated entity]												
2 – [short name beneficiary]												
2.1 – [short name affiliated entity]												
X – [short name associated partner]												
Total consortium												

The consortium hereby confirms that:

The information provided is complete, reliable and true.

The lump sum contributions declared are eligible (in particular, the work packages have been completed and the work has been properly implemented and/or the results were achieved; see Article 6).

The proper implementation of the action/achievement of the results can be substantiated by adequate records and supporting documentation that will be produced upon request or in the context of checks, reviews, audits and investigations (see Articles 19, 21 and 25).

ANNEX 5

SPECIFIC RULES

CONFIDENTIALITY AND SECURITY (— ARTICLE 13)

Sensitive information with security recommendation

Sensitive information with a security recommendation must comply with the additional requirements imposed by the granting authority.

Before starting the action tasks concerned, the beneficiaries must have obtained all approvals or other mandatory documents needed for implementing the task. The documents must be kept on file and be submitted upon request by the coordinator to the granting authority. If they are not in English, they must be submitted together with an English summary.

For requirements restricting disclosure or dissemination, the information must be handled in accordance with the recommendation and may be disclosed or disseminated only after written approval from the granting authority.

EU classified information

If EU classified information is used or generated by the action, it must be treated in accordance with the security classification guide (SCG) and security aspect letter (SAL) set out in Annex 1 and Decision 2015/444¹ and its implementing rules — until it is declassified.

Deliverables which contain EU classified information must be submitted according to special procedures agreed with the granting authority.

Action tasks involving EU classified information may be subcontracted only with prior explicit written approval from the granting authority and only to entities established in an EU Member State or in a non-EU country with a security of information agreement with the EU (or an administrative arrangement with the Commission).

EU classified information may not be disclosed to any third party (including participants involved in the action implementation) without prior explicit written approval from the granting authority.

ETHICS (— ARTICLE 14)

Ethics and research integrity

The beneficiaries must carry out the action in compliance with:

- ethical principles (including the highest standards of research integrity)

¹ Commission Decision 2015/444/EC, Euratom of 13 March 2015 on the security rules for protecting EU classified information (OJ L 72, 17.3.2015, p. 53).

and

- applicable EU, international and national law, including the EU Charter of Fundamental Rights and the European Convention for the Protection of Human Rights and Fundamental Freedoms and its Supplementary Protocols.

No funding can be granted, within or outside the EU, for activities that are prohibited in all Member States. No funding can be granted in a Member State for an activity which is forbidden in that Member State.

The beneficiaries must pay particular attention to the principle of proportionality, the right to privacy, the right to the protection of personal data, the right to the physical and mental integrity of persons, the right to non-discrimination, the need to ensure protection of the environment and high levels of human health protection.

The beneficiaries must ensure that the activities under the action have an exclusive focus on civil applications.

The beneficiaries must ensure that the activities under the action do not:

- aim at human cloning for reproductive purposes
- intend to modify the genetic heritage of human beings which could make such modifications heritable (with the exception of research relating to cancer treatment of the gonads, which may be financed)
- intend to create human embryos solely for the purpose of research or for the purpose of stem cell procurement, including by means of somatic cell nuclear transfer, or
- lead to the destruction of human embryos (for example, for obtaining stem cells).

Activities involving research on human embryos or human embryonic stem cells may be carried out only if:

- they are set out in Annex 1 or
- the coordinator has obtained explicit approval (in writing) from the granting authority.

In addition, the beneficiaries must respect the fundamental principle of research integrity — as set out in the European Code of Conduct for Research Integrity².

This implies compliance with the following principles:

- reliability in ensuring the quality of research reflected in the design, the methodology, the analysis and the use of resources
- honesty in developing, undertaking, reviewing, reporting and communicating research in a transparent, fair and unbiased way
- respect for colleagues, research participants, society, ecosystems, cultural heritage and the environment

² European Code of Conduct for Research Integrity of ALLEA (All European Academies).

- accountability for the research from idea to publication, for its management and organisation, for training, supervision and mentoring, and for its wider impacts

and means that beneficiaries must ensure that persons carrying out research tasks follow the good research practices including ensuring, where possible, openness, reproducibility and traceability and refrain from the research integrity violations described in the Code.

Activities raising ethical issues must comply with the additional requirements formulated by the ethics panels (including after checks, reviews or audits; see Article 25).

Before starting an action task raising ethical issues, the beneficiaries must have obtained all approvals or other mandatory documents needed for implementing the task, notably from any (national or local) ethics committee or other bodies such as data protection authorities.

The documents must be kept on file and be submitted upon request by the coordinator to the granting authority. If they are not in English, they must be submitted together with an English summary, which shows that the documents cover the action tasks in question and includes the conclusions of the committee or authority concerned (if any).

VALUES (— ARTICLE 14)

Gender mainstreaming

The beneficiaries must take all measures to promote equal opportunities between men and women in the implementation of the action and, where applicable, in line with the gender equality plan. They must aim, to the extent possible, for a gender balance at all levels of personnel assigned to the action, including at supervisory and managerial level.

INTELLECTUAL PROPERTY RIGHTS (IPR) — BACKGROUND AND RESULTS — ACCESS RIGHTS AND RIGHTS OF USE (— ARTICLE 16)

Definitions

Access rights — Rights to use results or background.

Dissemination — The public disclosure of the results by appropriate means, other than resulting from protecting or exploiting the results, including by scientific publications in any medium.

Exploit(ation) — The use of results in further research and innovation activities other than those covered by the action concerned, including among other things, commercial exploitation such as developing, creating, manufacturing and marketing a product or process, creating and providing a service, or in standardisation activities.

Fair and reasonable conditions — Appropriate conditions, including possible financial terms or royalty-free conditions, taking into account the specific circumstances of the request for access, for example the actual or potential value of the results or background to which access is requested and/or the scope, duration or other characteristics of the exploitation envisaged.

FAIR principles — ‘findability’, ‘accessibility’, ‘interoperability’ and ‘reusability’.

Open access — Online access to research outputs provided free of charge to the end-user.

Open science — An approach to the scientific process based on open cooperative work, tools and diffusing knowledge.

Research data management — The process within the research lifecycle that includes the organisation, storage, preservation, security, quality assurance, allocation of persistent identifiers (PIDs) and rules and procedures for sharing of data including licensing.

Research outputs — Results to which access can be given in the form of scientific publications, data or other engineered results and processes such as software, algorithms, protocols, models, workflows and electronic notebooks.

Scope of the obligations

For this section, references to ‘beneficiary’ or ‘beneficiaries’ do not include affiliated entities (if any).

Agreement on background — Background free from restrictions

The beneficiaries must identify in a written agreement the background as needed for implementing the action or for exploiting its results.

Where the call conditions restrict control due to strategic interests reasons, background that is subject to control or other restrictions by a country (or entity from a country) which is not one of the eligible countries or target countries set out in the call conditions and that impact the exploitation of the results (i.e. would make the exploitation of the results subject to control or restrictions) must not be used and must be explicitly excluded in the agreement on background — unless otherwise agreed with the granting authority.

Results free from restrictions

Where the call conditions restrict control due to strategic interests reasons, the beneficiaries must ensure that the results of the action are not subject to control or other restrictions by a country (or entity from a country) which is not one of the eligible countries or target countries set out in the call conditions — unless otherwise agreed with the granting authority.

Ownership of results

Results are owned by the beneficiaries that generate them.

However, two or more beneficiaries own results jointly if:

- they have jointly generated them and
- it is not possible to:
 - establish the respective contribution of each beneficiary, or
 - separate them for the purpose of applying for, obtaining or maintaining their protection.

The joint owners must agree — in writing — on the allocation and terms of exercise of their joint ownership (‘joint ownership agreement’), to ensure compliance with their obligations under this Agreement.

Unless otherwise agreed in the joint ownership agreement or consortium agreement, each joint owner may grant non-exclusive licences to third parties to exploit the jointly-owned results (without any right to sub-license), if the other joint owners are given:

- at least 45 days advance notice and
- fair and reasonable compensation.

The joint owners may agree — in writing — to apply another regime than joint ownership.

If third parties (including employees and other personnel) may claim rights to the results, the beneficiary concerned must ensure that those rights can be exercised in a manner compatible with its obligations under the Agreement.

The beneficiaries must indicate the owner(s) of the results (results ownership list) in the final periodic report.

Protection of results

Beneficiaries which have received funding under the grant must adequately protect their results — for an appropriate period and with appropriate territorial coverage — if protection is possible and justified, taking into account all relevant considerations, including the prospects for commercial exploitation, the legitimate interests of the other beneficiaries and any other legitimate interests.

Exploitation of results

Beneficiaries which have received funding under the grant must — up to four years after the end of the action (see Data Sheet, Point 1) — use their best efforts to exploit their results directly or to have them exploited indirectly by another entity, in particular through transfer or licensing.

If, despite a beneficiary's best efforts, the results are not exploited within one year after the end of the action, the beneficiaries must (unless otherwise agreed in writing with the granting authority) use the Horizon Results Platform to find interested parties to exploit the results.

If results are incorporated in a standard, the beneficiaries must (unless otherwise agreed with the granting authority or unless it is impossible) ask the standardisation body to include the funding statement (see Article 17) in (information related to) the standard.

Additional exploitation obligations

Where the call conditions impose additional exploitation obligations (including obligations linked to the restriction of participation or control due to strategic assets, interests, autonomy or security reasons), the beneficiaries must comply with them — up to four years after the end of the action (see Data Sheet, Point 1).

Where the call conditions impose additional exploitation obligations in case of a public emergency, the beneficiaries must (if requested by the granting authority) grant for a limited period of time specified in the request, non-exclusive licences — under fair and reasonable conditions — to their results to legal entities that need the results to address the public emergency and commit to rapidly and broadly exploit the resulting products and services at fair and reasonable conditions. This provision applies up to four years after the end of the action (see Data Sheet, Point 1).

Additional information obligation relating to standards

Where the call conditions impose additional information obligations relating to possible standardisation, the beneficiaries must — up to four years after the end of the action (see Data Sheet, Point 1) — inform the granting authority, if the results could reasonably be expected to contribute to European or international standards.

Transfer and licensing of results

Transfer of ownership

The beneficiaries may transfer ownership of their results, provided this does not affect compliance with their obligations under the Agreement.

The beneficiaries must ensure that their obligations under the Agreement regarding their results are passed on to the new owner and that this new owner has the obligation to pass them on in any subsequent transfer.

Moreover, they must inform the other beneficiaries with access rights of the transfer at least 45 days in advance (or less if agreed in writing), unless agreed otherwise in writing for specifically identified third parties including affiliated entities or unless impossible under the applicable law. This notification must include sufficient information on the new owner to enable the beneficiaries concerned to assess the effects on their access rights. The beneficiaries may object within 30 days of receiving notification (or less if agreed in writing), if they can show that the transfer would adversely affect their access rights. In this case, the transfer may not take place until agreement has been reached between the beneficiaries concerned.

Granting licences

The beneficiaries may grant licences to their results (or otherwise give the right to exploit them), including on an exclusive basis, provided this does not affect compliance with their obligations.

Exclusive licences for results may be granted only if all the other beneficiaries concerned have waived their access rights.

Granting authority right to object to transfers or licensing — Horizon Europe actions

Where the call conditions in Horizon Europe actions provide for the right to object to transfers or licensing, the granting authority may — up to four years after the end of the action (see Data Sheet, Point 1) — object to a transfer of ownership or the exclusive licensing of results, if:

- the beneficiaries which generated the results have received funding under the grant
- it is to a legal entity established in a non-EU country not associated with Horizon Europe, and
- the granting authority considers that the transfer or licence is not in line with EU interests.

Beneficiaries that intend to transfer ownership or grant an exclusive licence must formally notify the granting authority before the intended transfer or licensing takes place and:

- identify the specific results concerned
- describe in detail the new owner or licensee and the planned or potential exploitation of the results, and
- include a reasoned assessment of the likely impact of the transfer or licence on EU interests, in particular regarding competitiveness as well as consistency with ethical principles and security considerations.

The granting authority may request additional information.

If the granting authority decides to object to a transfer or exclusive licence, it must formally notify the beneficiary concerned within 60 days of receiving notification (or any additional information it has requested).

No transfer or licensing may take place in the following cases:

- pending the granting authority decision, within the period set out above
- if the granting authority objects
- until the conditions are complied with, if the granting authority objection comes with conditions.

A beneficiary may formally notify a request to waive the right to object regarding intended transfers or grants to a specifically identified third party, if measures safeguarding EU interests are in place. If the granting authority agrees, it will formally notify the beneficiary concerned within 60 days of receiving notification (or any additional information requested).

Granting authority right to object to transfers or licensing — Euratom actions

Where the call conditions in Euratom actions provide for the right to object to transfers or licensing, the granting authority may — up to four years after the end of the action (see Data Sheet, Point 1) — object to a transfer of ownership or the exclusive or non-exclusive licensing of results, if:

- the beneficiaries which generated the results have received funding under the grant
- it is to a legal entity established in a non-EU country not associated to the Euratom Research and Training Programme 2021-2025 and
- the granting authority considers that the transfer or licence is not in line with the EU interests.

Beneficiaries that intend to transfer ownership or grant a licence must formally notify the granting authority before the intended transfer or licensing takes place and:

- identify the specific results concerned
- describe in detail the results, the new owner or licensee and the planned or potential exploitation of the results, and
- include a reasoned assessment of the likely impact of the transfer or licence on EU interests, in particular regarding competitiveness as well as consistency with ethical principles and security considerations (including the defence interests of the EU Member States under Article 24 of the Euratom Treaty).

The granting authority may request additional information.

If the granting authority decides to object to a transfer or licence, it will formally notify the beneficiary concerned within 60 days of receiving notification (or any additional information requested).

No transfer or licensing may take place in the following cases:

- pending the granting authority decision, within the period set out above
- if the granting authority objects
- until the conditions are complied with, if the granting authority objection comes with conditions.

A beneficiary may formally notify a request to waive the right to object regarding intended transfers or grants to a specifically identified third party, if measures safeguarding EU interests are in place. If the granting authority agrees, it will formally notify the beneficiary concerned within 60 days of receiving notification (or any additional information requested).

Limitations to transfers and licensing due to strategic assets, interests, autonomy or security reasons of the EU and its Member States

Where the call conditions restrict participation or control due to strategic assets, interests, autonomy or security reasons, the beneficiaries may not transfer ownership of their results or grant licences to third parties which are established in countries which are not eligible countries or target countries set out in the call conditions (or, if applicable, are controlled by such countries or entities from such countries) — unless they have requested and received prior approval by the granting authority.

The request must:

- identify the specific results concerned
- describe in detail the new owner or licensee and the planned or potential exploitation of the results, and
- include a reasoned assessment of the likely impact of the transfer or license on the strategic assets, interests, autonomy or security of the EU and its Member States.

The granting authority may request additional information.

Access rights to results and background

Exercise of access rights — Waiving of access rights — No sub-licensing

Requests to exercise access rights and the waiver of access rights must be in writing.

Unless agreed otherwise in writing with the beneficiary granting access, access rights do not include the right to sub-license.

If a beneficiary is no longer involved in the action, this does not affect its obligations to grant access.

If a beneficiary defaults on its obligations, the beneficiaries may agree that that beneficiary no longer has access rights.

Access rights for implementing the action

The beneficiaries must grant each other access — on a royalty-free basis — to background needed to implement their own tasks under the action, unless the beneficiary that holds the background has — before acceding to the Agreement —:

- informed the other beneficiaries that access to its background is subject to restrictions, or
- agreed with the other beneficiaries that access would not be on a royalty-free basis.

The beneficiaries must grant each other access — on a royalty-free basis — to results needed for implementing their own tasks under the action.

Access rights for exploiting the results

The beneficiaries must grant each other access — under fair and reasonable conditions — to results needed for exploiting their results.

The beneficiaries must grant each other access — under fair and reasonable conditions — to background needed for exploiting their results, unless the beneficiary that holds the background has — before acceding to the Agreement — informed the other beneficiaries that access to its background is subject to restrictions.

Requests for access must be made — unless agreed otherwise in writing — up to one year after the end of the action (see Data Sheet, Point 1).

Access rights for entities under the same control

Unless agreed otherwise in writing by the beneficiaries, access to results and, subject to the restrictions referred to above (if any), background must also be granted — under fair and reasonable conditions — to entities that:

- are established in an EU Member State or Horizon Europe associated country
- are under the direct or indirect control of another beneficiary, or under the same direct or indirect control as that beneficiary, or directly or indirectly controlling that beneficiary and
- need the access to exploit the results of that beneficiary.

Unless agreed otherwise in writing, such requests for access must be made by the entity directly to the beneficiary concerned.

Requests for access must be made — unless agreed otherwise in writing — up to one year after the end of the action (see Data Sheet, Point 1).

Access rights for the granting authority, EU institutions, bodies, offices or agencies and national authorities to results for policy purposes — Horizon Europe actions

In Horizon Europe actions, the beneficiaries which have received funding under the grant must grant access to their results — on a royalty-free basis — to the granting authority, EU institutions, bodies, offices or agencies for developing, implementing and monitoring EU policies or programmes. Such access rights do not extend to beneficiaries' background.

Such access rights are limited to non-commercial and non-competitive use.

For actions under the cluster ‘Civil Security for Society’, such access rights also extend to national authorities of EU Member States for developing, implementing and monitoring their policies or programmes in this area. In this case, access is subject to a bilateral agreement to define specific conditions ensuring that:

- the access rights will be used only for the intended purpose and
- appropriate confidentiality obligations are in place.

Moreover, the requesting national authority or EU institution, body, office or agency (including the granting authority) must inform all other national authorities of such a request.

Access rights for the granting authority, Euratom institutions, funding bodies or the Joint Undertaking Fusion for Energy — Euratom actions

In Euratom actions, the beneficiaries which have received funding under the grant must grant access to their results — on a royalty-free basis — to the granting authority, Euratom institutions, funding bodies or the Joint Undertaking Fusion for Energy for developing, implementing and monitoring Euratom policies and programmes or for compliance with obligations assumed through international cooperation with non-EU countries and international organisations.

Such access rights include the right to authorise third parties to use the results in public procurement and the right to sub-license and are limited to non-commercial and non-competitive use.

Additional access rights

Where the call conditions impose additional access rights, the beneficiaries must comply with them.

COMMUNICATION, DISSEMINATION, OPEN SCIENCE AND VISIBILITY (— ARTICLE 17)

Dissemination

Dissemination of results

The beneficiaries must disseminate their results as soon as feasible, in a publicly available format, subject to any restrictions due to the protection of intellectual property, security rules or legitimate interests.

A beneficiary that intends to disseminate its results must give at least 15 days advance notice to the other beneficiaries (unless agreed otherwise), together with sufficient information on the results it will disseminate.

Any other beneficiary may object within (unless agreed otherwise) 15 days of receiving notification, if it can show that its legitimate interests in relation to the results or background would be significantly harmed. In such cases, the results may not be disseminated unless appropriate steps are taken to safeguard those interests.

Additional dissemination obligations

Where the call conditions impose additional dissemination obligations, the beneficiaries must also comply with those.

Open Science

Open science: open access to scientific publications

The beneficiaries must ensure open access to peer-reviewed scientific publications relating to their results. In particular, they must ensure that:

- at the latest at the time of publication, a machine-readable electronic copy of the published version or the final peer-reviewed manuscript accepted for publication, is deposited in a trusted repository for scientific publications
- immediate open access is provided to the deposited publication via the repository, under the latest available version of the Creative Commons Attribution International Public Licence (CC BY) or a licence with equivalent rights; for monographs and other long-text formats, the licence may exclude commercial uses and derivative works (e.g. CC BY-NC, CC BY-ND) and
- information is given via the repository about any research output or any other tools and instruments needed to validate the conclusions of the scientific publication.

Beneficiaries (or authors) must retain sufficient intellectual property rights to comply with the open access requirements.

Metadata of deposited publications must be open under a Creative Commons Public Domain Dedication (CC 0) or equivalent, in line with the FAIR principles (in particular machine-actionable) and provide information at least about the following: publication (author(s), title, date of publication, publication venue); Horizon Europe or Euratom funding; grant project name, acronym and number; licensing terms; persistent identifiers for the publication, the authors involved in the action and, if possible, for their organisations and the grant. Where applicable, the metadata must include persistent identifiers for any research output or any other tools and instruments needed to validate the conclusions of the publication.

Only publication fees in full open access venues for scientific publications are eligible for reimbursement.

Open science: research data management

The beneficiaries must manage the digital research data generated in the action ('data') responsibly, in line with the FAIR principles and by taking all of the following actions:

- establish a data management plan ('DMP') (and regularly update it)
- as soon as possible and within the deadlines set out in the DMP, deposit the data in a trusted repository; if required in the call conditions, this repository must be federated in the EOSC in compliance with EOSC requirements
- as soon as possible and within the deadlines set out in the DMP, ensure open access — via the repository — to the deposited data, under the latest available version of the Creative Commons Attribution International Public License (CC BY) or Creative Commons Public Domain Dedication (CC 0) or a licence/dedication with equivalent rights, following the principle 'as open as possible as closed as necessary', unless providing open access would in particular:
 - be against the beneficiary's legitimate interests, including regarding commercial exploitation, or

- be contrary to any other constraints, in particular the EU competitive interests or the beneficiary's obligations under this Agreement; if open access is not provided (to some or all data), this must be justified in the DMP
- provide information via the repository about any research output or any other tools and instruments needed to re-use or validate the data.

Metadata of deposited data must be open under a Creative Common Public Domain Dedication (CC 0) or equivalent (to the extent legitimate interests or constraints are safeguarded), in line with the FAIR principles (in particular machine-actionable) and provide information at least about the following: datasets (description, date of deposit, author(s) and embargo); Horizon Europe or Euratom funding; grant project name, acronym and number; licensing terms; persistent identifiers for the dataset, the authors involved in the action, and, if possible, for their organisations and the grant. Where applicable, the metadata must include persistent identifiers for related publications and other research outputs.

Open science: additional practices

Where the call conditions impose additional obligations regarding open science practices, the beneficiaries must also comply with those.

Where the call conditions impose additional obligations regarding the validation of scientific publications, the beneficiaries must provide (digital or physical) access to data or other results needed for validation of the conclusions of scientific publications, to the extent that their legitimate interests or constraints are safeguarded (and unless they already provided (open) access at publication).

Where the call conditions impose additional open science obligations in case of a public emergency, the beneficiaries must (if requested by the granting authority) immediately deposit any research output in a trusted repository and provide open access to it under a CC BY licence, a Public Domain Dedication (CC 0) or equivalent. As an exception, if the access would be against the beneficiaries' legitimate interests, the beneficiaries must grant non-exclusive licenses — under fair and reasonable conditions — to legal entities that need the research output to address the public emergency and commit to rapidly and broadly exploit the resulting products and services at fair and reasonable conditions. This provision applies up to four years after the end of the action (see Data Sheet, Point 1).

Plan for the exploitation and dissemination of results including communication activities

Unless excluded by the call conditions, the beneficiaries must provide and regularly update a plan for the exploitation and dissemination of results including communication activities.

SPECIFIC RULES FOR CARRYING OUT THE ACTION (— ARTICLE 18)

Implementation in case of restrictions due to strategic assets, interests, autonomy or security of the EU and its Member States

Where the call conditions restrict participation or control due to strategic assets, interests, autonomy or security, the beneficiaries must ensure that none of the entities that participate as affiliated entities, associated partners, third parties giving in-kind contributions, subcontractors or recipients of financial support to third parties are established in countries which are not eligible countries or target countries set out in the call conditions (or, if applicable, are controlled by such countries or entities from such countries) — unless otherwise agreed with the granting authority.

The beneficiaries must moreover ensure that any cooperation with entities established in countries which are not eligible countries or target countries set out in the call conditions (or, if applicable, are controlled by such countries or entities from such countries) does not affect the strategic assets, interests, autonomy or security of the EU and its Member States.

Recruitment and working conditions for researchers

The beneficiaries must take all measures to implement the principles set out in Annex II to the Council Recommendation on a European framework to attract and retain research, innovation and entrepreneurial talents in Europe³ ('the European Charter for Researchers'), in particular regarding:

- working conditions
- transparent recruitment processes based on merit, and
- career development.

The beneficiaries must ensure that researchers and all participants involved in the action are aware of them.

Specific rules for access to research infrastructure activities

Definitions

Research Infrastructures — Facilities that provide resources and services for the research communities to conduct research and foster innovation in their fields. This definition includes the associated human resources, and it covers major equipment or sets of instruments; knowledge-related facilities such as collections, archives or scientific data infrastructures; computing systems, communication networks, and any other infrastructure, of a unique nature and open to external users, essential to achieve excellence in research and innovation. Where relevant, they may be used beyond research, for example for education or public services, and they may be 'single-sited', 'virtual' or 'distributed'⁴:

When implementing access to research infrastructure activities, the beneficiaries must respect the following conditions:

- for transnational access:
 - access which must be provided:

The access must be free of charge, transnational access to research infrastructure or installations for selected user-groups.

The access must include the logistical, technological and scientific support and the specific training that is usually provided to external researchers using the

³ Council Recommendation C/2023/1640 of 18 December 2023 on a European framework to attract and retain research, innovation and entrepreneurial talents in Europe, Annex II (OJ C, C/2023/1640, 29.12.2023).

⁴ See Article 2(1) of the Horizon Europe Framework Programme Regulation 2021/695.

infrastructure. Transnational access can be either in person (hands-on), provided to selected users that visit the installation to make use of it, or remote, through the provision to selected user-groups of remote scientific services (e.g. provision of reference materials or samples, remote access to a high-performance computing facility).

- categories of users that may have access:

Transnational access must be provided to selected user-groups, i.e. teams of one or more researchers (users).

The majority of the users must work in a country other than the country(ies) where the installation is located (unless access is provided by an international organisation, the Joint Research Centre (JRC), an ERIC or similar legal entity).

Only user groups that are allowed to disseminate the results they have generated under the action may benefit from the access (unless the users are working for SMEs).

Access for user groups with a majority of users not working in a EU Member State or Horizon Europe associated country is limited to 20% of the total amount of units of access provided under the grant (unless a higher percentage is foreseen in Annex 1).

- procedure and criteria for selecting user groups:

The user groups must request access by submitting (in writing) a description of the work that they wish to carry out and the names, nationalities and home institutions of the users.

The user groups must be selected by (one or more) selection panels set up by the consortium.

The selection panels must be composed of international experts in the field, at least half of them independent from the consortium (unless otherwise specified in Annex 1).

The selection panels must assess all proposals received and recommend a short-list of the user groups that should benefit from access.

The selection panels must base their selection on scientific merit, taking into account that priority should be given to user groups composed of users who:

- have not previously used the installation and
- are working in countries where no equivalent research infrastructure exist.

It will apply the principles of transparency, fairness and impartiality.

Where the call conditions impose additional rules for the selection of user groups, the beneficiaries must also comply with those.

- other conditions:

The beneficiaries must request written approval from the granting authority for the selection of user groups requiring visits to the installations exceeding 3 months (unless such visits are foreseen in Annex 1).

In addition, the beneficiaries must:

- advertise widely, including on a their websites, the access offered under the Agreement
 - promote equal opportunities in advertising the access and take into account the gender dimension when defining the support provided to users
 - ensure that users comply with the terms and conditions of the Agreement
 - ensure that its obligations under Articles 12, 13, 17 and 33 also apply to the users
 - keep records of the names, nationalities, and home institutions of users, as well as the nature and quantity of access provided to them
- for virtual access:
- access which must be provided:

The access must be free of charge, virtual access to research infrastructure or installations.

‘Virtual access’ means open and free access through communication networks to digital resources and services needed for research, without selecting the users to whom access is provided.

The access must include the support that is usually provided to external users.

Where allowed by the call conditions, beneficiaries may in justified cases define objective eligibility criteria (e.g. affiliation to a research or academic institution) for specific users.

- other conditions:

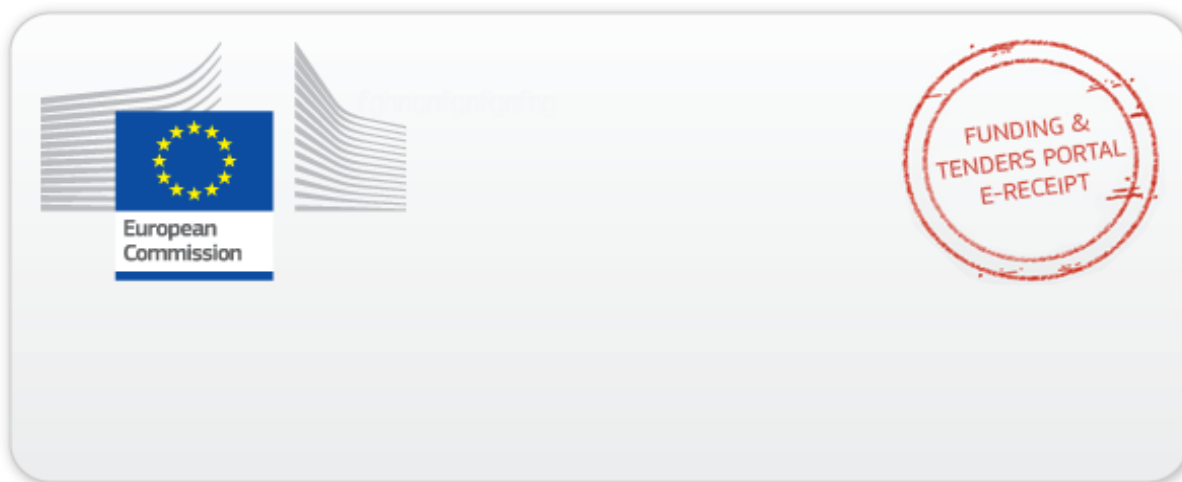
The beneficiaries must have the virtual access services assessed periodically by a board composed of international experts in the field, at least half of whom must be independent from the consortium (unless otherwise specified in Annex 1). For this purpose, information and statistics on the users and the nature and quantity of the access provided, must be made available to the board.

The beneficiaries must advertise widely, including on a dedicated website, the access offered under the grant and the eligibility criteria, if any.

Where the call conditions impose additional traceability⁵ obligations, information on the traceability of the users and the nature and quantity of access must be provided by the beneficiaries.

These obligations apply regardless of the form of funding or budget categories used to declare the costs (unit costs or actual costs or a combination of the two).

⁵ According to the definition given in ISO 9000, i.e.: “Traceability is the ability to trace the history, application, use and location of an item or its characteristics through recorded identification data.” The users can be traced, for example, by authentication and/or by authorization or by other means that allows for analysis of the type of users and the nature and quantity of access provided.



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